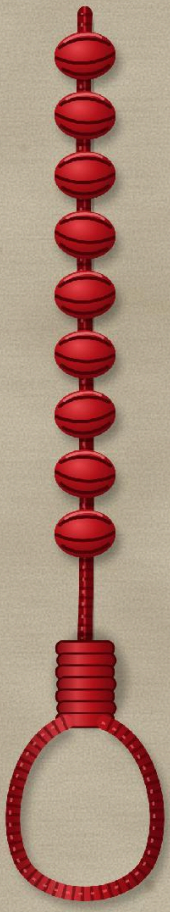
A NOVEL OF DHUWAKOT



THE HANGING LORD

SWAYAM SHAKYA

THE HANGING LORD

A Novel

A supernatural mystery thriller

SWAYAM SHAKYA

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, locations, incidents, and setting are used fictitiously, and purely based on the author's writing and imagination. The village of Dhuwakot and its customs, rites and beliefs do not exist. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, religion, organization, events or locales is entirely coincidental.

THE HANGING LORD
2026

“Do not look at the one who hangs.
What hangs, also watches.”

— saying of Dhuwakot

For the ones who love to read, imagine and explore,
and for the ones who dare to read after dark.

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CHAPTER ONE

The Village That Sleeps Before Sunset

On the eleventh night of Aswin, in the year 2049 of the Bikram calendar, with the great festival swing still hanging from the old pipal tree at the centre of Dhuwakot, a boy was born in the house of Karna Bahadur Gurung.

Dhanmaya the midwife would say, for what remained of her life, that the mist had come early that night. It rose out of the Kali Khola gorge before the cattle were tied, thick and the colour of boiled milk, and by the time the first pains began it had swallowed the terraces, the cowsheds, and the stone path to the school. In the birthing room the lamp burned with its flame bent toward the door, as if it wanted very badly to leave.

Outside, on the porch, Karna Bahadur sat with his elder son. Bishal was eight years old and stubborn in the way of firstborn boys, and he had refused to go to bed. The father held a full glass of warm rakshi he had stopped drinking hours ago. The boy held a slate and a stub of chalk, and by the light of a kerosene lamp he was practising the first letter of the alphabet, over and over, with his tongue caught between his teeth.

Dhanmaya could hear the scratch of the chalk through the wall. It was the last ordinary sound she would hear that night.

The child came a little after midnight, slick and furious, and cried. It was a good cry, a lusty one, the cry of a boy who meant to live. Dhanmaya laughed, wiped him down, and was reaching for the cloth to wrap him in when she realised that the scratching had stopped.

Not only the scratching. Everything had stopped. The crickets in the terraces went silent. The dogs, who lived in Dhuwakot, barked at the moon and at one another and at nothing at all. Even the river, which ran so loud in the gorge that the villagers had long ago stopped hearing it, was gone. A village is never silent; a village murmurs in its sleep. This was a silence like a held breath, and Dhanmaya, who had delivered ninety-one babies and buried four of them, felt the hair lift along her arms.

Then, from the courtyard, came a single sound. A long, slow creak, the sound of heavy rope taking a heavy weight.

She did not go out. She would never forgive herself for that, and she would tell anyone who asked that she had stayed because of the mother, because the afterbirth had not yet come, because a midwife does not leave. All of it was true. None of it was the reason. The reason was that she had understood, with the plain animal certainty that lives underneath learning, that whatever stood in the courtyard was not interested in her, and that her only chance of staying uninteresting was to be very still.

So she sat in the lamplight with the newborn on her chest and the mother weeping quietly beside her, and she listened to the rope creak until the grey of morning came through the shutters.

When at last she opened the door, the porch was empty.

The glass of rakshi stood full on the floorboards. The slate lay face-up beside it, the letter *ka* 'क' written forty times in a child's careful hand, the fortieth line trailing off the edge in a long white scrape, as though the hand that held the chalk had been pulled away mid-stroke. Karna Bahadur's black dhaka cap lay upside down on the step, and it was full of dew.

There were no footprints in the wet earth of the courtyard. There were no signs of a struggle. There was only the mist, standing among the houses like a crowd that had come to watch, and above it, in the pipal tree, the festival swing. Its thick rope was moving. Back and forth it went, slowly, though not a leaf stirred around it, and where the seat of the swing should have been, the loop of the rope was dark and wet, as though something had only just stepped out of it.

That was the first.

Over the next fourteen months it would happen eight more times, always on the night a son was born, always to the father and the eldest

boy of the house, and never, not once, to the women, who were left in the grey dawn with their newborns and a silence they would not describe. Dhuwakot would learn the pattern. It would also learn that there was nothing in the pattern that could be used.

And the swing would remain in the pipal tree, because no man in the village could be found who was willing to climb up and cut it down.

❦

Fourteen months later, on a Monday in the bitter first weeks of winter, Superintendent of Police Antim Karki stood in the district office at Bhanjyang Bazaar and read the Dhuwakot file for the third time. For the third time he arrived at the same page, and for the third time he could not bring himself to turn it.

It was a thin office for such a thick problem. A tin roof that ticked in the cold. A portrait of His Majesty King Birendra on the whitewashed wall, hanging very slightly crooked, which no one had dared to straighten because no one could agree which direction was crooked. A Remington typewriter whose letter '*e*' had long ago given up. A kerosene heater that smelled of a hundred winters and warmed only the six inches of air around itself.

The page was a list of eleven names.

Sub-Inspector Rajan Thapa, who had gone up first, with a notebook and two constables, and had sent down a message by runner from the last bazaar: *Going up now. Will report by Friday.* Inspector Bhim Bahadur Rai and four men, each with a Lee-Enfield rifle and a week of rations. Two plain-clothes detectives from Kathmandu who had believed, with the confidence of the capital, that a quiet approach would succeed where a loud one had failed. And finally Inspector Devendra Pandey, decorated, thirty years in uniform, who had looked at the list of those who had gone before him and decided that the trouble had been teamwork. He had gone alone.

Beneath every name, in the same blue ink, the same two words: *Whereabouts unknown.*

Eleven policemen. Nine fathers and nine sons from the village itself. Twenty-nine men and boys in fourteen months, from a place so small that it did not appear on the district map except as a smudge of green beneath a fold in the paper.

"You're doing it again," said a voice from the doorway. "Reading it as though the names will change."

Antim looked up. His wife stood in the cold draught of the open door with her cap under her arm and her breath smoking in the air, a slight woman in a heavy police-issue overcoat that had been cut for a larger man and taken in, badly, by the district tailor. Deputy Superintendent Aashi Karki had a narrow, watchful face and the kind of dark, patient eyes that make suspects start talking just to fill the silence. In nine years of marriage Antim had never once won a staring contest with her. He had stopped entering.

"The names are the same," he said. "It's the arithmetic that's getting worse."

"The Chief District Officer is on his way up. He's been on the telephone to Kathmandu since seven. I could hear him from the bottom of the stairs." She crossed to the heater, held her hands over it for a moment with an expression of profound disappointment, and then took the file from him. "He's going to ask us."

"I know."

"What are you going to say?"

"That we're a district of four hundred policemen, and that I've already sent eleven of them up a hill and had none of them back, and that I'm not in the habit of repeating mistakes." Antim ran a hand over his face. He was thirty-eight, broad through the shoulders, with a soldier's posture inherited from a father he did not often mention, and he looked, at that moment, like a man who had not slept properly since the monsoon. "That's what I'm going to say. And then he's going to say that there are no more men to send, and I'm going to agree, and then we'll both stand here looking at a portrait of the King."

"Hm," said Aashi, and her eyes dropped to the page and moved, fast and sure, down the column of names. He knew that look. It meant that she had noticed something and was deciding whether to say it.

Before she could, the stairs groaned, and Chief District Officer Hem Prasad Adhikari arrived like the weather.

He was a round, sweating man in a wool coat and a dhaka topi, with a face the colour of a boiled sweet, and he carried with him the unmistakable air of someone who has been shouted at by a more important person and is looking for a place to put it down. He did not

sit. He rarely did. He paced in the narrow space between the desk and the heater, wheezing, a handkerchief in his fist.

"The Home Ministry," he announced, "has asked me four times this week whether the Bhanjyang police force still has any policemen in it. *Four times*, Karki-ji. Once by letter, which I could forgive. Twice by telephone. And once, this morning, by the personal secretary of the Home Minister, who wished to know — I am quoting — whether the district was *being swallowed by a hill*." He flung the handkerchief at the heater. "The Gorkhapatra has run the story three times. The Samaj has run it twice with a drawing. A drawing! Of a *tree!* Now there are people in Kathmandu who think we have been conducting rituals up here. Tantric rituals. With *government vehicles*."

"Sir," said Antim.

"I need this closed, Karki-ji. I do not care how. Closed means somebody in the village talks, or somebody comes down from it, or someone shows me a body or a bribe or a bandit. I do not need the truth. I need an *answer*."

"Sir, the truth is usually the fastest answer."

"The truth," said the Chief District Officer, with sudden quiet, "is that eleven policemen have walked up that mountain and not one has come down. Do not tell me about the truth. Tell me who I can send."

There was a pause. The tin roof ticked. Somewhere below, in the bazaar, a vendor was calling out the price of oranges.

"Me," said Antim.

"Not you. You are the Superintendent of this district. If I lose you, there is nobody left to lose."

"Then both of us," said Aashi.

She had not raised her voice. She never did. But the room rearranged itself around the sentence. Antim turned to look at her, and the Chief District Officer stopped pacing.

"Both of you," he repeated, as though the words were in a language he had once studied.

"Sir, may I ask you something?" Aashi opened the file on the desk and turned it so he could see. "Of the eleven officers sent to Dhuwakot, how many were men?"

"Eleven. They were all —" He stopped.

"Eleven," Aashi said. "Of the twenty-nine people who have vanished in and around that village, how many were women?"

The Chief District Officer's mouth opened and closed.

"None, sir. Not one woman. Not one girl. Every wife in that village is still in her house, and every daughter. In fourteen months this thing has taken only men and boys, and left every woman and girl. And in fourteen months we have sent every man we could spare and not once sent anything else." She closed the file gently. "I'm not saying I know what it means. I'm saying we've asked the same question eleven times in the same voice and received the same answer. I would like to try asking in a different way."

"It's superstition, Aashi," Antim said quietly.

She turned.

"I'm not dismissing your point." He kept his tone level. This was an old argument between them, worn smooth as a river stone, and they both knew the shape of it. "Your pattern is real. I won't argue the pattern. But a pattern is a thing people leave behind, not a thing that leaves people. Twenty-nine men missing from a hill village? There are a dozen explanations that don't need a ghost. The coal pits across the border. The construction gangs in Bombay and Calcutta. Moneylenders who sell debts to labour contractors. Someone is moving men south in the dark, and the poor devils who watched their husbands and sons disappear have no way to say so, because the man doing it is the man who owns their land. And the mist and the rope and the whispering are the village's way of explaining the thing it's too frightening to name." He spread his hands. "Superstition is a locked door, Chief Sahib. People hide crimes behind it. Behind that door there is a man, and the man has an account book."

"And the eleven policemen?" said the Chief District Officer.

"Walked into something with money behind it, and were made to disappear by people who knew the country better than they did."

"And the fact that the families left everything where it stood?" said Aashi. "The slate? The full glass? People who are taken by contractors take their boots, Antim. People who run away take their goats."

None of them spoke. The heater ticked.

"Sir, here is the thing," said Aashi, and she turned back to the Chief District Officer, and her voice softened a little, because she was going to ask for something. "If Antim is right, and there is a man with an accounts book up there, then he has been watching the road for fourteen months. He knows what a policeman looks like. He knows how a

policeman walks. He has seen eleven of them, and each one carried the same face. A lone man in uniform is a threat to him. But a man and his wife on a tiresome journey to see some relatives? Who's going to look twice?"

"And if Karki-ji is wrong," said the Chief District Officer slowly. "If it's not a man with an account book."

"Then we will have sent the one thing the village has never lost," said Aashi, "up the one road that has never let it back."

The silence that followed had weight. Antim could feel it settle on his shoulders like snow. He wanted to say, *It is a terrible argument*, and he could not, because it was not terrible. It was only that he would have been much happier if it had been.

"You would be the first married pair in the history of the force to be assigned to the same operation," the Chief District Officer said at last, heavily. "There are regulations."

"There are regulations about a great many things, sir," said Aashi. "I don't believe the Home Ministry has written one about this."

The Chief District Officer looked at her for longer than she thoughtt. Then he looked at Antim. Then he looked, in what was clearly a final act of despair, at the crooked portrait of the King, as though the King might have an opinion.

"Plain clothes," he said. "You go as civilians. You take the minimum, and you do not carry the wireless set up the hill — it's the first thing they'll see. You take the Land Rover as far as the road allows, and a driver, and the driver stays with the vehicle. I want a report by Friday, by whatever means you can send it." He pulled a fresh handkerchief from his coat and wiped his forehead. "Karki-ji, if you do not come back, I will be forced to explain it to your mother."

"Then, sir," said Antim, with a dry half-smile, "I would strongly advise that we come back."

❦

By the time they reached the police quarters it was dark and bitterly cold, and the whole of Bhanjyang Bazaar already knew.

This was not surprising. It was the nature of Bhanjyang that a thing said at the district office at ten in the morning would be told in the tea-shop by noon, embroidered by the tailor's wife by three, and arrive

at the Karkis' own front gate by dusk in a form so altered that Antim and Aashi barely recognised it. By the time Aama met them at the door, the story was that the Superintendent and his wife had been *ordered* up the mountain as punishment for some crime; that the Superintendent had *refused* and been struck by the Chief District Officer; and that a certain jyotishi in the next valley had already cast their horoscopes and been unable to finish.

"Dhuwakot," said Antim's mother, from the doorway, as if the word itself were a small bad smell. "*Dhuwakot*? And nobody thought to ask me."

She was an old woman of sixty-three with a face like a walnut and a voice that had been used to command a household of seven through three famines and a general strike. She wore a mustard-coloured shawl, and in her left hand she held a wooden ladle, which she did not appear to know she was holding. She had been, Antim saw, crying, and was furious about it.

"Aama —"

"Don't *Aama* me. Your father went into the hills. *Your father.* A Subedar in the army, a man who had been shot at in three countries, and what happened to him? A *bridge*." She brandished the ladle. "A bridge! And now you are going to a village where *eleven* policemen — eleven! — have gone up to look at a tree. A tree, Antim!"

"It isn't about the tree, Aama."

"Everything is about a tree. Come in. Eat. You will both eat, because I will not have my son walk into the mountains on a bowl of the district's tea."

It was no use arguing. They ate. Aama had made dal-bhat with ghee, and a potato curry with timur pepper, and the bitter greens that she insisted were medicine, and a sharp tomato achar that made Aashi's eyes stream, and the whole of it was hot and generous and unbearable in the way of a mother's cooking before a departure. Antim ate quickly, without noticing. Aashi ate very little, and Aama, who noticed everything, put a second spoonful of rice on her plate without comment and watched until she had finished it.

Afterwards, when the plates were cleared, the old woman went into her room and came back with two things in her hands.

The first was a bundle of red thread. She tied a length around Antim's left wrist, and a length around Aashi's right, muttering under

her breath, her fingers quick and hard. The second was a twist of paper, folded small, which she pressed into Aashi's palm and closed her fingers over.

"Rice and ash," she said. "Under the pillow. If the night is long."

"Aama, that's —"

"I did not ask what it is. I am telling you where it goes." She looked at her daughter-in-law for a moment longer than was necessary, and something moved in her walnut face, something very old and very knowing. Then she patted Aashi's hand, twice, brusquely, as one pats a loaf to see if it is done. "A husband and a wife go up together, and they come down together. If it ever comes to a choice, you do not choose. You understand? You do not *separate*."

"Yes, Aama."

"Good." She turned away, and picked up the ladle again, and attacked a pot that did not need attacking.

Later, in the narrow bedroom, with the kerosene lamp turned down and the cold pressing against the window, Antim lay on his back and stared at the ceiling. A single beam crossed it, a thick old beam of sal wood, and from it, at some forgotten time, someone had hung a hook for a lantern. He looked at the hook. He did not like hooks, or beams, or anything that could carry a rope. It was a small thing, a private thing; he had never told his wife the reason, though she had guessed it, as she guessed most things. He had been twelve, standing on the bank of the Trishuli on a bright morning, when the old rope bridge that his father was crossing had parted like a cheap thread. He remembered the sound more than the sight. A long, singing crack. Then nothing.

"You're quiet," said Aashi, beside him.

"I'm thinking."

"You're thinking about the bridge."

He turned his head. She lay on her side, watching him, her hair loose on the pillow, and in the low light of the lamp she looked younger than she was, and very tired.

"I'm thinking you're right about the pattern," he said. "That's what I can't forgive. I've been looking for the flaw in it for an hour and there isn't one. Twenty-nine men and not one woman. It doesn't feel like contractors. It feels like —" He stopped.

"Like what?"

"Like *appetite*," Antim said, and was ashamed of the word as soon as it was out.

She did not mock him. She reached out and laid her hand against his chest, and left it there, and they lay in silence for a while, listening to the old house breathe.

"Antim," she said eventually.

"Hm?"

For a moment he thought she would say it. He felt her draw breath. Her hand tightened a little on his shirt, and he waited, and the lamp hissed, and somewhere in the bazaar a dog barked once and was still.

"Nothing," Aashi said. "Sleep. We leave before light."

He slept; he was a man who could sleep, a skill of the army and of a responsible son, and common in men, especially fathers. She did not. When his breathing had lengthened she rose carefully, wrapped herself in her shawl, and went to the window, and stood looking north to where the hills rose black against a starless sky, row behind row, like a congregation of hooded men.

In the pocket of her overcoat, folded into the shape of a small hard square, was a note on the stationery of Dr. Mahat, the district physician, written in a hand she could barely read and a language she could not stop reading. It was dated three days ago. She had told nobody. She knew exactly what Antim would do if she told him: he would be kind, and he would be afraid, and he would find some reason, a perfectly good reason, to leave her at the district office with the telephone and the portrait of the King.

And she would let him. That was what frightened her. She would let him, because she wanted to.

She pressed her palm against her stomach, flat and careful, the way a person shields a lamp from the wind. Then she went back to bed, and lay beside her husband with her eyes open, and did not sleep at all.

❦

They left on Tuesday, in the blue hour before dawn, in the only Land Rover the district owned.

It was an ancient vehicle, older than most of the constables who drove it, with a canvas roof patched in four colours and a gearbox that had to be coaxed like a nervous horse. The men of Bhanjyang called it

Budhi, the old woman, and swore by it with the grudging loyalty one gives to a relative who has outlived everyone's expectations. The driver was Hawaldar Tika Ram Magar, a quiet, thick-wristed man of forty with a moustache like a brush, who had been told only that he was to take two people in civilian clothes as far as the Kali Khola bridge and wait. He had asked no questions. In the Nepal Police, the men who asked no questions lived longest.

Antim sat in the front, in a brown wool jacket and a grey muffler, with a canvas rucksack between his boots. His service revolver was in the small of his back, under the jacket, where it chafed. Aashi sat behind him in a plain cotton sari and a shawl, a tourist's camera hung around her neck for appearance's sake, and a small leather bag in her lap that held her notebook, a torch, a flask, and the folded note she had not shown anyone.

The road out of Bhanjyang was the kind that exists only because a government once drew it on a map. It climbed in switchbacks along the shoulder of the hill, a single lane of rutted red mud with a wall of rock on one side and, on the other, a drop of six hundred feet into a river that sounded, from this height, like a distant crowd applauding. Twice they stopped to haul stones off the track where the night's rain had brought down the hillside. Once they waited while a herd of black goats poured across the road, driven by a small boy in a woollen cap who looked at the Land Rover, and then at the people inside it, and then, quite deliberately, away.

By nine, the sun was out, hard and clean, and the valley below laid spread in terraces of green and gold, with smoke rising from a hundred cooking-fires in a hundred homes, and the Himalaya hanging in the north like a row of white sails. By eleven the road had begun to climb into the cloud-line, and the colours of the world began to go.

It happened gradually, the way a photograph fades. First the gold went out of the terraces, then the green out of the pines. The air grew wet and heavy and smelled of moss. The mist came down in strands, then in sheets, then in a single grey wall that closed behind them as they drove through it, so that Antim, looking back, could no longer see the road they had come by.

"It's thicker than I expected," said Hawaldar Tika Ram, speaking for the first time in three hours.

"Is it always like this?"

"Around the bridge, sahib. They say it comes up from the river." He shifted down a gear. "They say a lot of things."

Aashi leaned forward between the seats. "What do they say?"

The Hawaldar was silent for a long moment, his hands steady on the wheel. "That it's not a mist," he said. "That it's a kind of breathing. That the village doesn't breathe in the night, so something else does it for them."

"And what do you say?"

"I say I drive, memsahib," said Tika Ram, and that was all.

At twenty minutes to two they reached the Kali Khola.

The bridge was a long iron girder bridge from the days of the Rana prime ministers, painted once in a colour that might have been green, now eaten to the bones by rust and rain. Beyond it the road went on, narrower, into a tunnel of dripping rhododendron, and then simply disappeared into the cloud. The river ran below, loud and brown. Tied to every rail of the bridge, so thickly that the iron seemed to wear them, were strips of cloth: red, mostly, faded to pink, and among them here and there a frayed length of rope, knotted, with something small and dark tied into the knot.

"Offerings," said Antim, to nobody.

"Or warnings," said Aashi, quietly.

Tika Ram slowed to a crawl and drove onto the bridge. The old planks drummed under the wheels. They were halfway across when the engine coughed.

It was a polite cough, a little clearing of the throat, and for an instant Antim thought nothing of it. Then it coughed again, and the Land Rover shuddered and slowed, and slowed further, and rolled forward on the last of its momentum to the far end of the bridge, where it stopped. The engine died. The silence that came after was enormous.

"Starter," said Tika Ram, with the confidence of a man who is already worried. He turned the key. Nothing. He turned it again. Nothing, not even the click of a dying battery, only a flat, dead absence, as though the vehicle had never had an engine at all. "It's the damp, sahib. It's the old girl's throat. Give me ten minutes."

He climbed out and lifted the bonnet. Antim got out on the other side and stood in the road, listening to the river.

The thing he would remember afterward was how *wrong* the air felt. Not cold, precisely; he had been colder. It was the stillness. The

mist hung without a trace of movement, not a thread of it stirring, as though the whole world had been set in glass, and under the roar of the Kali Khola he found himself listening for something he could not name. There were no birds. He realised it only now. On the whole road since dawn, even at the height of the sun, he had not heard a single bird.

"Antim."

Aashi had climbed down on the bridge side and was standing a few paces away with her hand to her nose. "Do you smell that?"

He did. It had been there for a minute, faint, sweet, and underlying: wet rope and old incense, and beneath them something else, something that made his stomach turn without his knowing why. Marigolds, he thought. Marigolds left a week in a closed room.

"The river," he said, without conviction.

"The river doesn't smell of flowers."

He looked at his watch, out of habit. The second hand was not moving. It stood at nineteen minutes to two and did not stir, and when he held it to his ear there was no sound at all. He turned his wrist and showed her. Without a word she looked at her own. The small gold watch her mother had given her on the day she passed her police examination had stopped at exactly the same minute.

"Nineteen minutes to two," Aashi said, very softly. "The minute the engine died."

"It's that damn damp. Cheap mechanisms —"

"Antim."

He fell silent. From the pocket of his jacket he took the small brass compass he had carried since his army days, and flipped open the lid, and watched the needle. It did not point north. It did not point anywhere. It turned, slowly, in a long, searching circle, like a hand feeling in the dark for a doorknob, and then — he blinked — settled, trembling, in a single direction. Not north. It pointed up the road, into the cloud, toward Dhuwakot.

"Sahib," said Hawaldar Tika Ram, from under the bonnet, in a voice that had lost its steadiness. "Sahib, there's nothing wrong with her."

"What do you mean?"

"The plugs are dry. The fuel's clean. The wires are —" He straightened up. His face had gone the colour of putty. "There's nothing wrong with her, Sahib. She has simply decided."

Antim went around to the back of the vehicle and unclipped the wireless set. It was a heavy khaki box with a stubby antenna and a handset on a coiled cord, the kind that had been new when the Chinese built the Araniko Highway. He turned the dial. He pressed the switch. "Bhanjyang, Bhanjyang, this is Karki. Bhanjyang, do you read me?" Nothing. Not static, not the hiss of an empty channel. Silence, absolute and listening. He tried again, and a third time, with the hair rising on his neck, and then he put the handset down very carefully, as one puts down a thing that might wake.

"Hawaldar."

"Sahib."

"You will stay with the vehicle. You will keep the doors locked, and the rifle across your knees. If a mechanic comes, take him. If nobody comes by four o'clock, you walk back down to the last village and telephone Bhanjyang. Do not stay here after dusk. Is that understood?"

"Yes, sahib."

"I mean it, Tika Ram. Not after dusk."

"Sahib," said Tika Ram Magar, and tried to smile, but did not succeed. "I have been in the force twenty-two years. I know what a man who says *do not stay after dusk* is afraid of."

Aashi put a hand on his arm. "Tika Ram-ji, we'll be back by Friday. You have our word."

"Yes, memsahib." The Hawaldar nodded, once, twice. "I'll keep the old girl warm for you."

There was only one way to go on, and it was not on four wheels. The bus to the end of the road, the one that served the farms above the gorge, was due at the Kali Khola at half past two: it came up from the plains once a day, and turned back down before dark, and it was the only public transport that reached within two hours' walk of Dhuwakot. Antim shouldered the rucksack. Aashi adjusted her shawl, took her bag, and did not look back at the Land Rover, or at the bridge, or at the long gallery of faded red cloth fluttering without wind from its rails.

When she did glance back, a few moments later, the Hawaldar was already sitting in the cab with the doors locked, his rifle across his knees, his face a white smudge behind the glass, staring straight ahead.

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The bus arrived ten minutes to three, twenty minutes late, and it arrived like a man who has been running.

It was an old Tata, a rattling blue-and-yellow thing with eyes painted on either side of its radiator and a slogan across the front glass in red Devanagari: *Mother's Blessing*. Its roof was piled high with sacks of rice, bundles of firewood, a bicycle, and two crates of live chickens that screamed at the world in unison. Passengers clung to the ladder at the back. A thin boy in a cap hung from the door by one hand, shouting a list of villages in a voice already hoarse: "Jyamire, Jyamire, last bus, last bus!" He looked at Antim and Aashi standing in the road, and did not slow, and for a second Antim thought he meant to drive past.

Then the brakes shrieked, and the bus lurched to a stop, and the boy dropped down and said, in a tone of weary resignation, "Two? Up?"

"Up," said Antim. "As far as it goes."

"It goes to Jyamire, sahib. Then it turns back. We turn back before dark; that is the rule." The boy was perhaps sixteen, with a sharp, tired face. "Are you going to Jyamire for the night?"

"Further," said Aashi.

The boy's face did a strange thing. It did not close, exactly. It emptied. "Further than Jyamire," he said, "there is nothing, didi, but the Dhuwakot path."

"Then that is where we are going."

The boy looked at her, and for the first time at her stomach, though there was nothing to see beneath the folds of the shawl, and then up again quickly at her face. He swallowed. He said nothing. He put out a hand and helped her up the steps, and he did not take the fare.

Inside, the bus was warm and crowded and smelled of kerosene, wet wool, onions, and the sweet smoke of cheap tobacco. The seats were wooden benches. To the other passengers, Antim noted with some satisfaction, they were nothing at all: a schoolmaster in a brown jacket and his wife in a cotton sari, going up to visit a relative. The uniforms, the caps and the brass badges lay folded at the bottom of the rucksack, and their identity cards were sewn into its lining. Antim and Aashi found a place near the back, wedged against a sack of millet, and for a time they simply rode, being flung against each other at every bend. Someone's transistor radio was playing Narayan Gopal's *Swarga Ki Rani* through a crackle of static, the great, sad, honeyed voice

swimming in and out of the engine's roar, and a man in the next seat was humming along with his eyes closed. It was so ordinary, so entirely and solidly *Nepali*, the smell and the noise and the elbows, that for twenty minutes Antim almost forgot the dead watch on his wrist and the needle that had pointed up the road.

Then he began to notice who was *not* talking.

At first there had been talk, plenty of it, the happy, argumentative chatter of a hill bus: the price of rice, the new school at Bhanjyang, whose daughter had been married to whom. But as the road climbed and the cloud thickened, the voices went down, one by one, like lamps being put out. The man humming stopped. A woman in the front who had been scolding a child fell silent mid-sentence. By the time the bus entered the long forest of pine above the gorge, there was no sound in it but the engine and the chickens, and the passengers were sitting very straight, with their eyes on the windows, looking at nothing, as people sit in a hospital corridor.

A woman had been watching Aashi for some time.

She sat across the aisle, on the end of a bench: a very old woman in a faded purple sari and a woollen shawl, with a conical doko basket at her feet and a face so deeply creased that it looked like folded cloth. Her eyes, though, were bright and black and entirely clear. She had looked at Aashi when she boarded. She had looked again when the bus lurched. Now she leaned across the aisle, and with a hand like a bundle of twigs she took Aashi's wrist.

"Daughter," she said. Her voice was a dry whisper. "You are going up."

"Yes, Aama."

"With him?" A tilt of the head toward Antim. "Your husband?"

"Yes."

"Good. That is good." The old woman's grip tightened. "Chori, listen. You will reach it at the lamp-lighting hour or after it. The bus will not wait. Nobody will wait. When you come to the village, you do not go to the houses. You do not knock. You stand still, in the road, where the light can see you, and you let *him* find you."

"Who?"

"The one who finds." The old woman said it with great patience, as if it were self-evident. Then she reached into the fold of her shawl, and took out a small tin box, and opened it. It held a pinch of grey-white

ash. She pressed her thumb into it, and before Aashi could pull back she marked her forehead, a short firm streak between the eyebrows, and then, after the smallest hesitation, touched the same thumb lightly against the front of her shawl, over her stomach.

Aashi went rigid.

"Aama," Antim began.

"It is for the road," said the old woman, without looking at him. She withdrew her hand and closed the tin and sat back on her bench, composed, a small purple statue. When she spoke again it was so low that only Aashi, leaning close, could catch it.

"What you carry, daughter, is a sweet thing," she whispered, "and it is the one thing in that valley the Lord has not yet been given. You hide it. You hide it well. You do not tell it its own name until the sun is back."

Then she turned her face to the window and said nothing more, and not all of Antim's questions, nor the very gentle ones from Aashi, could bring her to speak again.

Aashi sat with the ash cold on her forehead and her hand locked in her husband's, and did not look at him. He was looking at her. He did not say a word. But she could feel it in the grip of his fingers, in the stillness of his whole body: the question, enormous and unasked, and the dawning of something he was not yet ready to believe.

The bus climbed. The road narrowed. Twice it stopped, once for a rockfall that the conductor and four passengers cleared in sullen silence, and once for nothing at all, for a long and airless minute in the middle of the pines, with the engine idling and every face turned toward the trees. Then it went on, faster now, the driver hunched over the wheel, and the shadows lengthened across the road and began to pool in the hollows.

It was ten minutes past five when the bus finally lurched out of the forest into a bare, windy clearing and stopped. A tea-stall, shuttered. A water-tap. A single stone shrine, no bigger than a dog-kennel, from which something glinted, and a trail that started at the shrine and went up and up and up into the cloud.

"Jyamire," said the conductor-boy, in a voice that cracked. "Last stop. Everybody down. Everybody down *now*."

There was no argument. The passengers poured out of the bus like water from a broken jar, hauling their sacks and their children and their

chickens, and they did not stand about to talk or stretch their legs. They scattered, in all directions, at a half-run, with their heads down, along paths that ran to little huts clustered at the edges of the clearing. Doors slammed. Bars dropped. Within three minutes the clearing was empty of everyone but the two police officers and the old woman in the purple sari, who got down last, took up her basket, and walked away down a side path without once looking back.

The conductor-boy was already swinging up the steps. “Two hours,” he called back, over the thunder of the starting engine, “two hours up that path, didi, sahib, I swear it, and you will be in the dark before you are halfway. Stay in Jyamire. Stay with someone. There is a man who rents a room, tell him —”

“We’re going up,” Antim said.

The boy stared at him. For a moment he seemed about to say something that mattered, something which crowded behind his teeth and could not get out. Then the driver leaned on the horn. The bus lurched forward, and the boy jumped onto the step, and clung there, looking back at them with wide eyes as the vehicle ground into a clumsy turn at the edge of the clearing and went roaring back down into the trees as though the road behind it were on fire.

Its taillights lingered in the cloud for a few seconds. Then there was only the wind.

Antim looked at his wife. She looked at the trail.

“Well,” she said, “Chief Sahib did say he wanted a report by Friday.”

He did not laugh. But something in his shoulders eased, and he reached over, quite slowly, and with the corner of his muffler wiped the ash from her forehead. She caught his hand before he finished.

“Leave it,” she said. “Please.”

He looked at the grey smear on her skin, and at her eyes, and at the old woman’s thumbprint, which was already half-gone. “You are going to tell me,” he said, “what she meant.”

“On the way up,” said Aashi. “I promise.”

Above them, in the clouds, the last of the day was bleeding out of the sky.

She told him on the path.

They walked in the last of the light, single file, Antim in front with the rucksack, the trail climbing in a long diagonal through stands of

pine and rhododendron whose trunks stood out of the mist like the legs of enormous animals. The ground was soft with needles and the cold bit through the soles of their boots. Neither of them had spoken for a quarter of an hour. Then Aashi said, behind him, “Seven weeks,” and he stopped walking.

He did not turn around at once. He stood for a moment with his back to her and his hand on the strap of the rucksack, and she watched his shoulders rise and fall.

“Dr. Mahat confirmed it on Friday,” she said. “I wanted to tell you at home. I tried to tell you last night. I was afraid you would put me behind a desk.”

“I would have,” said Antim, hoarsely.

“I know.”

“I would have put you on a bus and chained you to the Chief Sahib’s chair.” He turned. In the dusk his face was strange to her, stripped of its habitual composure. “Aashi, we are going up a mountain after eleven policemen who didn’t come back, and you are — and an old woman on a bus *knew* — how did she *know*?”

“I don’t know.”

“We are going back.”

“Antim.”

“We are going back down tonight, to Jyamire, and I will find that man who rents rooms, and in the morning —”

“And in the morning what? Take the next bus down and tell the Chief Sahib that we couldn’t do it because I am pregnant?” Her voice shook, and she steadied it. “He will send someone else. He will send a man, and the man will vanish, and the thing will have twelve. Or he will send nobody, and in a month there will be another baby in that village and another father and another son. You know that. You said it yourself, in the office. A pattern is a thing people leave behind.” She drew a breath. “I don’t think this is a thing we can leave behind. And I don’t think it’s a thing we can send other people to.”

“That is a very good argument,” said Antim, “and I hate it.”

“I know you do.”

“I hate it very much.”

“I know.” She came up the path and put her hands on his face, her gloves cold against his jaw. “I’m seven weeks, Antim. Not seven months. I can walk. I can think. I can shoot straighter than you, which

is the thing that has bothered you since our wedding day. And if the old woman is right, whatever is in that valley doesn't know yet. I'd rather *it* never learned."

He stood very still. Then, slowly, as if lifting something heavy, he put his arms around her and held her, and she felt him shake, once, and then go still.

"You do not leave my sight," he said into her hair.

"I won't."

"Not for a minute. Not for a breath. Aama said it. We go up together and we come down together."

"Together," Aashi agreed.

Higher up, as the trail steepened, Antim's practical mind rose back to the surface like a stubborn cork. "Hear me," he said, without looking round, in the low firm voice of a man making a formal statement. "Whatever the old woman knows, whatever the villagers whisper, I will tell you what I believe. There is no lord in that valley. There is a man. A thug, a smuggler, a moneylender with a gang, I don't care what you call him. He has a story, and the story does his work for him better than a rifle could. The mist, the rope, the red cloth on the bridge: stage-dressing."

"And the watches?"

"Damp."

"Both of them?"

"Cheap mechanisms." He shifted the rucksack. "I am not saying we shouldn't be careful. I am saying that whatever is coming for us has hands and a purse."

She did not argue. It was one of the kindest things she could have done, and he did not notice that she had done it.

They went on. Neither of them noticed that the wind had stopped.

❦

They came into Dhuwakot a little after seven, in a darkness so complete that the torch seemed less a light than a rumour of one.

It had begun to fail an hour earlier, the beam turning yellow, then orange, then a sullen brown, and now it lit no more than a single pace of path ahead of Antim's boots. The mist lay on the hillside like wet wool. The path levelled, and widened, and the pines fell away on either

side, and in front of them, looming out of the gloom, stood a gateway of rough grey stone, low and crooked, with an iron bell hanging from its lintel and, beside the bell, an empty iron hook, such as a lantern might once have hung from. The bell was green with age. It did not swing. As they passed beneath it, Aashi felt a drop of something cold strike the back of her neck, and when she touched it, it was only water.

On the far side was the village.

It was a poor, steep place, a scatter of low stone-and-mud houses with slate roofs, built in terraces up the slope and linked by stairs of fitted rock. There was a school, a cattle-pen, a long communal tap with a trough. A small whitewashed temple stood at the centre of the largest terrace. Any other hill village in Nepal, at that hour, would have been warm with sound and smoke: the bark of dogs, the clank of brass pots, the coughing laughter of men by the cooking-fires, a radio, a baby, a mother calling a child to bed.

Dhuwakot made no sound at all.

There was not a single light. Not a lamp in a window, not a fire in a doorway, not even the dull red wink of a hearth through a crack in a shutter. The doors were shut, every one, and each of them was barred, Antim could see, with a heavy wooden beam. The windows were boarded over from within. Along the sills of the houses, pinned there by small stones, lay thin lines of something pale, which he took at first for frost.

"No smoke," Aashi whispered.

She was right. In the cold, clear stillness, not a single chimney breathed. A village of two hundred souls had gone to ground with its hearths cold, as though it had decided that even the *warmth* of a fire might be seen.

They walked slowly up the central stair. Their boots were terribly loud. At each house Antim paused and looked at the doors and tried to imagine the people behind them: the men sitting rigid with their backs against the barred doors, the women in the dark, the children held very quiet, and the boys who had been born in the last year, small and breathing and innocent of what they had cost. He felt, quite distinctly, the weight of attention. Not eyes, precisely, but the pressure of many people holding their breath at once.

He raised his hand to knock on the nearest door.

"*Don't*," said Aashi.

"Somebody has to —"

"The old woman said stand still. Stand where the light can see us."

"There is no light."

"Then where can we be *found*?" She caught his sleeve. "Antim, listen."

He listened.

From somewhere ahead and above them, thin and desperate and unmistakable, a baby began to cry.

It was a newborn's cry, high and cracked with outrage, and it rose from a house on the next terrace and hung in the cold air for a full three seconds, and Aashi's whole body leaned toward it before she could stop herself. Then, in the middle of a breath, it ceased. It did not fade. It was *cut*, with the sharpness of a door being slammed, and then the silence rushed back into the space where it had been, as though it had been waiting, and in that silence there was a sound that Antim would never afterward be able to explain to anyone and never be able to forget: the soft, wet *pat* of a hand clapped over a small mouth.

Aashi's fingers closed on his arm until it hurt.

"They're afraid it will *hear* him," she breathed.

At the very top of the terrace stood the old pipal tree. They had seen it from below as a vast black shape against the lesser black of the sky, a thing too large for the village that sheltered beneath it, its trunk as broad as a bullock-cart, its branches reaching over the roofs like the arms of a drowned giant. Antim lifted the failing torch, and the beam crawled up the bark, and found a bough, and found hanging from it, in a long dark curve, a rope.

It was a very thick rope, the sort used for a festival swing, woven of jute and bamboo-fibre and grown grey with a year's rain, and it hung straight down from the branch and ended in a loop where the swing's seat had once been. The seat was gone. The loop was empty. It turned a very little in the torchlight. In a village where no air moved, where the mist hung motionless, it turned, slowly, in a long tired half-circle, as if somebody had just let go.

The torch went out.

It did not fade or flicker. It was a light, and then it was not, and the whole weight of the mountain night came down on them. In the blackness Antim heard his wife draw breath, and felt her hand find his, and heard, from the very top of the tree, one slow creak of rope.

"Put out your light," said a voice behind them.

Antim spun, his hand going for the revolver, and had it half drawn when the speaker said, quite calmly: "It is out already. That is a good sign. Be still, please. Be *very* still, and put that thing away. It cannot help you, and it will only make the evening longer."

A lantern had appeared in the dark.

It was a plain old hurricane lantern with cracked glass and a flame turned so low that it was a bead of honey-gold, and it was held by a figure who had not been there a moment ago. There had been no footfall, no scrape of sandal on rock; the mist had simply opened and the figure had stepped out of it, and now stood on the path a few paces away, holding the lantern at the height of the waist so that its light fell upward onto chest and chin and left the rest in shadow.

The figure was tall and slender, and stooped a little at the shoulders, in a long coat of faded charcoal wool that hung loose enough to hide whatever shape lay beneath it. A thick grey muffler was wrapped about the lower half of the face, up over the nose, and a worn woollen shawl was drawn over the head and pinned beneath the chin, so that nothing could be seen but a strip of face between the cloth and the shawl: two eyes, deep-set and pale as water in a well and smudged at the rims with old kohl, and the high bone of a brow, and, on the centre of the forehead, a scar. On the left wrist, where the sleeve had slipped, a single thin glass bangle shone red in the light.

It was a small scar, no longer than a thumb-joint, a pale curved line, slightly raised, like the mark of a very thin cord pulled very tight against the skin. It shone a little in the lantern-light. Aashi found, to her annoyance, that she could not look away from it.

"Who are you?" said Antim.

"A person with a light," said the stranger, "in a village that doesn't have one." The voice was dry, even and unhurried, pitched somewhere between a man's and a woman's, the voice of someone who has said these things before and had them disbelieved. "You will forgive me if I do not say my name. In Dhuwakot, we do not hand out names after sunset. Come. We should not be standing in the open."

"We are police officers," said Aashi, "and we have come to investigate —"

"Yes." The pale eyes rested on her, and she felt the look like a hand on her shoulder. "I know what you are. I knew when you were on the

bus. Eleven of you have come up this path in fourteen months, and I have counted every lantern that went up it and not one that came down." The stranger turned, a very little, to look at the tree. "You do not want to be near that. Walk with me. Quietly. Do not look up, whatever you hear."

"How do you know about the eleven?" Antim demanded. "Who told you that?"

"The same one who tells everyone," said the stranger, and began to walk.

They had no choice. Behind them was the dark and the gate and the long cold path to Jyamire; the gate, they would learn, was the one place in all of Dhuwakot where the Lord's reach ended. Before them was the small gold bead of a lantern, swaying gently in the hand of a figure who was already moving off into the night, and who was not, they noticed, looking back to see if they followed.

The stranger led them past the pipal tree. Aashi kept her eyes on the slender back ahead of her and did not raise them, though she felt the rope above her as one feels a person standing too close in a crowd.

Antim noticed it as they climbed. At nearly every barred door the stranger paused, never for long, and set something on the worn stone of the threshold: a bundle of split firewood, a leaf-wrapped packet, a small brass pot with a cloth tied over its mouth, once a twist of dried herbs knotted with red thread. Nothing was said, and no door opened. But at one house a few steps on, Antim glanced back and saw the bar of the door lift a finger's width, and a thin hand reach out into the cold and draw the offering in, and the door closes again with a soft, grateful sound. The stranger did not turn to look. It seemed to be a thing done every night, by someone who had long ago stopped expecting thanks.

They climbed the last terrace, past a final cluster of shuttered houses, past a cattle-shed with the beams of its roof bare and black; they went through a gap between two walls and out onto a stony shelf above the village, where the path dwindled to a goat-track and the mist lay in gullies like spilled milk. This was the oldest part of Dhuwakot, the stranger told them, over one shoulder. Upper Dhuwakot, the first place the first families had built. Nobody else lives there now.

"Why?" Aashi asked.

"Because it is nearer," said the stranger, "to the tree's roots."

They walked on, in silence, in the hush of the sleeping mountain, until a house rose up before them out of the mist.

❦

It was a small house, low and old, of grey fieldstone and slate, with a single window shuttered from within and a door of heavy dark wood bound in iron. A trident was nailed above the lintel, rusted red. In the circle of the lantern the walls glimmered faintly, and it took Antim a moment to understand that they glimmered because they were damp, and that the damp was of the kind that comes only to places that are never warmed.

And around the house, on the bare ground, ran a line.

It was perhaps as wide as a man's thumb: a smooth, unbroken ribbon of white powder poured on the earth in a perfect ring, so close to the walls that a person could not have passed between the line and the stone. Antim crouched and touched it. It was fine, soft, a little gritty, with a faint smell of lime and rice-flour and something older, something that made him think of burnt bone. It had been laid with care. Not a grain was out of place.

"Pitho," said the stranger. "Ground rice, from the first harvest. Lime from the old kiln. Salt from the Tibetan road. And ashes, which I will not name." The stranger stepped over the line with a curious hitching stride, left foot first, as one stepped over a sleeping animal, and turned and held out a hand to them. "Left foot first, please. Do not scuff it. Do not let your clothes drag on it. If you scatter it by so much as a finger's width, you must tell me *at once*, because I will have to mend it, and it is not a thing that can be mended in the dark by someone who is hurrying."

Aashi stepped over the line with her left foot and felt, absurdly, as if she were crossing a threshold into a different country. Antim followed. When they were both inside, the stranger knelt, with surprising speed, and with the edge of a bare palm smoothed a few stray grains back into place. Then the stranger rose and pushed open the door, and they went in.

It was a single room with a loft above, and it was clean, and cold, and bare. A hearth of blackened stones. A low wooden platform for sleeping, heaped with quilts. A row of small clay pots on a shelf, sealed

with wax. Over the door and over the single shuttered window hung bundles of dried herbs and nailed planks, and around the windowframe, in thick white paint, a pattern of lines and curves that Antim, a rational man, recognised and declined to recognise: a rope, he thought, drawn over and over, knotted, looped, closed.

The stranger bolted the door behind them and set the lantern on the hearth-stone. The muffler stayed where it was, even when the fire was built up, with quick deft movements, from a heap of dry sticks; but as the stranger reached for the poker the sleeve of the coat rode up, and Aashi saw the wrist and the back of the hand in the firelight. A band of old scar, thick, ropy, shining, circled the wrist beside the thin red bangle like a second, cruder bracelet, and another showed across the heel of the palm, and she thought, with a small cold shock: *rope burns. They held a rope that was pulling. They have held it with all their weight.*

The stranger saw her looking, and drew the sleeve down, and said nothing.

Tea came, black and strongly gingered, in two tin mugs, and with it a plate of *dhido* made from buckwheat and a bowl of gundruk, sour and salty, and they ate in the heat of the fire without speaking, because neither of them had realised how hungry they were. The stranger did not eat, but sat on their heels across the hearth, a long shape in the firelight, with the muffler and the shawl and the lit eyes, and watched them.

"That line outside," said Antim, when his mug was empty. "What is that line keeping out? What is that evil?"

"I did not say *that evil*," said the stranger. "I have not said that word. In this house, we say *Lord.* We say, when we must, *the Lord who hangs. Jhundiyeko Prabhu!*" The stranger said the Nepali low and without emphasis, but the fire seemed to shrink a little at the name, and for an instant the whole room leaned as the lamp had leaned in the birthing room fourteen months before. "Please do not say it again after I have gone."

"A lord who hangs," said Aashi. "From the pipal?"

"From the pipal. From the roof-beam. From the branch of whatever tree is near, wherever there is a house in which a son has just been born. It is not a ghost, memsahib. A ghost is a thing that was previously a person. This was never a person, or so we have always told ourselves,

though it has worn the shape of many." The stranger lifted the poker and turned a log.

"Forgive me," said Antim, who had been listening with his jaw set, "but in my experience a lord who hangs is a man who hangs *others*. A thug with a rope and a reputation. A smuggler who has found that a good legend is cheaper than a good gang." He said it politely, the way a man lays a coin on a counter. "I have seen men do worse with less."

The stranger regarded him for a long moment over the edge of the muffler, without the slightest offence. "Yes," they said. "The eleven who came before you said something very like that. One of them said it in almost those words." Another log was turned. "My grandfather's grandfather said that it was old when the first stone of the first house was laid. That the village was not built beside it but *around* it. That it was given a place and a name and a promise, and that the promise has been kept, with great exactness, for a long time. And last year, for the first time in memory —"

"Someone broke it," said Aashi.

The pale eyes lifted.

"I didn't say that."

"You didn't have to." She leaned forward. "Antim thinks there's a man behind this, a man with an account book. I have not decided what I think. But I know the sound of a village after a crime. I've heard it in a hundred places. It doesn't sound like fear. It sounds like *guilt.*"

For a long time the stranger did not answer. The log crackled, and sank, and sent up a spurt of sparks.

"Every house in Dhuwakot has a sin in it," the stranger said at last, quietly, "and every sin has a mother who keeps it. You will not get one of them to say it. Not for you, not for the Chief District Officer, not for the King. The eleven who came before you asked too loudly, and in the wrong places, and in the dark. I am not the kind who asks. I am the kind who waits."

"For what?" said Antim.

"For somebody who cannot be counted."

The sentence hung in the air between them. Aashi felt it cross her skin like a draught.

"Tonight you are guests," the stranger said, rising, "and a guest in a protected house is safe. This I swear by what is left of my own name. But I must ask three things of you, and I must ask that you not forget

them, even if you are afraid, even if you are *certain*, even if you think you recognise the voice. First, whatever calls you from outside, by any name, in any voice, you do not answer. Second, you do not open the door, nor the window, nor the shutter, for any reason that sounds like love. Third!..." The stranger paused. "You do not look through any gap. Not a crack. Not a knothole. Not a finger's width of space between two planks. If you must look, look at the fire."

"And if we don't?" asked Antim.

"Then," said the stranger, "you will join the eleven."

It was said gently. The stranger bent and took up the lantern again, and for an instant its light fell fully across the face, across the strip of cloth and the pale eyes and the pale hooked scar upon the forehead, and Aashi had the strangest, most fleeting impression that she knew it: not the face, but the *shape* of the scar, which she had seen before, somewhere, or been shown, or dreamed. It was gone before she could place it.

The stranger put the lantern on its hook above the hearth, so that its low gold light filled the room, and banked the fire, and laid out two quilts and two pillows on the sleeping-platform with a stiff formal courtesy, and showed them the water-jar and the clay pot that served for other needs. Then the stranger took a place on the floor with back against the bolted door and hands folded in the lap, and bowed his head, and was still.

Antim sat on the edge of the platform with the revolver across his knee. Aashi lay down beside him fully clothed. She slid her hand beneath the pillow, and felt the little twist of paper that Aama had given her, rice and ash, and closed her fingers around it. She did not expect to sleep.

She was right.

❦

The first sign came a little before two.

Aashi would remember afterward that she had been looking at the lantern. Its flame, which had burned straight and steady for hours, had begun to lean. Slowly, with no draught she could feel, it bowed toward the door, the way the lamp had bowed in a birthing room in the village

below, fourteen months before, and she thought, absurdly: *it wants to leave.*

The figure by the door lifted their head.

They did not move, otherwise. But their whole body changed, as a deer's changes in the instant before it bolts, and the cloth over their mouth began to stir with a rapid whisper, shaping words that were old and not Nepali. Antim's fingers closed around the butt of his revolver. The fire sank. In the silence of the mountain a sound came creeping over the roofs, from the direction of the village, very faint, very far.

"Creeeeak…"

It was rope. It was a heavy rope taking a heavy weight, and Aashi knew it before she let herself know it, as one knows a voice in a dream.

"Creeeeak…" Slow. Patient. Closer.

It was coming up the hill. She could hear the rhythm now, the long sigh of the rope swinging out and the long groan of it swinging back, a measured, patient, pendulum sound, and with each swing it was a little nearer to the house. She heard a drip, and then another: a wet, steady dripping, as of water falling from a great height onto stone. And she smelled it, creeping under the door and through the planks and into the dry cold air of the room, rank and sweet and unmistakable: marigolds, old marigolds rotting in a closed room, and wet rope, and under them something else, something living and rotting at once, something that should not have been able to hang in the air as thickly as it did.

"Be still," said the stranger at the door, without moving. "It cannot cross. It will test. It will try everything it has. Be still."

The creaking stopped.

Aashi felt her heart stop with it. In the breathless hush there was only the fire, and the beating of her own pulse, and the sense — enormous, intimate — of something *standing* just outside the wall, so close that she could have reached through the stone and touched it.

"Antim."

The voice came from just beyond the door, low and warm and tired, and she felt her husband's whole body go rigid beside her.

"Antim. *Babu.* It's me. Open the door, son. It's cold out here."

It was a man's voice, deep and slow and rich, with a soldier's flat vowels. Aashi had never heard it in her life. But she had heard it described, once or twice, in the careful, stunned, reluctant way that

people describe the dead, and she knew, with a kind of sick certainty, whose voice it was.

"Babu, I could not hold on. The rope was so rough. I could not hold on, and you were on the bank, and you could not hear me. Open the door. I'm so cold."

"*Don't,*" said the stranger at the door.

Antim was on his feet. She had not seen him rise. The revolver hung forgotten at his side, and his face in the lantern-light was bloodless and childlike, the face of a twelve-year-old boy on the bank of a river on a bright morning. His lips were moving. "Baba," he said. "Baba —"

"*Antim!*" Aashi flung herself off the platform and caught his arm with both hands. He did not feel her. He took a step toward the door, and she dug her heels into the stone floor, and was dragged, and the stranger in the grey muffler, who had moved with that terrible quickness, was suddenly between them and the bolt with one rope-scarred hand locked on Antim's wrist.

"Your father," the stranger said, very distinctly, "is not out there."

"He is —"

"Your father is at the bottom of the Trishuli, and has been for years, and he does not know your name. *Look at me.* That is a voice made out of the bottom of you. It is wearing the thing you buried deepest. It has done it to all of them. Look at me, officer!"

A tremor ran through Antim. Slowly, the glaze went out of his eyes. He stared at the scarred hand on his wrist, and then at the eyes above the cloth, and then at his wife, who was clinging to him with her face wet. His chest heaved. "Aashi," he whispered. "Aashi, I —"

"I know," she said. "I know. I'm here."

Outside, the voice of Subedar Karki had stopped.

There was a pause, long enough for Aashi to hear her own breath, long enough to think that it was over.

Then, outside the shuttered window, something *scratched*.

It was the lightest sound. A fingernail drawn very slowly down the wood. Tap, and scratch, and tap, and scratch, moving along the shutter toward the place where a knot in one of the planks had worn through to a hole the width of a thumb. She saw it. She saw it with perfect, cold clarity, in the dim gold of the lantern, a small dark circle in the plank,

and through it, from the other side, a thin line of paler darkness: the night itself, looking in.

"Do not look," said the stranger by the door. They sounded, for the first time, afraid.

She looked at the fire. She held her husband's hand so hard that the bones ground together. She stared into the red heart of the coals until her eyes burned, and she heard the scratching stop, and a new sound begin: a slow, wet, careful drip, drip, drip, on the sill, on the stone, in the dust of the powdered line, and something being drawn, patiently, across the ground outside the walls.

The stranger dropped to their knees and pressed an ear against the floor, and went white around the eyes. "It's touching the line," they said. "God of the hills. It has never touched the line."

"What is it doing?"

"It is *testing the edge*." The voice cracked. "It is walking around the house. It is going slowly. It is looking for the place where it is thinnest, and it is not looking *for the two of you*." They lifted their head, and those wide, unblinking eyes found Aashi's face, and then slid, slowly, to the place beneath her shawl where her hand had gone without her knowing. "It is looking for *that*."

Aashi said nothing. There was nothing in her mind at all.

"Who told it?" said the stranger, almost to themselves. "Nobody could have told it. It has barely *begun*. It cannot know the sex of a thing so small, and yet it —" The stranger stopped. A dreadful understanding passed across the upper half of the face. "It has never needed to be told, has it. It has always known. It has always known which houses were carrying."

"What do you want from us?" Antim said, and his voice came out in a croak.

"I want nothing from you. It is not my wanting that matters." The stranger rose, slowly, on shaking legs. "The line will hold, I think. The line should hold. But I swore you were safe, and I swore it on a name I cannot afford to lose, and I don't think —" The stranger swallowed. "I did not know, Superintendent, that one of you was carrying."

Outside, abruptly, the dripping ceased.

In the stillness they heard the creak of rope one more time, a single, patient, long-drawn note. It was no longer coming from the village below. It was coming from above them. From the roof.

From the very beam of the house.

"Creeeeak…"

Dust sifted down from the ceiling and into the lantern-light. Aashi's gaze rose, against her will, to the dark loft above the hearth, a black square of shadow under the slates. Nobody had slept there in years. There was no child in the house. There was no woman, no crib, no cradle, no sign of any life but their own.

And then, in the loft, in the dark, directly above their heads, a baby began to cry.

It was thin, and furious, and very new, and it was the most terrible sound that Antim Karki had heard in his life. He felt his wife's nails go through his sleeve. He saw the stranger in the grey muffler, who had been brave through all of it, stagger back against the wall with one rope-scarred hand pressed against the cloth over the mouth, the eyes wide above it, and heard them say, in a voice that was hardly a voice at all:

"There is no child in this house."

The lantern flame leaned, and bowed, and shrank to a single bead of gold.

Above them, patiently, a rope began to creak.

❦

End of Chapter One

CHAPTER TWO

The Hour of the Lamp

The rope creaked, and the baby cried, and for a length of time that none of them could afterwards measure, nothing else in the world was permitted to happen.

It was not a loud sound. That was the horror of it. Aashi had braced herself, in the long seconds after the first cry, for something enormous: a scream, a crash of slate, the roof torn open like the lid of a tin. Instead there was only the thin, furious wail of a newborn in the dark of the loft, and beneath it, keeping time with it, as steady as a mother's foot on the rocker of a cradle, the long slow groan of rope.

"Creeeeak..." And the child's breath, drawn in. *"Creeeeak..."* And its cry, let go.

"Do not go to it," said the stranger.

They had slid down the wall until they were sitting on the stone floor beside the bolted door, the pale eyes fixed on the black square of the loft. One hand was pressed flat against the planks as though holding the door shut by will alone. With the other they had fumbled a small clay pot from inside the coat, broken its wax seal with a thumbnail, and scattered a pinch of its grey powder across the threshold in a quick, shaking arc.

"It will sound hungry," they said. "It will sound cold. It will sound like the one you were never allowed to meet. Whatever it sounds like, it is a *door*, and a door opens in both directions."

Antim had come up onto his feet with the revolver in both hands. The barrel followed the cry across the ceiling like the needle of a compass. "I could put six rounds through those planks," he said. His

voice was low and quite steady, which frightened Aashi more than a shout would have done.

"You could." The stranger did not look at him. "They would go through nothing, and when you had finished you would have taught it the sound of your gun. He learns, Superintendent. He has learned from eleven of you already."

For a moment the barrel did not move. Then, slowly, as if lowering a heavy bucket into a well, Antim let the revolver sink to his side.

It was Aashi who noticed that the crying had changed.

It was fainter. It had been a scream; now it was a protest, and then a complaint, and then something softer still, the fretful, hiccuping murmur of a child who is being rocked and does not yet know it. The creaking above them slowed to match. *Creeeeak*, and a long pause. *Creeeeak*, and a longer one. It had become, quite unmistakably, a lullaby, a lullaby sung in rope, and somewhere in her mind a small calm voice informed her that it was a very good lullaby, that she had never heard a better, that her eyelids were heavy and that it would do no harm to rest them for a moment.

She bit the inside of her cheek, hard, until she tasted iron. She dragged out the twist of paper from under the pillow and tore it open and pressed the rice and ash into her palm until the grains cut.

"Antim," she said. "Antim, don't sit down."

But he had already sat down.

He sat on the edge of the sleeping-platform as though his strings had been cut, the revolver sliding from his fingers and landing on the quilt, and he looked at her with an expression of mild and drowsy surprise. "I'm only resting my eyes," he said, in the reasonable tone of a man who has said it a thousand times. "It's quiet now. Listen. It's quiet."

"*Superintendent.*" The stranger had come up off the floor, quick as a cat. "You must not sleep. If you sleep it will take you through the rope —"

His head tipped. His eyes closed. It was not the sleep of exhaustion. It was a drop, a sudden, total fall, like a man stepping onto a stair that is not there. Aashi caught him as he went over, seized his shoulders, shook him, said his name, said it again, slapped his face, and he did not wake. His skin was burning. His lips moved, shaping a word, and she bent close to hear it, and the word was *Baba.*

Around his left wrist, the brightest thing in the room, the red thread that his mother had tied there glowed in the lantern-light like a freshly opened vein.

❦

He was twelve, and the morning was bright.

It was always bright in this part of the memory, and he had never understood why. The Trishuli ran loud and brown beneath the old bridge, full of the mountains' laundry, and the sun lay on the water so hard that it hurt to look. The bridge was a rope bridge, the old kind, twisted jute and braided cane and a handful of iron staples, swinging out over the gorge from one bank to the other like a sentence nobody had finished. His father was halfway across it.

He was always halfway across it. Subedar Karki, in his uniform, with his back to the bank, walking at the steady unhurried pace of a man who has crossed a great many rivers, one hand trailing along the rope.

"Baba!" Antim called.

His father did not turn. The planks creaked under his boots.

"Creeeeak…"

And that was wrong, because it was the wrong sound; because in the true memory the creak was a bridge's creak, wood and straining fibre, and this was the creak of a rope under a hanging weight, long, patient, intimate, and as the sound reached him Antim understood that he was not standing on the bank. He had never been standing on the bank. He was on the bridge already, twelve years old and barefoot, and the planks were moving under him in the long slow rhythm of a swing.

The bridge was longer than it had been. It ran out ahead of him into a whiteness that had no far side. The river below was not brown. It was white and soundless, a river of mist, and the rope railings on either side were knotted at every pace, each knot as thick as a fist, and each knot bound with a tuft of black hair.

"Baba, stop. Wait for me."

"Creeeeak…"

A hand's breadth from his bare feet a plank gave way, and fell, and through the gap he saw them.

They hung in the white beneath the bridge, upside down, in rows. They hung from ropes that came out of nowhere, as though the sky itself were a beam, and they hung with their arms trailing loose beneath their heads like men swimming through the air, and their eyes were open, and their lips were moving. They were wearing their hats. That was the thing that stayed with him, the terrible small mercy of it: that the dhaka topis stayed neatly on the upside-down heads, as if gravity had been suspended out of courtesy. In the front row he saw khaki. He recognised Sub-Inspector Thapa, whom he had met once at a Dashain parade and who had shaken his hand too hard. He recognised Inspector Rai's moustache. Behind them came more khaki, and plain clothes, and then the village: men with the broad hands of farmers; and lower down, smaller, in rows that went on and on, boys. A boy in a school shirt, holding a slate. The chalk in his hand was still moving. It was writing the same letter on the empty air, over and over, and the air was keeping it.

Antim counted. He could not help it; he had always been the one who counted. He counted eleven police, in khaki and plain clothes, and nine men in dhaka topis, and nine boys, and the number he arrived at was twenty-nine.

Ahead of him, on the bridge, his father had stopped.

"You were always the one who counted," said Subedar Karki, without turning. It was his father's voice, the flat soldier's vowels, patient and slightly amused. "Do you remember how you used to count the steps up to the barracks? Four hundred and eleven. You made me promise never to take a different path."

"Baba, turn around."

"The rope wasn't rough, Babu." The voice was warm, and a little sad. "That's what I wanted to tell you. They always say it was rough. It wasn't. It was kind. It only wanted to be held."

"*Turn around.*"

His father turned.

There was no face. There was a hat, and a collar, and between them, in the place where a face should have been, a smooth pale oval, blank as an egg, crossed from the brow to beneath the chin by a single thin, curved line, the line of a rope drawn very tight. And then the whole figure was lifting from the planks, slowly, its boots rising from the boards as though lifted by the hair, its arms hanging, its head tipping

back and back until it hung from the white sky, upside down above the bridge, and the oval where the face should have been was the last thing he saw of it.

The voice came from everywhere.

"*Twenty-nine,*" it said. It was not his father's voice any longer. It was the voice of something that had learned a great many voices and was only now beginning to enjoy them. "*Twenty-nine, and the rope has room. It is a long rope, Superintendent. Come and be counted.*"

Antim ran.

He did not run toward the bank, because there was no bank. He ran toward the one thing he could see in all that whiteness: a small figure at the far end of the bridge, standing quite still, in a cotton sari, with a shawl drawn over her head. She was holding something in her arms. A bundle, wrapped in red.

"Aashi!"

She lifted her face. She was smiling, and it was the wrong smile, a smile that was a little too wide and a little too patient, and in the crook of her arm the red bundle stirred and turned and a tiny wrist came out of the folds, and around the wrist was knotted a loop of rope. The small face that rose to look at him was his own. It was his own face, at twelve, wide-eyed and appalled, with the Trishuli's light in it.

Every plank on the bridge fell away at once.

He felt the drop in the pit of his stomach, the long, sick lurch of the fall, and he threw out his hands for the rope and the rope was not there, there was only the white and the creaking, and the creaking was closing around him like the fingers of a hand —

And his left wrist *burned.*

It burned like a brand. The burn was a bright and furious thing, a clean, white, domestic heat, and it closed around his wrist and *pulled*, with the stubborn strength of a small old woman hauling a pot off a fire. And a voice, not the voice of the hanging thing, but a fierce, familiar, cross voice that smelled of ghee and woodsmoke and boiled rice, said in his ear, quite distinctly:

"*You do not separate.*"

The bridge cracked in half. The white went black. The creaking turned, in a single heartbeat, into a scream, a long thin scream of fury that went on, and on, and on —

❦

Antim woke to the sound of a rooster crowing.

It was the most ordinary sound in the world, and it was the strangest thing of all, because in all his hours in Dhuwakot he had not heard a bird or a beast or a barking dog, and the simple, cheerful, absurd crow of a rooster in the grey light seemed to him the greatest miracle he had ever witnessed. He lay on his back on the sleeping-platform with his mouth open and his heart pounding and stared at the ceiling. The beam. The slates. A pale square of window where somebody had pulled a shutter ajar. Daylight.

"Antim."

Aashi was kneeling over him. She was white with exhaustion, her hair stuck to her cheeks, and her fingers were digging into his shoulders as though she had been holding him down for hours. Perhaps she had. Her eyes were red. "Antim, look at me. Say my name."

"Aashi." His voice was a rasp. "It was —"

"Say it again."

"Aashi Karki. Deputy Superintendent. Seven weeks." He found, to his considerable surprise, that he was crying, and that it did not seem to matter. "Aashi, I was on the bridge."

"I know." She laid her forehead against his, and he felt her shake. "I know. You were saying it all night. I couldn't wake you. I thought —" She stopped, and breathed. "The thread. Look at your wrist."

He lifted his left hand.

His mother's red thread was gone. In its place, around his wrist, lay a thin black ring of char, the ash of burnt cotton, no wider than a bootlace, and beneath it, printed into the skin as clearly as a seal on wax, a ring of raw red weal. The mark was warm. It did not hurt. It looked, he thought stupidly, like a hand: like the print of small, strong, determined fingers.

"It went white a little before dawn," said Aashi. "I watched it. It went white and it crackled, and you screamed — you *screamed*, Antim, I have never heard — and then the rope upstairs screamed with you, and then it stopped. Everything stopped. The crying, the creaking, all of it." She wiped her face with the back of her hand. "And a minute later, the cock crowed."

"*Aama*," Antim said.

"Yes."

"I never even — I thought she tied that for show, Aashi. She ties one on me every Dashain."

"I know," said Aashi, and began, helplessly, to laugh, and then to cry, and then to do both at once, and he held her until it was done.

❦

The stranger was already at the door.

They stood with their back to the room and one hand on the bolt, as they had stood, Aashi realised, for all of the hours of the night, a long slender figure in a coat of charcoal wool, the shawl fallen back on the shoulders, the muffler still in place. They had not slept. Their head hung a little, and the lantern on its hook above the hearth had burned itself down to a blue bead of flame.

"It is a full day," the stranger said, without turning. "The sun is above the ridge. It cannot come back to the line in the daylight; it has no weight in the day. I tell you this so that you will not be afraid when I open the door." There was a pause. "I tell you *this*, also, so that you will not be afraid of what you see."

The bolt slid back. The door swung open on a morning so bright, so blue, so scrubbed and washed and innocent, that Antim blinked like a man leaving a cinema.

The mist had drawn back into the gorge and lay there like milk in a saucer. Beyond the white line, the hillside fell away in terraces of gold with stubble, and the sun lit the slate roofs of Dhuwakot one by one, as a lamp lit a row of faces. In the distance a woman was calling a buffalo by name. It might have been any hill village in Nepal on any winter morning.

But the line was broken.

Not broken, Antim saw, as he stood in the doorway; the ring of white powder ran unbroken around the house, as perfect as the night before. It was what lay *outside* it that made the hair rise on his neck. Pressed into the damp earth in a ring around the house, a pace beyond the powder, there ran a single track of marks, close together, going all the way around. They were not footprints. They were too small, too narrow, too deep, a ring of points like the heads of nails: *toe-marks*, only toe-marks, the tips of two bare feet, set down at the edge of the

ground where a creature would stand if it were hanging from a rope with the toes just touching the earth, and swaying, and swaying, and walking around in circles on the points of its feet.

And at the height of Antim's chest, all the way around the house, the white-limed wall was wet. Not wet like rain, in streaks. It was wet in a long pale band, a hand's breadth wide, as though a thick damp rope had been dragged slowly around the stones from one end to the other and left a darkness behind it, and on the sill of the shuttered window, pressed into the old dust, lay a dozen long thin scratches: the marks of a fingernail, drawn downward, again and again, from the knot-hole to the sill.

"It walked the circle seven times," the stranger said. "I counted. Seven is the number it prefers."

"And the loft?" said Aashi.

She had not meant to ask. It had simply come out of her, the way a hand goes to a wound. The stranger turned at last and looked at her, and in the plain morning light she saw that the pale eyes were bloodshot to the rims, and that the kohl around them had run in grey streaks to the cheekbone.

"You may look," they said. "I have looked already."

It was a short ladder, and Antim climbed it first, with the revolver in his hand and his heart doing nothing sensible at all. The loft was a low space under the slates, bare boards and a few coils of old rope on a nail, and light fell in a bar through a crack in the roof. It was empty. There was no cradle, no cloth, no child. There was only, in the middle of the dust, a small round hollow, about the size of a newborn's body, as though something had lain there recently and been lifted away. Heaped carefully within the hollow, in the unmistakable shape of a swaddled infant, were wet marigold petals, hundreds of them, rotting at the edges and yet brilliantly orange.

On the swaddle's chest was a loop of red thread tied in a tiny noose.

Antim looked at it for a long time. Then he came down the ladder and did not say what he had seen, and Aashi, looking at his face, did not ask.

"It wore a cradle's shape for you," the stranger said quietly. "It is learning. It has not done that before. In fourteen months, it never once tried to be *kind*."

❦

They ate breakfast on the doorstep in the sunshine, because none of them could bear to be indoors.

It was a strange and wonderful meal. When the stranger had stepped, with that hitching, left-footed stride, over the white line to fetch water from the spring, there was a plate waiting on the stone just beyond the powder, covered with a clean cloth. Under the cloth lay four sel rotis, still warm, thick golden rings of rice-bread fried in ghee, and beside them stood a clay cup of buffalo milk with a skin on it. There was no message. Nobody was in sight. But down the slope, far below among the roofs, a small bent figure in a brown shawl was hurrying away between the houses with a basket on her back, and she did not look round.

"Dhanmaya," said the stranger, setting down the water-jar. "The midwife. She has not spoken one word to me in fourteen months, and she has not missed a morning." The mouth under the muffler might have smiled. "In Dhuwakot, one is forgiven a great deal if one's neighbour has a good conscience and a good oven."

They broke the selrotis between the three of them and passed the cup of milk from hand to hand, and for a few minutes the only sound was chewing. Antim sat with his wrist resting on his knee, turning the black ring of ash with his thumb. Aashi sat close beside him, so close that their shoulders touched. The sun was warm. A small yellow bird landed on the roof of the cattle-shed and sang a few bars to nobody and flew away.

"I think," said Aashi at last, "that we owe you an apology."

The stranger looked up.

"We have been calling you *the stranger*, in our heads, and *he*, and *the man*," she said. "You never said. We never asked. It was rude of us, and I would like to put it right, if you will allow it."

For a long moment the stranger regarded her. Then the stranger lifted both hands and began, slowly, to unwind the muffler.

It came away in grey loops, and the shawl came down from the head, and the face beneath was a face that Aashi found she had been waiting all night to see, and understood in the same instant that the waiting had itself been a kind of discourtesy. It was a long face, with high cheekbones and a firm, delicate jaw. The mouth was soft and

wide, the mouth of a girl, and along the jaw lay the faint grey shadow of a beard that had been shaved the day before, carefully, with a blunt razor and a steady hand. The kohl around the eyes, smudged by the night, had been laid on with long practice. Dark hair, streaked with grey, was drawn back and braided in a long plait that fell over one shoulder, and in the lobe of the left ear a tiny silver ring caught the sun. It was the face of a person of perhaps forty, or fifty, or thirty-five; a face that had spent a very long time deciding not to be read. And in the middle of the forehead, thin and pale and curved like the first quarter of a moon, was the scar.

"Kinnar is the word the plains would use," the stranger said. "In Delhi they say *hijra*. Here in the hills, they mostly say nothing at all, which is its own kindness and its own cruelty." The voice was the same dry, even voice, but in the daylight it sat easily where it had sat, in the night, uneasily: between the registers, like a bird on a wire. "I was a son, as the village counted. I have not been a son for a great many years. I have never been a daughter. I am, I think, the question that the village has not yet found the courage to ask."

Antim cleared his throat. He was a rational man, and a soldier's son, and he had been raised in a world with two kinds of people in it, and he felt the old categories rise in him like reflex, and for a moment he was ashamed of that, and then he put the shame aside and did the one simple thing that was in his power.

"What should we call you?" he said.

The kinnar looked at him with a flicker of something very like surprise. "Nobody has asked me that in a long time," they said. "The name I was given was a son's name, and I buried it when I stopped answering to it. The one I chose, I have never said aloud in Dhuwakot. There was no one here I trusted to hold it." The pale eyes were steady. "I will give it to you when this is finished, if we are all three alive to trade names. Until then, I ask you to be patient with me."

"Of course." Antim inclined his head, as to a senior officer. "And, forgive me. If we must speak about you, to one another. What do we __"

"Ah." The kinnar smiled, and it transformed the long grave face for an instant into something almost mischievous. "That is the kindest thing about our language, Superintendent. In Nepali the word *uni* does not ask anyone to choose. It is only English that is always in such a

hurry." The corners of the eyes crinkled. "Say *uni*. It has never yet asked me to be anything I was not."

"*Uni*," said Aashi, softly.

"*Uni*," Antim agreed, and it came more easily than he had expected, and the ease of it, in the sunshine, with sel roti in his hand, was one of the small, unexpected graces of that long and terrible morning.

The kinnar rewound the muffler loosely about the throat, like a person adjusting a favourite shawl, and left the rest of the face bare. The sun lay on the scar. "Now," they said. "I think that you wish to ask me everything."

"Yes," said Antim. "Everything."

"Then eat first. It will be a long story, and I would rather tell it to people who are not hungry."

"There were forty families," said the kinnar, "when they first came up."

They had moved to the stone bench beside the door, with the sun full on their faces, and the kinnar sat with the clay cup of milk in both hands and spoke in the slow, level cadence of one who has told a story many times to an audience of nobody. Antim had taken out his notebook. Aashi sat with her knees drawn up under her shawl, watching the hillside.

"It was seven generations ago. The year the rains failed, my grandfather's grandfather used to say, and the year after, and the year after that. The plains were burning with hunger and a war together, and the tax-collectors went from village to village with their lists and their soldiers, and where they had been there was nothing left to bury. So forty families took what they could carry and went up. They went up into the mist, because the mist was the only place that the soldiers had never wished to go. They carried their dead's ashes in brass pots. They carried seed. And one evening, in a fold of the hills where the cloud lay so thick that they could not see the hands in front of their faces, they came upon a pipal tree."

"The one in the square," said Aashi.

"The very one. Even then it was old. It stood alone on a shelf of grass, wider than a house, and there was a shrine at its foot with no god in it, only a hollow of black stone, and a smell of marigolds, though no marigold grew within a day's walk. And from the lowest bough of that tree hung a man."

Antim's pencil stopped.

"Dead, they supposed. Very long dead, by the look of the rope. He hung there with his head bowed on his chest and his arms loose at his sides, and the strangest thing, my grandfather's grandfather said, the thing which the old women would never let a child forget, was that he was *smiling.* The mist moved around him. It moved as water moves around a stone. The first families stood under that tree in the cold and the dark with their children crying, and the eldest of the women, a widow named Rukmini, who was the first of her name and not the last, walked forward and looked up into the hanging face, and said to it, in the tone in which one speaks to a landlord: *Sir, we are tired, and we are hungry, and we have nowhere to go. Will you give us a place in your heart?*"

The sun was warm on Aashi's knees, but she was cold. "And it answered."

"It did not answer in words, memsahib. It answered in a mist." The kinnar turned the cup in their scarred hands. "In the morning the soldiers' lanterns went past the foot of the hill, and did not see the village. The next month, the first seed came up in the terraces, green as a wet leaf, with no rain. The year after, the first baby was born, and it lived, and the one after it, and not one child in that village died of fever or flux or the river for a hundred years. They had found their place at the hearth. The mist hid them, and fed them, and fenced them in. And the price —"

"The price," said Antim.

"A rope for a son." The kinnar said it quietly. "That was the whole of the bargain, as it has been kept in our village from mother to daughter. Whenever a son is born in Dhuwakot, the family ties a knot in the great rope, in the pipal, and with the knot a gift: first a goat, then a pot of the first milk, and in later generations a lock of the baby's hair, because the old women said that a gift which comes from the body is a gift that is meant. And the rope took it, and the mist stayed, and in the best of years nothing was taken but the knots."

"It was not always so peaceful, Deputy Sahib," the kinnar added, and then, more quietly, "or so it is said." Their eyes went to the pipal far below. "In the old days the village was not spared, either. The Lord who hangs*, Jhundiyeko Prabhu*, took what He wished, and it was not only knots. Fathers, brothers, grown sons, and in daylight as readily as

in the dark. So the forty families gathered beneath the tree and performed a pooja, a great and terrible one, whose words and rites the eldest mothers have kept ever since and do not share. I do not know what it cost them. I know only what it bought. It could not end Him. It could only bind His power to the night, and bind Him to the hill; in two hundred years He has never been seen beyond the gate on the Jyamire road, nor has the mist. Whatever He takes, He takes within sight of His tree. By day He has no weight, and the village may work and eat and raise its children in the sun. The men go out to their fields at dawn like men anywhere, and are home before the second bell, and none of them sleep. But when the last light goes, the pooja lets go of Him, and He does what He pleases. That is the peace they bought, memsahib: half of every day. By day I may say His name. After dark I will not."

"And the swing?"

"The swing is the rope, Deputy Sahib. Every Dashain the village sets the seat into the loop and the eldest boy of the oldest house sits in it, and is pushed three times, in the sight of the tree, and the whole village sings. It is our festival, and our thanks, and our reminder to Him that we are *keeping* the promise." The kinnar paused. "It is also, I have come to believe, an inspection."

Nobody laughed. In the sunshine the word sat on the doorstep like something that had crawled out of the earth.

"I rode it," said the kinnar.

It was said so lightly that, for a second, Aashi did not understand. She turned her head.

"The year I was seven. I was the eldest boy of the oldest house, at least in the village's reckoning, and the oldest house had decided that year to give the Lord something extra, because a new landlord had come to Bhanjyang and the taxes were doubled. They tied me to the seat with a rope that was not a swing-rope. They said it was *to keep me from falling.*" The thin finger touched, once, the scar on the forehead. "I remember the push. I remember the first swing, and the second. I remember that at the top of the third there was no more sky. There was only a face. And then I came down, and it was dawn, and I was lying in the grass with the rope round my brow, and I had been, they told me, three days gone."

"What did it —" Aashi stopped herself. "Forgive me. You need not."

"It did nothing," said the kinnar. "That is what has taken me nearly forty years to understand. It *looked.* He looked at me for three days, and it could not decide what it was looking at. A son, which it was owed. A daughter, which it was not. It turned me over and over like a man turning a coin that has two heads or none. And in the end it set me down." The smile was very small. "I have survived in this village for thirty-nine years by being a *question*. The mothers never forgave me for it, and never could do without me. It is a very particular way to live. I do not recommend it."

Antim had put down his pencil altogether. He was looking at the kinnar with an expression Aashi had not seen on his face before: a kind of grave and wary respect, with something under it that might one day grow into friendship.

"The duty of my kind," the kinnar went on, "in the plains, is to bless the birth of a son. We come with a drum and a song, and we are fed and feared and paid, and we are not to be refused, because it is dangerous to refuse. In Dhuwakot, no one had ever kept a kinnar. But the old women remembered the custom from the plains, and when I came back from the swing they said, *Well, then, she shall sing at the births.* And so I did, for thirty-eight years. Nine mornings in the last fourteen months, I have gone to a house at dawn with my bangles and my drum, to sing for a new boy, and nine times I have found the porch empty and the glass of rakshi standing full, and the mother looking at me from the dark of the doorway as if I had been the one to do it." The voice did not shake. It only became a little quieter, and a little more distinct. "I began to carry the lantern then. I walk around the village every night. I leave wood and milk at the doors. If I cannot sing, I can at least carry the light."

"Why you?" said Antim.

"Because there was no one else it could not take."

For a time the three of them sat in the sun and said nothing at all.

"The promise was broken," said Aashi at last. "You said so last night. When?"

"At the Dashain of two thousand forty-nine," said the kinnar. "The first night of the swing. I know that much, because that was the night Karna Bahadur Gurung's boy was born, and a boy born at Dashain must have the first knot of the season." The kinnar's brow furrowed. "The knot was not tied. Or it was tied wrong. Or it was tied by the

wrong hands. I do not know. The keeping of the knots belongs to the eldest of the mothers, and the mothers do not speak to me of such things."

"The eldest of the mothers," said Aashi slowly.

"The woman you will meet today, I think, whether you wish to or not."

"And the eleven policemen?" Antim said. "You said you counted the lanterns. Tell me what you saw."

"Sub-Inspector Thapa came in daylight, with two constables and a notebook," said the kinnar. "He asked everyone everything. He wrote it all down. He was a good man, and tidy, and the villagers fed him dal-bhat and told him nothing, and on the third evening he went up to the tree to look at the rope with his torch, and did not come down. Inspector Rai brought four men with rifles, and walked around the village in a square, and slept in the school. The two from Kathmandu drank tea in every kitchen. They were very popular." The gaze was distant. "Inspector Pandey came alone. A big man, with a great grey moustache, a sensible man. He refused my line. I offered it to him. He said, *Thank you, but I would like to see what it does to a man who is not afraid.* " He sat down under the pipal that night with a flask and a torch, and a notebook on his knee, and at midnight, when the rope began to move, he stood up and *saluted* it." The kinnar paused. "I do not know why that has stayed with me."

"And in the morning?"

"In the morning there was a flask under the tree, and a notebook, and no Inspector. I took the notebook. The pages were gone."

Antim leaned forward. "You took it? Where is it?"

"I buried it," said the kinnar. "It was the only thing I could think of to do for him. I am sorry. I could not have known that anyone would ask."

"And the place where all of them went?" said Aashi. "You said last night that you know where He can be found."

"Ah." The kinnar rose, and went to the edge of the shelf, and pointed across the pipal and the roofs, up the far slope, to where the mountain rose in a grey, broken wall of cliff above the highest terraces. In the clear morning light Aashi could see it plainly: a vast pale slab of rock, leaning outward from the face of the cliff like a great hand held out, palm down. Beneath the slab, in the shadow, there was a darker

patch, narrow and vertical, like a thumbprint on a window. “The villagers call it the Hanging Rock. Beneath it there is a crack, wide as a door, where, they say, a stair once began, before it was built over. They have always called that crack the Throat.”

“A cave.”

“A cave. A stair. A tunnel. I do not know what it is. By day it is solid rock; I have put my shoulder against it a hundred times. There is no hinge, no seam. But at the hour of lamp-lighting, when the sun is touching the western ridge and the first lamps would be lit if the village dared to light them, the shadow of the pipal tree comes up the slope. You can watch it. It climbs the terraces, and the cliff, and its tip touches the rock. For the length of time that a small lamp takes to burn, the Throat is open.”

“And after?”

“After, the dark comes, and the Lord comes up.” The voice was flat. “That is the hour He walks. It is the hour you heard Him at the line.”

“So we must go in before the dark,” said Antim, slowly, “and in the hour between.”

“There is no other way. By day, the Throat is stone. By night, He is hungry and above ground. In the hour of the lamp He is neither sleeping nor hungry, He is *present*, He is waiting for the Counting.” The kinnar turned from the cliff. “It is the only time anyone has ever gone in. And I will tell you what I know of the going, which is almost nothing. I was taken in once, as a child, and came out with this.” The fingers touched the scar. “Of the eleven, not one came out. And I believe, though I cannot prove it, that the village’s eighteen went down the same stairs. I do not know what is in there. I know only that the lamp is the thing that tells the rope which way is *down*.”

Antim’s eyes narrowed. “Eighteen?”

“The nine fathers and the nine sons, Superintendent. Along with your eleven.” The kinnar did not look away. “Twenty-nine. I have counted them every night.”

Antim wrote the number in his notebook, and underlined it twice, and a stillness settled over the three of them that was not quite grief, but grew in the same soil.

“You said last night that you were waiting,” Aashi said, “for someone who could not be counted.”

"I did."

"Who did you mean?"

The kinnar was silent for a long moment. The wind moved the end of the plait on their shoulder.

"The Lord counts sons," they said at last. "That is how He keeps His ledger. It does not trouble itself with women; a woman is not a number in its book. So I thought, for fourteen months: *what is needed is a woman, with authority, whom the village's women will speak to, and the Lord will not see.* A woman with a badge. I prayed for her every night like a fool." The kinnar's gaze lifted to Aashi's. "I did not let myself ask what I would do if she came *carrying.* A woman carrying is not a woman to it. A woman carrying is a *door.*"

Aashi's hand had gone to her stomach again, without her knowing.

"I am sorry," the kinnar said. "I am so sorry."

"Don't," said Aashi. Her voice was quite steady. "Don't be sorry. It has been looking for me since the day we left Bhanjyang. It would have found a way. At least here I know what I am walking into." She drew a breath. "What do we need?"

"Aashi —" said Antim.

"I'm not asking *if*, Antim. I'm asking *what.*"

He looked at her. He looked at the thin black ring of ash around his wrist. And then, with the air of a man laying down a weapon and taking up a harder one, he turned to the kinnar and said: "I don't believe in your Lord. I want to say that plainly. I have spent twenty years believing that every ghost is a man in a sheet and every curse a man with a motive. I am not able to stop. But I was in that house last night, and I heard what I heard, and I have a mark on my wrist that I cannot explain. So I will say this instead. Whatever is in that cliff, it has taken twenty-nine of my people, and I mean to see its face. If it's a man, I will arrest him. If it is not —" He stopped. "If it is not, I will find a form of words for it later."

"That," said the kinnar, "is more than the eleven ever said."

"What do we need?"

"Until the lamp-lighting hour, you need to look," said the kinnar. "The village will not answer you. But *look*. Walk its streets. Sit in its kitchens. See what is hung in the doorways and what is not. Whoever broke the promise is in that village, and I am the worst introduction you could possibly have. Go as the schoolmaster and his wife. Say nothing

that has *Lord* or *rope* in it. Listen." The long face was grave. "And return to me by the middle of the afternoon. You will need the hours before sunset for what I must teach you."

"Teach us what?"

"How to go into a cave," said the kinnar, "when you cannot let go of each other's hand."

❦

Dhuwakot by daylight was another country.

They went down the stone stairs at half past eight in the warm, thin, brilliant sunshine of a hill morning, Antim carrying the rucksack and Aashi her shawl and her camera, a respectable couple, a little footsore, on their way to an aunt's. The mist had fallen right back into the gorge. The terraces glowed gold and green. From every chimney, rose a plume of blue woodsmoke, straight up into the still air, and the whole village seemed to *exhale*, as though it had been holding its breath all night and had at last been given permission to stop.

It was terribly normal. That was what unnerved Antim most. A cow lowered in a shed; a woman beat a rug on a wall; a pack of small boys in torn sweaters, not one over the age of ten, chased a hoop of bicycle-tyre down the steps and shrieked. There were hens. There was a radio, somewhere, playing a film song. A girl in a school uniform sat on a doorstep with a book. The doors that had been barred the night before stood open, and the windows were thrown wide, and through them he glimpsed kitchens and cooking-fires and the hump of quilts being aired. There were men, too. That surprised him, and then, on reflection, did not. They were out on the terraces with their ploughs and sickles, mending walls, splitting wood, carrying fodder in doko baskets: men of every age from fourteen to seventy, who greeted the strangers with plain hill courtesy, a nod, a "Namaste, sir." But they worked fast. They worked with one eye on the sun. Antim noticed how often a head would lift toward the western ridge, as a sailor glances at the sky, and how little anyone lingered; a joke would begin and end quickly, as though laughter were rationed. By day the men of Dhuwakot were free. It was only that every one of them was counting the hours of it.

"It's like a village in a war," Aashi murmured.

"Yes."

"Only the war has been going on in the dark, and nobody's mentioned it."

They came to the tap at the foot of the main terrace, a long stone trough with a bronze spout, where a queue of women stood waiting with brass gagris on their hips, and the chatter came to an end as one wiped a slate.

Eleven pairs of eyes looked at them. Antim had been looked at by suspects, and by judges, and once by a very angry elephant, and none of those experiences had prepared him for being looked at by eleven women at a village tap.

Then the silence broke, all at once, like a pot dropped on a stone floor.

"*Eh*, look, look — Maili, look! The one from the hill has brought *guests*!"

"Guests? In *this* cold? Aiyaa, in a cotton sari! The poor girl will catch her death."

"City people, you can tell from the shoes. Look at the shoes."

"And the husband! So tall, so *thin*, what is the wife feeding him? Babu, are you from Kathmandu?"

"We are from Bhanjyang, mother," said Antim, with the stiff and wary courtesy of a man who has just been outflanked. "I am a schoolmaster."

"A schoolmaster!" The speaker was a square, powerful woman of fifty in a red blouse and a green-checked shawl, with a mouth like a purse and a gold ring through her nose the size of a bangle, and she exchanged a glance with her neighbours that conveyed a great deal. "A *schoolmaster.* We have one of our own, an old man, and he is trouble enough. And his wife with her *camera.* And where are you going, with your fine shoes, in a village that does not receive visitors?"

"To see an aunt," said Aashi.

"Which aunt?"

There was a pause that was perhaps half a second long. "The one up the hill," said Aashi, and smiled, with every ounce of demure and respectable and slightly stupid sweetness that she possessed. "She is my husband's mother's cousin."

A shriek of laughter went up from the queue, and the woman in the green shawl actually slapped her thigh. "*That one!* The aunt of a schoolmaster! Aiyaa, hear that, Sunita, that one's got *relatives*. Does

she send for you every Dashain, Didi, to bless the children? You will find a good many mothers who would like to know. Eh, eh." She wiped her eyes. But her face, Aashi noted, was not entirely laughing; behind the fat amusement, as behind a shutter, something had narrowed and sharpened and was taking careful stock.

"It is a very cold house, that house," the woman said. "Up on the hill, with the ash all round it. You will not sleep warm. You must come to *my* house tonight."

"You are very kind —"

"Tilmaya. Tilmaya Gurung. Anyone will tell you. Ask for Tilmaya, with the nose-ring." She looked Aashi up and down, slowly, from shawl to shoe, and her gaze came to rest, as such gazes always do, on the one place that mattered. "And how many children do you have, Didi?"

Aashi had been prepared for the question and had a lie ready, but when it came she found, to her mild alarm, that it was a different lie from the one she had prepared. "None, yet," she said. "Nine years, and nothing."

"*Nine years!*" A soft hiss of pity, like steam, went down the line of women. "Aiyaa, aiyaa. Poor thing. Nine years and nothing. Have you been to Dolakha? To the Bhimsen temple? You must go to the new moon, with a pot of curd and a red cloth, and you must go *barefoot.* It worked for my sister-in-law. Four sons. Four! They are like stairs. And have you tried the pomegranate, at dawn, before you drink water?"

"Eat nothing for the first three days of the month but boiled radish," volunteered a thin woman at the back.

"*Radish!* The girl needs to be *fed*, Mina, look at her, she has no flesh —"

"And the husband," said another, "has he been looked at? A husband should be looked at. There is a man in Sindhuli who —"

They descended on her like a flock of kind, loud, bossy hens, and in the space of five minutes, Aashi found herself in possession of six remedies, two recipes, a pinch of turmeric in a twist of paper, and a bangle, which was thrust upon her by a toothless old lady who claimed that it had been worn by seven mothers and never failed. Antim, quite forgotten, stood with a sort of dignified helplessness at the edge of the group until a girl of about sixteen with a long plait and a face like a startled deer seized his sleeve and said, in an urgent whisper, "Sahib,

will you please lift my gagri? I cannot lift it when it is full and Aama will beat me if I spill."

"Of course," said Antim, and lifted it. It weighed rather more than his rucksack. He settled it on the girl's hip and received in return the quick, sidelong smile of a person who has been shown a small kindness in a place where there are few. "What is your name?"

"Pabitra." The smile wavered. She dropped her eyes, and whispered, so that only he could hear it: "My father comes in from the fields at four, and bars the door, and sits with his back against it. He has not slept a night since last Dashain."

Antim felt the words go through him like a splinter.

"Pabitra, *hurry up!*"

She ran. The queue closed over the place where she had been. A cold wind came up the stairs, and for a moment he could have sworn that every woman in the line had turned, very slightly, to look up the slope toward the pipal tree. Then Tilmaya clapped her hands briskly and said, "Well! This is no way to treat a guest. We must have you for tea."

And at that moment, from the temple at the centre of the village, an iron bell began to toll.

It tolled slowly, nine times. The sound rolled over the terraces like a stone rolling downhill, and as the ninth stroke died away the women at the tap set down their pots, without a word, and wiped their hands on their skirts, and began to walk. They did not hurry. They did not speak. They went up the main stair in twos and threes, like people going to a funeral, and the loud, easy gossip of five minutes before had been drained out of them as completely as water from a basin. In the doorways, other women were emerging, wrapping their shawls about them; and from the courtyards and the alleys came young girls, and old women, and a stream of mothers carrying bundles; and all of them were walking, in silence, toward the pipal tree.

"Antim," said Aashi.

"I see it."

"It's the Counting."

They followed, a little apart, at the edge of the crowd.

The pipal tree, by daylight, was less terrible and in some ways more so. It was a vast and ordinary and beautiful thing, its great grey trunk fluted like the pillar of a temple and its leaves flickering in the sunlight,

and its roots broke the earth around its base in a long knuckled spread. A low whitewashed platform ringed the trunk, and along its edge stood nine small clay lamps, unlit. At the centre of it, on the lowest bough, hung the rope. In the daylight it was a thick, ugly, ancient thing of jute and fibre, thicker than Antim's thigh at the top, and it swung very slightly, in the wind that was not there, with its empty loop turning a few feet above the ground.

The women formed a ring around the platform. There was a hush. And out of the hush came nine mothers, in red.

They were of every age. A girl of seventeen, hardly more than a child herself, with her baby clutched to her chest like a stolen thing. A solid woman of thirty-five with a face like a closed door. A very young mother who could not stop trembling. A woman with a toddler astride her hip, a stout round-eyed boy of fourteen months who stared at the tree, and at the strangers, and at the world with the uncomprehending equanimity of one who has been born into a catastrophe and does not yet know that it is unusual: Sumitra Gurung, Karna Bahadur's wife, the first. Each of them wore a red shawl. Each of them carried a boy.

They lifted the children. They lifted them high, in both hands, toward the rope, as one lifted a child to be blessed, and the babies blinked and squirmed and one of them began to wail, and they began to speak. It was not a song. It was a flat, low, measured chant, spoken by all nine at once, in the same words, in the same tone, in the same breath, with the dreadful regularity of a lesson learned by heart:

"Nau chhan, Prabhu. Nau, ra aru chhaina."

"Nine are here, Lord," Aashi whispered. "Nine, and no more."

"*Nau chhan, Prabhu. Nau, ra aru chhaina.*" And the crowd of women, standing in a wide circle, took it up in a murmur, over and over, so that it ran through them like wind through reeds, and the sunlit air of the morning seemed to thicken around it.

Antim felt his scalp creep. He thought: *They are not praying. They are making a report.*

The chant went round three times. At the third, each mother bent and tied a thread of red wool around a low root of the tree, and kissed her baby's head, and lowered it. It was done. A long breath went out of the crowd.

And out of the shadow on the far side of the pipal, on the arm of a girl in a white frock, an old woman came forward.

She was very, very old. She was tiny and bent and wrapped in a white cotton sari with a wide red border, and her hair was white and thin and drawn back in a knot, and her face was a map of ten thousand wrinkles, as soft and fine as crumpled silk. She walked on the girl's arm with a little stick, and she did not look where she was going, because she could not: her eyes were wide, and open, and as white and blank as river-stones.

"Hajurama," the woman murmured. "Hajurama. Hajurama has come."

She stopped beside the platform. She did not lift anything. She held in the crook of her left arm a small, red-wrapped bundle, close against her breast, and she rocked it, slowly, with the dreamy absent tenderness of a grandmother who has rocked a thousand, and she was humming to it under her breath.

Aashi counted. She had been trained to count. Nine mothers in red. Nine children lifted. And in the arm of the blind old woman, a tenth bundle, a red-wrapped bundle no bigger than a loaf, from which came, at long intervals, a thin and oddly even sound, more like the idea of a cry than a cry.

She turned her head very slowly and saw that Antim had counted it too.

None of the nine mothers had looked at the tenth bundle. Not one. They stood a very little apart from it, with their eyes lowered and their babies pressed to their shoulders, the way people stand at the edge of a pit.

And Hajurama turned her face, the white blind face, across the whole width of the crowd and the platform and the sunlit square, directly to where Aashi stood. She smiled. It was a sweet smile. It was the smile of a grandmother who sees a dear grandchild enter a room.

"There you are, chori," she said, in a clear, cracked, carrying voice. "I have been waiting for you. Come and sit with the women. You have had a long road, and it is cold, and you must be tired."

"Hajurama," said Antim, with great politeness, "my wife and I are travelling together —"

"Of course you are, Babu." The blind face turned toward his voice with perfect accuracy, and the old smile did not alter by a hair. "And a very good thing it is. Husband and wife should go together. But there are some rooms, you understand, where a man cannot be, and the

Mothers' Courtyard is one. It is an old custom. It is not for me to change it." She patted the girl's arm. "Before noon, no man crosses that gate. After noon, you may come for tea, and sit on the step, and be fed like a king. But *now it is for* women."

Antim looked at his wife.

He did not say *Aama said you do not separate.* He did not have to. It was in the tight set of his jaw and in the way his fingers had closed on the strap of the rucksack, and Aashi, who had lived with that face for nine years, read it as plainly as a signboard.

Forty paces, she thought. The Mothers' Courtyard was a broad gateway on the east side of the square, in the wall of the largest and oldest house in Dhuwakot, a tall house of dark wood and mud-plaster with carved lattice windows and a roof of heavy slate. Its gate stood wide open. From where she was standing, at the edge of the pipal's platform, she could see straight in: a flagged yard, a tulsi pillar, a row of women on mats. And from the courtyard, through the gate, one could see the pipal tree, and the platform, and the place where a tall man in a brown jacket would stand.

"I'll be at the tree," Antim said, very low. "In sight. If I lose sight of you for the length of one breath —"

"I know." She squeezed his hand once, hard. "Go and look at your rope."

She went across the square on Hajurama's arm, walking slowly to match the old woman's pace, with the nine mothers falling in behind, and she felt the rope above and behind her like a pair of eyes between her shoulder blades. She did not look back. At the gate she did, once, very quickly. Antim stood on the platform with his hands in his pockets, in the shadow of the great tree, looking exactly like a schoolmaster who had stopped to admire the view. He raised a hand. She went in.

❦

It was a house that had been beautiful, once, and still remembered how.

The yard was swept clean as a plate. In its centre a tulsi pillar rose out of a little plinth, bright with marigolds, a hundred of them, orange and yellow and fresh, and Aashi felt her stomach turn at the sight and did not know why, until she remembered the heap of petals in the loft.

A dozen jute mats were laid out along the walls in the sun. On the mats sat the women of Dhuwakot, thirty or forty of them, with their shawls pulled round them and their brass cups in their laps, and they looked at Aashi as she entered with open, curious, friendly faces, and she felt, with absolute certainty, that every one of them had been waiting for her.

"Sit, sit," said Hajurama. "No, not there, there's a drought. By me. By me, child."

She was installed on a low wooden stool at the old woman's right hand, in the best of the sun. A brass glass of tea was pressed into her hands. It was sweet milky tea, steaming, with a scatter of ginger on the surface, and the smell that rose from it, ginger and tulsi and woodsmoke and something faint under them, a green bitterness like crushed stalks, struck her nose and went down into her chest and stayed.

She held the glass and did not drink.

On a quilt at Hajurama's feet, in a neat row, lay the nine babies.

It was a very sweet sight, and she felt it in her heart even as the skin on her arms prickled. The mothers had set them down in the sun, side by side, like loaves on a baker's shelf, nine little boys in nine red wraps, and they kicked and gurgled and stared at the sky. The youngest could not have been three weeks old. The oldest, Sumitra's, was sitting up and gnawing at the edge of a wooden spoon. And on the left wrist of every one of them, finer than a bracelet, tied with a tiny and elaborate knot, was a loop of red rope.

"They are beautiful," Aashi said, and it came out almost steady.

"They are the village," said Hajurama simply. "They are all we have."

She had not put down the tenth bundle. It lay in her lap, in the crook of her arm, and she stroked it absently with one thin finger as she spoke. Aashi did not look at it. She had made up her mind that she would not look at it until she had to.

"Now," said the old woman, "you have come a long way, and you are a guest in my house, and I will not ask you to say why. I am an old woman. I do not need to be told. Tilmaya, bring the girl a shawl, she is shivering. But if you wish to ask *us* anything, chori, you must ask. It is the way. A guest is entitled to her questions."

It was an opening so perfect, so graceful, that Aashi, for a moment, could not use it. She felt rather as she had when she was twelve and had

been invited to play chess with her uncle, a judge of the district court and a ferocious chess player, who had set up the pieces and said, with a kind smile: *Black or white, chori?*

"I am only a schoolmaster's wife," she said at last. "But I could not help hearing in the bazaar, in Bhanjyang, that this village had known great sorrow. And I thought, perhaps, that I might sit with the women who had borne it. I am no use to anyone. But I have always thought that it helps, a little, to be told by someone who is a stranger."

It was a very good speech. She watched it go down into the circle of women like a stone dropped in a well, and she saw, in the long moment before the answering ripple, a few of the faces, a very few, softened with the sudden, unguarded gratitude of people who have not been asked.

Then Sumitra Gurung took her son's wooden spoon from his fist and put it aside and said, in a flat, clear, practised voice: "My husband went out to see the cattle, and the mist took him."

A murmur ran around the mats.

"*My* husband," said the girl of seventeen, in the same voice, on the same breath, as though it were the next line in a hymn, "went out to see the cattle, and the mist took him."

"My husband went out to see to the cattle —"

"— and the mist took him."

"— and the mist —"

They went on, one after another, around the circle, all nine, each in her turn, each in the same words, the same measure, the same slight pause before *the mist*, the same small descending fall of the voice on *him*. It was not a mourning chorus. It was not even a lie, exactly. It was a lesson, learned by heart and recited for an inspector. And Aashi, sitting very still with the glass between her palms, felt something go cold and quiet and clear in the back of her mind, the particular cold and quiet that comes to a good investigator at the exact moment she understands she is being handled.

She had read Sub-Inspector Thapa's report three times. She could have recited it. *Karna Bahadur Gurung was seated on the porch of his house at the time of the birth, in company with his elder son Bishal, aged eight, as attested by the midwife Dhanmaya Tamang. A glass of rakshi. A school slate.* There had been no cattle. There was no

cattle-shed behind the Gurung house, and there had not been for years, for Karna Bahadur had been a carpenter.

"You keep cattle, then?" she said gently to the girl of seventeen.

"What?"

"Your husband went out to see the cattle. I only wondered how many you keep."

The girl's mouth opened. She looked down the line. She looked, Aashi noticed, not at Hajurama, who sat with her sightless face tilted up in the sun and her smile in place, but at Tilmaya Gurung, who had just come back across the yard with a shawl, and who had stopped in the middle of the flagstones with her broad back stiff as a post.

"We — no," said the girl. "We had a — a goat."

"A *goat*," said Tilmaya sharply, coming forward, throwing the shawl over Aashi's shoulders with a rough kindness. "Of course a goat. Do not trouble the poor child with questions, Didi, she has been out of her mind with grief since the winter. She says what she remembers. Drink your tea."

"Yes," said Hajurama comfortably. "Drink your tea, chori. It is ginger and tulsi, it is for the cold. We make it every morning."

From the tenth bundle came that thin, even sound again, a cry that did not rise or catch or break as a real infant's does. Hajurama's hand moved over it, and it stopped.

Aashi felt a small, hot, urgent hand slide into hers beneath the fold of the shawl.

It was Pabitra. Aashi had not heard her approach: she had come from behind, through the forest of skirts, a skinny girl of sixteen in a faded blue frock with her hair in one long plait and a face like a startled deer, and she had squeezed herself in between Aashi's stool and the wall, and was pressing her shoulder against Aashi's arm with the earnest ferocity of a girl who has decided, on no evidence, to trust.

"Didi," she breathed, with her mouth to Aashi's elbow, so quietly that it was only a movement of air. "Didi, the ones with the hats."

Aashi did not turn her head. "What about them?"

"Hajurama gave them tea." A tiny shiver ran through the small body. "In the big pot, the *brass* pot. And she sang. And they drank two glasses, the fat one even three, and they went all sleepy and *smiley*, and they let the aunties walk them up the hill. Singing. Like at a wedding." The fingers tightened. "Didi. Don't."

"*Pabitra!*"

It was Sumitra's voice, sharp as a slap. The child went rigid. Then she was gone from Aashi's side as though plucked out by an invisible hand, and was standing in the middle of the yard with her head hanging and her hands behind her back, while Tilmaya Gurung looked at her with the broad bland tolerant stare of a woman who has decided that a child is only a child.

"She is a dreamer, that one," said Tilmaya comfortably. "She makes up stories. She tells the little ones that the tree has eyes. Drink, Didi."

Aashi lifted the brass glass to her lips. The tea touched her mouth, hot and sweet. She did not swallow it. She held it behind her teeth for the space of three heartbeats, and then, under cover of the shawl, bent her head as if to cough, and let it run quietly down into the folds of the wool.

"It is very good," she said, and put the glass down on the mat beside her. "I think I will not finish it. I am rather — I have not been well on the road. It disagrees with —"

She stopped. It was too late. She had heard what she had been about to say, and the whole courtyard had heard it too, for no one in it had made a sound.

"— with the little one," said Hajurama.

She said it kindly. She said it as one finishes a sentence for a friend. And then she reached out, with that sure unerring blind hand, and laid her palm flat on the front of Aashi's shawl, over the low flat place below her navel, and let it rest there.

The hand was very dry. It was very light. It felt like a leaf.

"*Ah*," said Hajurama. And the smile on her wrinkled face did not change at all, and yet something behind the smile changed entirely, as when a lamp is carried slowly past a window. "Seven weeks. Perhaps eight. Nine years of waiting, and the gods have their little joke." She patted the shawl, twice, affectionately. "A boy, I think. Yes. A *boy*. I am seldom wrong."

Somebody on the mats gave a stifled gasp. A brass cup rang on a stone. And all about her Aashi saw the faces of the women of Dhuwakot turn, in a single slow rippling movement, from smiling to something else: the faces of the nine mothers, which became abruptly white, with the dreadful naked stare of people who have just seen a fire start in the next house; and the faces of the other women, the aunts and

cousins and sisters on the mats, which did not turn white at all, but grew very still, and bright, and *hungry.*

"A carrying woman," whispered Tilmaya. "At the lamp-lighting hour. In *Dhuwakot.*"

"Hush." Hajurama smiled. "She is a guest."

"It will be a *son*, Hajurama. It will —"

"I said, hush, Tilmaya." The old voice did not rise. It did not need to. "She is a daughter of this house until she leaves it. And she must not go," said Hajurama, turning her blind face to Aashi with infinite gentleness, "up that cold hill tonight. Not in her condition. She will stay with us. She will have the best bed in the Mothers' House, by the fire, with the babies, and nobody will trouble her. Her husband may sleep where he likes." The cracked voice was warm as honey. "Husbands are not required."

You do not separate, said a voice in Aashi's head, with the force of a slammed door.

She rose to her feet. She did it quite slowly. She was a police officer, and the skill that every officer learns before any other is how to stand up in a room in which she is no longer free to leave.

"You are very kind, Hajurama," she said. "But my husband is waiting for me at the gate."

"He can wait."

"He will not," said Aashi. "He will come and look for me. He is a schoolmaster. They are very persistent men."

For a long moment nobody moved. From the pipal tree, forty paces off, came the faint dry whisper of its leaves.

Then Hajurama laughed. It was a delighted, silvery, girlish laugh, wholly without malice, and it broke the tension of the yard as a bubble breaks. "Ah, you have spirit! She has spirit, Tilmaya. That is good. That is very good. One needs it, for a son."

Aashi took the opening, because it would not come again. "Hajurama, forgive me. The little one in your lap. Whose child is she? I counted nine mothers this morning, and I did not see one of them look at her."

The thin finger that had been stroking the bundle stopped.

"Ah," said Hajurama, in a tone as light as thistledown. "She is not a child for questions, chori. She is delicate." And she rose, quite suddenly for one so old, and the girl in the white frock sprang to take her arm,

and she gathered the red bundle against her breast and said, “She must be fed. You will excuse an old woman.” She went through a low door at the back of the yard, into a room Aashi had not noticed, and the door was drawn shut behind her.

The yard waited. From behind the planks came small sounds: the clink of a brass cup, the scrape of a spoon, a humming that rose and fell, and Hajurama’s voice murmuring endearments in the sing-song of one who has said them ten thousand times. *There, there, my little one. Drink. Drink.* But there was no cry, and no small greedy sound of feeding, and Aashi, who had listened for it with her whole body, felt the skin tighten along her arms.

Nobody on the mats looked at the door. That was how she knew that all of them were listening to it.

“Whose is it?” she murmured to Tilmaya, who had come to stand at her shoulder with the air of a woman guarding a pot on the boil.

“Nobody asks, Didi.” The reply was low and quick, and for the first time there was no laughter anywhere in it. “A woman asked once. Fourteen months that child has been in that room, or ten, or two, depending on whom you ask, and the nine who have borne boys have never been called in. Not one. Sunita, who is Hajurama’s own sister’s daughter, says she has never seen a cradle carried in or a cloth carried out.” A small, fierce glance at the shut door. “Do you think we have not wondered? We have wondered every night. We have only learned not to wonder aloud.”

On the mats, an old woman touched her fingers to her forehead and bent her head over her cup as though she had not heard.

The door opened. Hajurama came out as she had gone in, the bundle in the crook of her arm, the cloth drawn so close about its head that not a curl, not a cheek, not a fold of skin showed anywhere. She settled herself on her stool with a little sigh. “There,” she said. “Asleep. She is a good child. She is a very quiet child.”

“May I see her?” said Aashi. “Only for a moment. I have waited nine years to hold a baby.”

“Later, chori. When she wakes.” Hajurama was already rising. “She needs her milk warmed. These things take time.” And again the little procession of old woman and girl and bundle crossed the yard, and again the door shut, and again the humming began, and the brass cup rang on the stone. When it came out the second time, the bundle was a

little differently wrapped, and Aashi, watching it, understood with a cold, clear certainty that she would not be shown its face, not today, and that it did not matter how many times she asked.

She did not ask a third time. She sat quite still with her hands in her lap, and counted the minutes by the sun on the flagstones, and when Hajurama returned and lowered herself onto the stool beside her, she let the old woman take her hand.

"You are a clever girl," said Hajurama, and the sweetness had gone out of her voice and something plainer and much older had come into it. She waved her free hand at the yard, and the women on the mats rose without a word and drifted to the far wall, as water drained from a basin. "Clever, and brave, and you have a good husband waiting at my gate. So I will tell you a thing that I have not told any policeman, and I tell it to you as one mother to another. Tell your husband also."

Aashi did not move.

"The Lord is real, chori." The blind face was turned straight toward her, quite still. "I know how it sounds. I know that in your city you laugh at such things. But He is real, and He is angry. He has been angry for a very long time, and He is not a thing that is sorry. I was a girl, not much older than that Pabitra, and I was told, as all girls are told, *do not look at Him when the rope is moving.* I looked." The hand in Aashi's tightened a little, and then loosened. "He did not kill me. That would have been a kindness. He took my eyes, and left me the rest, so that I could have a long life in which to remember."

The courtyard had gone entirely silent. Somewhere beyond the wall, the pipal's leaves whispered.

"I am not asking you to like me," Hajurama said. "I am an old woman, and I have done things in this village that I will answer for, one day, to someone more patient than you. But I am asking you to go home. Take your good husband and go down to Bhanjyang while the light holds. Whatever a schoolmaster is looking for, it is not worth the little one you carry." She patted the hand, twice, and her smile, when it came, was one of such simple and uncomplicated kindness that Aashi was nearly ashamed of what she had been thinking. "There is jaggery in my pocket. Take some. It is good for the road."

It was wrapped in a twist of paper. It was warm from the old woman's skin. Aashi took it, because she could think of no way not to.

On her right wrist, under the sleeve, Aama's red thread went faintly warm, and then cool again, and she could not decide what either meant.

"Thank you, Hajurama," she said. "You are very kind."

"I am not kind," said the old woman, quite gently. "I am only old. Go, chori, a mother never keeps a bird against its will. But if you will not go home," and the blank white eyes followed her across the yard, "then come back to us by the lamp-lighting hour. We will have a bed. They always do."

❦

Antim had been staring at the rope for twenty minutes, and it had not once looked back at him.

That was something. He stood on the whitewashed platform at the foot of the pipal, in the dappled light, with his hands behind his back and his eyes lifted, in the pose of a man who is admiring an ancient tree, and he was careful not to look too long at the courtyard gate. He knew exactly where it was. He had known it every moment, as one knows where a sore tooth is: forty paces east, a dark rectangle in a wall, with sunlight in it and women's voices.

Around him the square was emptying. The mothers had gone, and the crowd had broken into twos and threes and drifted back to the day's work, and now only a few old women remained, sitting on the temple steps shelling peas into brass bowls, and a small boy doing nothing in particular with a stick. Nobody was watching him. That, too, he did not believe.

The rope hung before him. Close up, in daylight, it was both much less and much more than it had seemed in the torchlight. It was an old hemp-and-jute rope, grey with weather, as thick at the shoulder as a man's thigh, and it came down out of the bough in one great curve and ended in a loop of its own thickness that hung a little above the height of his head. It smelled of rain and dust and, very faintly, of marigold. And all along it, from the bough down to the loop, thick as the beads on a rosary, ran *knots*.

He had not understood what the knots would mean until he stood beneath them.

They were big, hard, ugly knots, each tied in the same way: a long coil of the rope pulled through itself in a loop and drawn tight, with a

lock of black hair bound into the heart of each. He tried to count them. He reached the first fifty, and the second, and gave up somewhere around three hundred, when the rope rose out of reach into the foliage and the knots went on above him, up into the leaves, older and darker and more swollen, until they were hardly knots at all, only great black fists of fibre that had been tied over and over by hands that had been dust for a century.

A rope for a son. Seven generations of sons. He thought of the old women of Dhuwakot tying them, year after year, with the cold dry mechanical competence of women baking bread.

The newest were at the bottom. He crouched to look, and found nine of them in a row, small and tight and pale, with the fibre still green in the twist. At the heart of each, instead of black hair, was a wisp so fine and so light that it moved in the faint draught of his breath: the pale down of a baby's head.

He put out his hand. He had not meant to. The rope was warm.

It was not the warmth of a rope in the sun. He knew that warmth; he had stood on the parade ground at Bhanjyang for twenty years in the sun, and ropes grew hot and dry in it. This was a different warmth, damp and low and even, the warmth of a body, and under his fingertips, as he laid them against the lowest of the nine new knots, he felt, very faintly, as one feels a pulse through a wrist, a slow regular tick.

Tick. A long pause. *Tick.*

He took his hand away so fast that it hurt.

For half a minute he simply stood there with his heart hammering, in the bright cold sunshine, and told himself with all the energy of twenty years' training that rope can carry the pulse of the hand that holds it; that he had touched it with a hand that was frightened; that a man who has not slept and has dreamed of his father hanging from a bridge may find a heartbeat in any object he cares to name. It was a perfectly good argument. It was only that it did not account for the fact that his fingers, when he looked at them, had left a faint dark print on the knot, as if the rope had been *wet.*

"*Sahib.*"

It was the boy with the stick.

He had come up without a sound, a small boy of perhaps six with a shaven head and enormous ears, and he stood now at the corner of the platform and regarded Antim with the large round unblinking solemnity

that small boys bring to the gravest matters. “Sahib,” he said, in a piping whisper, “you must not touch the rope. It does not like it.”

“I’m sorry,” said Antim, gravely. “I did not know.”

“It likes the whistles, though.”

Antim went very still. “The whistles?”

The boy pointed, with his stick, upward and to the left.

At the far side of the great bough, half hidden in the leaves, where the rope swung out of the tree, there grew a low branch of the pipal, a dark, thick, knuckled limb that Antim had taken for a part of the tree. It was not bare. It was hung with *things*. They turned a little in the light, glinting. They were small, and brass, and they were arranged along the branch in a row, tied to it by lengths of red wool at even distances, like the ornaments on a festival tree.

He stepped around the trunk. He stood on tiptoe. He did not need to count.

There were eleven.

They were the standard issue of the Nepal Police, the little brass whistle on a loop of cord that every constable wore at his breast, with the crown and the crossed khukuris stamped on the barrel; and on each, stamped smaller beneath the crown, a number. He knew those numbers. He knew them as he knew his own name, because he had signed for every one in the quartermaster’s register at Bhanjyang, and sent every one up the hill. Thapa. Rai. The two from Kathmandu. Six constables he had known by name. Pandey’s was at the very end of the row, a heavier whistle, a superior’s whistle, with a chain instead of a cord, and when he reached up and put out his hand to touch it, the little brass tube felt, strangely, *stiff*, as though something had been pushed up inside the barrel.

He worked it out with his thumbnail. It came free with a small dry sound, rolled tight as a cigarette and not much thicker, a strip of thin paper curled to fit the bore.

He unrolled it with his back to the square. It was a page torn from a notebook, in a firm, square, familiar hand, a hand that had once written him a commendation on a badly typed form, and it said:

Day 3. Nine mothers, nine stories, the same words, the same stumble. “He went out to see the cattle.” Karna Gurung was a carpenter, kept no cattle. The Rai woman’s husband was a tailor. They have been TAUGHT it. Someone is teaching them. The old blind

woman, the one they call Hajurama, serves the tea herself, from a brass pot, and sings while she pours. I have not drunk it. Tomorrow I will. I think that I must. If I do not write again, whoever finds this:

It is not the tree. It is what the tree is TIED to.

Follow the knots. They are tied by women's hands. — D.P.

He read it twice. Then he folded it very small, and put it in the inner pocket of his jacket, and stood for a time with his face turned up to the leaves and the whistles shining in them, and the small boy with the stick watched him in perfect silence.

"They were very polite, the policemen," the boy said at last. "They said *thank you* for the tea."

Antim looked down. The child's face was serious and entirely innocent.

"And what is *your* name?" Antim said.

"Ram," said the boy. "But you must not tell Hajurama what I said."

"I will not." He crouched, so that their eyes were level. "Ram, I want to ask you something, and I want an honest answer. Why are you out here alone?"

"It is daytime," said Ram, as if to a slow child. "In the day we can go anywhere. Baba is in the field, and my brother is at the school. We must be home when the bell rings the second time, and then we bar the door, and Baba sits against it with the khukuri." He shrugged his small shoulders. "That is how it is."

Antim looked at the shaven head and the enormous ears and the stick, and thought of eleven letters he had signed, and of how each of them had begun with the word *regret.* "Then listen carefully," he said, very gently. "You told me about the whistles. That was brave, and I will not forget it. But I want you to promise me something. You are not to be a hero. Not this week, and not when you are older. If anyone asks you to look at the tree, or to follow them up the hill, or to find out what the grown-ups will not say, you do not. You go home. You bar the door. You stay alive. That is all anyone needs from you."

"Even if I am not afraid?"

"Especially then. The brave ones are the ones I have had to write letters about."

The boy considered this with great solemnity. Then he held up his little finger, as hill children do, and Antim, after a moment, hooked it with his own.

"I promise, sahib," said Ram, and having settled that, regarded him a moment longer. "Your wife is coming. She is walking very fast. She does not look happy."

Antim spun.

Aashi came across the square at a pace just short of a run, with her shawl clutched round her shoulders and her face the colour of paper, and when she reached the platform she caught his sleeve in both hands and held on, and for a moment she did not say anything at all. He took her by the elbows. He felt her trembling.

"Say it," he said.

"Not here." The words were almost soundless. "Not with the tree *listening.* Antim, they know. The old woman knows. She put her hand on me and she — and the baby she will not let anyone see —" Her voice cracked and she stopped, and swallowed, and drew a breath, and when she spoke again it was in a whisper so level that it frightened him more than her tears would have done. "They gave policemen tea, Antim. In a brass pot. They sang to them. And walked them up the hill like a wedding party."

"I know," said Antim.

She stared at him.

He took the folded page from his pocket and put it into her hand.

She read it standing there beside the roots of the tree, in the thin morning sunshine, with the whistles ringing faintly overhead in a wind that was not there. When she had finished she shut her eyes. "*Follow the knots,*" she said. "*They are tied by women's hands.*"

"Yes."

"And she warned me," Aashi said slowly. "At the end. Kindly, Antim, like somebody's grandmother. She said the Lord is real, that He is angry, that He took her eyes, and that we should go home to Bhanjyang while the light holds. She said to tell you."

"A kind warning," said Antim, "from the woman who poured the tea."

"She meant it. That is the part I cannot make fit." Aashi looked down at the page again. "Unless it is possible to be afraid of a thing and feed it anyway." Her eyes opened, and there was something in them, a kind of terrible clarity, that he had seen only a few times before, once in the witness box of the district court and once across a kitchen table the night before they left Bhanjyang. "They aren't the victims. Some of

them are. But not all, and not the old one. She is afraid of it, Antim, and I think she is *feeding* it anyway."

"Then the first thing we do," said Antim, slowly, "is go back up the hill."

"The first thing we do," said Aashi, "is go together. And we won't separate again."

"Not for one breath."

"Not for one breath," she agreed, and put her arm through his, and they walked back across the square together, past the old women on the temple steps who did not look up from their peas, and the small boy with the stick who watched them go; past the pipal, past the swinging, patient, listening rope, and up the stair toward the shelf where the kinnar's house stood, in the full sun, in the cold, with the long day ahead of them and, behind them, one by one, the watching faces drawing back from the doorways.

The kinnar listened to all of it without once interrupting, sitting very straight on the stone bench with the clay cup cooling in their hands, and when Aashi came to the part about the tenth bundle the long grave face did something that she had not seen it do in a night and a morning. It lost its composure.

"A tenth," the kinnar said. "You are certain."

"Nine mothers. Nine babies in a row on the quilt. And one in her lap."

"I have walked past that house every night for fourteen months." The voice was very low. "I have heard a thin sound in it at night. I thought it was a child crying, one of the nine, though it never changed. A real child's cry changes. I thought —" The scarred hand closed on the cup until the clay creaked. "I did not count. Twenty-nine I have counted, every night, and I never once thought to count the *babies*."

"Whose is it?" said Antim.

"I do not know." The kinnar set the cup down very carefully, as though it might break. "I know only that Rukmini is the name of the first widow who spoke to the tree, and that the eldest of the mothers has always taken that name, one after another, for seven generations, and that the one you call Hajurama has kept the knots for longer than I have been alive. She taught me my first song. She was kind to me when I came down from the swing." A silence. "She put a blanket around me. I remember it was red."

Nobody spoke. Down in the village, very small and clear in the afternoon stillness, a woman was calling a child in to eat.

"*It is not the tree. It is what the tree is tied to,*" Antim said at last. He had unfolded Pandey's page and was holding it flat against his knee. "I have been thinking about that line for an hour. A rope is tied at both ends. We have all been looking at the loop, at the end that hangs. I would like very much to see what is at the other end."

"The Throat," said Aashi.

"The Throat." He folded the page again. "He knew, Aashi. Pandey knew exactly what he was doing. He drank that tea on purpose, and let them walk him up the hill, because he wanted to see where they were taking him. He saluted it. He was a decent man, and a brave one, and I sent him there with a form and a stamp." He drew a breath. "I would like to finish what he started."

"Then eat," said the kinnar, rising, and with that sudden tenderness of the very frightened, which expresses itself in feeding, they went indoors and began to bang pots.

❦

It was, Aashi would think afterwards, the strangest afternoon of her life, and one of the happiest.

There was dal-bhat, hot and plain, with a spoonful of ghee that the kinnar produced from a sealed pot at the back of the shelf and refused to explain. There was a dish of potatoes fried with fenugreek and a dry red chutney that took the skin off the roof of the mouth. They ate cross-legged on the floor with their fingers, in the thin gold light that came through the one open shutter, and for an hour there was almost nothing to remember but the taste of the food and the small domestic sounds of three people sharing a meal. Antim, who had eaten nothing but sel roti since the dawn of the world, put away three platefuls and was scolded for it, and then scolded for stopping. The kinnar, it emerged, was a tyrant in a kitchen. They stood over Aashi with the ladle like a mother-in-law in a film, saying: "Eat. Eat. You are eating for two." And then, hearing themselves, stopped, and flushed to the roots of the grey-streaked hair, and said, "Forgive me. That is a thing one says," and Aashi laughed until she cried.

"Sit," said the kinnar, when the plates were cleared. "Here, by the door, in the light. Take down your hair."

"What for?"

"Because you cannot go into a place like that with your hair loose. It is a habit of my grandmother's." The pale eyes were gentle. "She used to say that a woman's hair is the first thing that any rope will reach for. You will be braided close, and tight, and pinned. I will do it. I have done it for the brides."

So Aashi sat on the sill with her back to the sun and her hair falling over her shoulders, and the kinnar stood behind her with a wooden comb, and began, slowly and expertly, to draw the long black strands into three. It was a very old and very intimate thing, and Aashi, who had not had her hair braided by another person since she was a child, found that her eyes had filled again.

"They used to love me, you know," said the kinnar, behind her, in the voice of one remarking on the weather. "In the old days. Before the swing, I was only a strange child. After it I was a luck-piece. At every wedding they called me to bless the bride, and at every birth I sang. When Sumitra's boy was born, she was the one who put the red thread on my wrist." The comb paused. "It was the same thread Hajurama put on all of them. I wore it for a year. It was only in the winter that I began to understand that I should not."

"What changed?"

"The women began to look at me." The comb moved on. "Not unkindly. They still leave me the milk. But they began to look at me, in the doorways, as if I were a thing that had been *left over*. I think they had begun to understand that the Lord could not take me because I was not worth the taking. And that is not the same as being loved." A tug, a twist, a pin. "I do not tell you this to be pitied. I tell you because it is the thing I most wished somebody had told me, when I was young."

"What?"

"That, it is a very lonely thing to be the question." The kinnar set the last pin and laid both hands, for a moment, on Aashi's shoulders. "And that one may be the answer, if one lives long enough."

Antim, sitting across the room with the revolver in pieces on a cloth, said nothing at all, but he put down the oily rag and looked at the two of them, and Aashi saw his face, and loved him for it.

They went through it all, in the long gold hour before the light began to go.

The kinnar laid it out on the floor like a lesson in a schoolroom, with a stub of charcoal and the flat of a slate, as methodical and patient as a teacher with a dull class and a long examination. It was simple, and dreadful in its simplicity. There was a lamp: a plain little clay saucer with a spout, filled to the brim with mustard oil and trimmed with a twist of cotton wick, which would burn, if it was shielded from the wind, for the length of time between sunset and the first full dark. It was to be lit from the kinnar's own lantern at the mouth of the Throat. It would be carried between them in both hands, low, at the height of the waist. It was to be kept alight at any cost.

"The lamp is what tells the rope which way is *down*," said the kinnar. "I do not know why. It is what the old women said, and the old women were not fools. A rope hangs. A rope has an end, and the end is a weight, and that is how it finds you. But a lamp has a *direction.* A flame points up. Whatever is in that place will try to turn you, to make you think that up is down and down is up, and the flame is the one thing in the dark that will not agree." The charcoal scratched a small upright line. "Keep your eyes on it. Do not look up. Do not look behind you. Whatever you hear, whoever speaks, you look at the flame."

There were two small leather pouches of pitho, rice-flour and lime and salt and ashes, which they were to scatter in a ring around themselves if the lamp should fail. There was a cord of fresh red thread for each wrist, to be tied at the cliff, tied with the kinnar's own knots, which were not like the knots on the rope; the kinnar spent a long time showing Antim the difference, how the loop ran back on itself and closed, so that the thread had no loose end. There was salt. There was a small clay pot of water from the spring. And there was the revolver, reassembled and loaded.

"Take it," the kinnar said. "It will make you feel like yourself. That is worth something. It will not make the smallest difference to what is in there, but a man who has lost the feeling of being himself is lost already."

"And this?" Aashi was holding a short curved knife with a plain wooden handle, in a leather sheath.

"A khukuri. My father's. It is not for the Lord. It is for the rope, if the rope should ever take you by the ankle." The kinnar's mouth tightened. "Cut. Do not stop to think."

Antim took the knife from her, and looked at it, and slid it into his belt behind the revolver.

"There is one more thing," said the kinnar. "The most important."

They had come to the end of the slate. The charcoal had worn down to a stub. The kinnar set it aside, and turned, and took Antim's hand in their left and Aashi's in their right, and brought them together, palm to palm, fingers lacing, and closed their own two hands over the knot.

"A rope needs an open end," the kinnar said. "That is its whole nature. It is not a thing that exists in a circle. It is a line, with a beginning and an end, and that is why it can *hang* a thing: because it can be thrown over a branch and drawn tight. But a ring, a closed ring, has no end for it to take." The pale eyes were steady. "I do not know whether it is true. I have never seen it tried. But I know what my grandmother told me, and I know that my grandmother's mother tied her husband's hand to her own for the whole of the Dashain, and neither of them was ever taken. Do not let go. Not for a step. Not for a breath. Not if you are frightened. Not if you are *certain*. You hold each other's hands in that place as you would hold the edge of a cliff."

Aashi looked at Antim. He looked at her. Their joined hands lay in the kinnar's, warm and tight, and she thought of Aama's brusque voice in the kitchen, and the tiny hot print of a small hand on her husband's wrist.

A husband and a wife go up together, and they come down together.

"Yes," she said. "We understand."

"Then there is nothing more to teach." The kinnar released them, and sat back on their heels, and for a moment the whole long grave body sagged, and they looked very tired, and very old, and very young. "Rest. Both of you. Sleep for an hour if you can. I will wake you."

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They did not sleep.

They lay side by side on the sleeping-platform in the amber light, with their hands joined between them on the quilt, and listened to the

sounds of the kinnar in the yard: the scrape of a broom, the clink of a pot, the low murmur of someone saying a prayer or a list.

"Aashi," said Antim.

"Hm."

"If it is a boy —" He stopped. His voice was a little unsteady. "I have been thinking. I would like to call him Subodh. For Baba. If you do not mind."

She turned her head. His face, in the low light, was very young. "And if it's a girl?"

"Then I would like to call her Aama." He smiled, quite helplessly. "You see the difficulty. We should have to explain to my mother that she has been *replaced*."

She laughed, and it hurt, and she laid her forehead against his shoulder. "She will say it is a very silly name."

"She will cry for a week. And then she will not allow anybody else to say it."

They lay in silence for a while.

"I was afraid," Aashi said, "that you would say we should turn back. When I told you. On the path."

"I did say it."

"You said it *once*." She lifted her head and looked at him. "And then you walked up the rest of the mountain beside me. And you didn't say it again. That is the kindest thing anyone has ever done for me."

He turned his face against her hair. "I would be very grateful," he said, rather thickly, "if you would not die in a cave. I have thought about it a good deal, and I find I cannot do without you."

"I will do my best," said Aashi.

"Together," he said.

"Together."

Outside, the shadows of the pines had begun to lengthen across the stones. Somewhere far down in the village a door closed. And then another. And then, one by one, down the whole length of the hill, all of them.

❦

They went up at five o'clock, at the last of the light.

It was Wednesday, the second day of their journey, and the sky over the western ridge had turned the colour of a ripe peach, with a long bar of violet cloud lying along the horizon like a bruise. The wind had dropped. The mist, which had lain all day in the gorge, was beginning to climb, slowly, in pale strands, up the sides of the terraces, and it seemed to Aashi that the whole mountain had drawn in a breath and was holding it.

The kinnar walked ahead, with the lantern lit and the clay lamp in the crook of one arm, in the long charcoal coat, with the shawl pulled over the head and the muffler loose about the throat. They did not look back. Behind them came Antim and Aashi, hand in hand, in a single file where the path was narrow and side by side where it widened, and neither of them said a word.

They went down through the village, because there was no other path to the cliff.

It was empty. It was more than empty; it was *shuttered.* Every door was closed, every window boarded, and from behind each of them came the faint, dry sounds of a great many people trying very hard not to be heard: the shift of a foot, the creak of a floorboard, the low mutter of a man's prayer cut short, once, the choked cough of a child hastily smothered. At the Mothers' Courtyard the gate stood open. It was the only door in Dhuwakot that did.

Hajurama was standing in it.

She stood quite alone, small and white and upright in the shadow of the gateway, with her stick in one hand and the red bundle in the crook of the other arm. Nobody held her. She did not need to be held. The blank white eyes were turned out across the square, to where the three of them were passing the foot of the pipal, and she did not move, and she did not speak. She only lifted her free hand, slowly, with the palm outward, in the gesture of a grandmother blessing a grandchild on a long road, and held it there.

Aashi felt the red thread on her wrist go warm.

"Do not look at her," said the kinnar, very quietly, without turning. "Look at the tree."

She looked at the tree. It stood alone at the heart of the square in the failing light, vast and dark against the peach-coloured sky, and from the lowest bough the rope hung straight down, with its loop of nothing, perfectly still. The whistles had stopped turning. And on the platform at

the foot of it, in the very place where Antim had stood, she saw a row of small things she had not seen in the morning: nine tiny clay lamps, set in a line, each with a wick. Not one of them was lit.

They went on past it, and up. The stairs narrowed. The roofs fell away below them, and the path wound back out over the shelf where the kinnar's little house sat in its ring of white powder, and beyond the house, where no path had been before, a goat-track climbed across the open hillside in long zigzags toward the cliff.

It took them twenty minutes. The wind had gone, and the silence was so complete that Aashi could hear the small noises of their own climbing, the scrape of boots on stone, the tick of a pebble rolling away, her husband's slow, deep breathing; and under them, deeper and fainter, the sound she had not noticed until now, like the first thought of a sound, so low that it was felt in the bones before it was heard. It was a creak. It was the creak of a very long rope.

It was coming out of the mountain.

"Nearly there," said the kinnar.

The cliff stood before them. Close to, it was far greater than it had looked from below, a grey and broken wall that went up and up and leaned out above their heads, and at its foot, a few paces off, the Hanging Rock jutted from the face like a vast pale palm. In its shadow the earth was bare and dry and strewn with small white stones, and the grass did not grow there. The kinnar stopped, and set down the lantern, and tied the fresh red cords at their wrists with the knots that had no loose end, and turned to face the west.

The sun was a hand's breadth above the ridge.

"Watch," they said.

They watched. At first there was nothing but the long golden light coming level across the hillside, throwing every stone and tussock into relief; and then, from the square a quarter of a mile below, a shadow began to climb.

It was the shadow of the pipal tree.

It was enormous. It had begun at the root, a black stain on the stones of the square, and now it ran up the hill toward them across roofs and terraces and the open slope, climbing as the sun went down, and the shadow of the swing's long rope trailed from its branch like a single thin black line, swaying, though no wind blew. It crossed the shelf. It crossed the white ring of the kinnar's house, and passed through it as if

the powder were not there. It reached the foot of the cliff, and raced up the grey rock, and the tip of the rope-shadow reached the Hanging Rock and touched the dark vertical crack beneath it.

And the rock sighed.

It was the sound of a very large animal letting out a breath. There was no grinding of stone, no groan of hinge; the crack simply *widened.* It opened along its length, slowly, like a lip parting, until it was wider than a doorway and taller than a man. A breath of air came out of it, cold, damp, and heavy with a smell of marigolds, rope and old earth. It lifted the loose ends of Aashi's braid. And inside, in the dark, as the last of the sunlight slanted in over their shoulders, she saw a stair.

It was a narrow stair, cut in the living rock, and it went down. Its walls were carved. Rows and rows of rope had been chiselled into the stone, endless interwoven loops and coils and knots, running down into the dark like a vast stone braid, and at the top of the stair, on the lintel, someone had carved a single crude figure with its head bowed on its chest and its arms hanging at its sides, and on its face, worn almost smooth by two centuries of damp, was a smile.

"The hour of the lamp," said the kinnar, in a strange, flat voice. "It is open. We have the length of one burning."

The kinnar knelt. With hands that shook only a little, the kinnar lifted the glass of the lantern and touched the wick of the little clay lamp to its flame, and the lamp caught, and burned, a steady yellow tongue the size of a thumbnail. The kinnar rose and put it into Aashi's hands, and Antim cupped his own around hers, and together they held it between them, low, at the height of the waist, as they had been taught.

"I will keep the lantern here," said the kinnar, "at the mouth. If the door begins to close, I will call. If I call, you will hear. If you hear me, you come back, and you do not stop." The pale eyes went from one face to the other. "When my lantern burns down, the door shuts. I do not know what happens to those who are inside when it does."

"We'll be out before that," said Antim.

"I know you will." It was said with great firmness, and it was not quite a lie. The kinnar smiled, and it was the smile of the morning, quick and unexpected and brave, and then the long body bent and the scarred arms went round Aashi in a brief, fierce embrace that smelled of woodsmoke and mustard oil and cold air. "Go with the Mothers'

blessing,” they said into her hair, “the real ones, not hers. And come back.”

“I will come back,” said Aashi.

She stepped away. She and Antim stood together at the mouth of the Throat, with the lamp between them and the stair dropping away at their feet into the dark, and the cold air blowing up past them from the deep places of the mountain, and the creak of rope, very slow, very far down, keeping time. Her left hand was locked round her husband’s right. She felt his palm, hard and warm and dry, and the steady pulse in his wrist, and the whole familiar weight of him at her side.

“Together,” said Antim.

“Together,” said Aashi.

They went in.

The last sunlight slid off the stone behind them. The carved ropes in the walls seemed to stir as the little flame passed by, and for a moment, behind her, Aashi heard the kinnar’s voice calling some word she could not catch. Then the Throat drew its breath, and the dark closed over their heads, and there was nothing in all the world but a single small flame, and two joined hands, and a stair that went down.

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End of Chapter Two

CHAPTER THREE

The Throat of the Hill

The sun went down on Dhuwakot the way it had gone down for two hundred years, all at once and without apology.

It touched the western ridge a little after five, a swollen red coin balanced on the teeth of the hills, and for a few minutes the whole valley burned with it: the slate roofs, the terraces, the white wall of the temple, the high pale slab of the Hanging Rock, all of it lit from the side with a thick, sad gold, so beautiful that a stranger might have wept. Then the coin slid behind the ridge, the gold drained out of the stones as water drains from a cracked pot, and the shadow of the pipal tree, which had been climbing the hill for the better part of an hour, stopped climbing and simply *lay* there, as a long dark arm lies across a bed.

The first bell rang from the temple at twenty past.

It was a thin, sensible sound, and the village obeyed it as it had obeyed it every evening for fourteen months. On the terraces the men straightened from the last of the furrows, and looked once at the sky, and did not stop to talk. Sickles went into belts. Ploughs were left where they stood. A boy of fifteen who had been late with the buffaloes ran the last stretch of the lower path with his heart in his mouth and the animals lumbering ahead of him in a cloud of their own steam, and a man at the top of the stair called out to him without anger, in the flat, practised voice of a man who has called the same words a hundred times: “Hurry, Shyam. *Hurry.* The bell has gone.”

They came in along the terrace walls in ones and twos, the men of Dhuwakot, farmers and carpenters and the old schoolmaster with his bad hip, and every one of them walked faster than he wished to be seen

walking. There was no talk. A joke began and was dropped. A man laid his hand for a moment on a neighbour's shoulder in passing, not in greeting but in the simple, wordless acknowledgement of fellow-passengers on a sinking boat, and went on.

By the second bell the lanes were empty.

Doors shut, one after another down the length of the stair, with a sound like a slow clapping. Bars dropped into their brackets. Shutters were pinned from within, and the planks nailed across the windows were checked, and checked again, by hands that had checked them a hundred times already. In the houses with sons, the sons were brought in from the yard and counted. In the houses where the fathers had been taken, the women counted too, from habit, and found the number wrong, and counted again.

In one low house on the second terrace a man named Dil Bahadur sat down on the packed-earth floor with his back against his own barred door, and laid a khukuri across his knees, and did not move. His small son sat in his lap, with his shaven head against the father's chest, holding a stick that he was not permitted to bring indoors and had brought indoors anyway. Neither of them spoke. The boy had learned that the evenings were a thing one did not speak through.

"Baba," Ram whispered at last. "I kept my promise."

"What promise?"

"To the schoolmaster. I said I would go home when the bell went. I went home *before* it went."

The man's arms tightened around him, very slightly, in the dark. "Good boy," he said, in a voice that was not quite steady. "Be that. Be that always."

In another house, a girl of sixteen named Pabitra lay on her mat with her eyes wide open and her father's breathing, harsh and awake, coming from across the room. She had not slept at night for four months, and had learned to lie so still that her own heartbeat seemed loud. In a third, Dhanmaya the midwife stood at her shuttered window with a brass lamp she had not lit, because even a lamp might be seen, looking out through a crack in the plank at the empty street and the long red light failing on the roofs, and saying under her breath, over and over, the names of ninety-one children and the four she had buried.

In the Mothers' House the nine mothers sat close together by the great hearth with their sons in their laps. Nobody had asked them to put

the babies to bed, and nobody had. The fire burned low. It was a thick-walled house, and the women sat in it as people sat through a landslide night, with their faces turned up a little, listening to nothing.

"Where is Hajurama?" said the girl of seventeen, in a thin voice.

Tilmaya Gurung, who had been staring into the flames, said nothing for a long moment. "She went to see the gate," she said at last.

"The gate is shut."

"Then she went to see something else." The big woman's mouth worked, and went still. "Do not ask. Do not ask where an old woman goes at the bell. Keep your child warm."

On the platform beneath the pipal, in the failing light, nine small clay lamps stood in a row, with their wicks dry, waiting for a hand to light them. Nobody came. The great rope hung from its bough in the dusk, its loop turning, now, a very little, at the height of a man's head.

And nobody saw the small bent figure in the white sari with the red border go out by the little gate behind the Mothers' House, with her stick tapping lightly on the cobbles and a red-wrapped bundle clasped to her breast. Nobody saw her pause for a moment at the edge of the lane with her blind white face lifted to the last grey light, as though listening, or smelling something on the wind. Nobody saw her turn, quite steadily, without once feeling for the wall, toward the high ground and the cliff and the open mouth of the mountain; or heard her humming, very low, under her breath, a tune that might have been a lullaby.

It was an evening like every other in fourteen months: every door in Dhuwakot stayed shut, and one person walked out through the village and was not seen.

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On the stairs, it was very quiet.

It had not been like this on the hillside. On the hillside, at the end, there had been the long slow creak of rope coming up out of the mountain, patient and measured, as if the cliff itself were breathing through a rope in its throat. Aashi had heard it all the way up the goat-track, each stroke a little nearer, and had told herself that it was the wind, though there was no wind, and had said nothing to Antim, who was saying nothing to her.

But the instant the crack had closed its lip behind them, the creaking had stopped.

It stopped as if the clock had stopped. One moment it was there, enormous and intimate, and the next there was only the soft sound of their own boots on the stone and the small, fragile noise of the lamp, a sort of whispering breath, as the little flame fed on its oil. And behind them, where the door had been, there was only a wall of grey rock as solid as the rest. Aashi put out the fingers of her lamp hand to it, without thinking, and found it cold and rough and absolutely unyielding.

"Do not look back," said Antim, quietly.

"I'm not looking back. I'm touching it."

"Do not do that either."

She took her hand away. She held the lamp low and a little forward, at the height of the waist, as the kinnar had taught them, in her right hand; her left was locked in her husband's right; and they went down.

The stairs were narrow, so narrow that they could not walk side by side without touching the walls, and so they went with Aashi a half-step ahead and Antim behind her shoulder, his arm stretched out past her to keep their hands together. It was an old, well-made stair, cut by someone who had known exactly how steep a woman with a child could bear, and the treads were worn into shallow dishes in the middle by the feet of a great many people. The walls were carved. In the lamplight the carving was extraordinary: rope, rope everywhere, in tight rippling coils that ran down the sides of the stair like water, looped and knotted and interwoven, so cunningly that Aashi's eye kept trying to find where one rope ended and the next began, and failing. Every few paces, the pattern changed. A single knot would stand out in higher relief than the rest, fist-sized and round, and in the centre of each knot, pressed into the stone, there was a small dark hollow. She stretched out one finger of the hand that held the lamp to the first of them, and drew it back at once.

"It's hair," she said. "There is hair in it. Real hair."

"Stone does not grow hair."

"No." She lifted the lamp, and the little flame leaned close, and in the hollow she saw it plainly: a wisp, as fine as thistledown, soft as a baby's. "It does not."

They went on. And the strangest thing, the thing that both of them would turn over in their minds for the rest of their lives, was that nothing at all happened.

Nothing leapt out of the dark. Nothing whispered from the walls. No cold hand closed on an ankle; no voice they knew called their names. The air was cool and a little damp, as the air of a grain-store is, and it smelled, faintly, of earth and marigold and old stone, but the smell did not worsen. The flame stood straight and steady, a single yellow tongue, without once bowing to any drought. For ten minutes, then twenty, they descended in a peace so perfect that it began to seem deliberate; and with every step their fear, instead of leaving them, thickened.

"Antim," said Aashi, at last, very low. "It is too quiet."

"I know."

"Last night, the voice, the scratching, the baby. Last night it did not wait for us to be comfortable. It came for us at once. It knew what we were afraid of before we did." She swallowed. "Why is it letting us walk?"

"Because we are walking toward it." He said it without raising his voice, and for a moment she heard in it the rational man, the Superintendent, the soldier's son who had told a Chief District Officer that superstition was a locked door and behind every locked door there was a man with an account book. "A fisherman does not thrash the water when the fish is swimming into the net. He sits still. He waits." He drew a breath. "This is a trap, Aashi. A trap needs quiet. I have been in three of them. It is always very quiet."

"Or it is a mercy."

"Nothing in this valley is a mercy."

"Hajurama gave us jaggery."

He said nothing. She felt his hand tighten around hers until the bones ground, and the grip said, as plainly as words: *I will not argue with you about it down here.*

He had begun, she realised, to count. She could hear it in his breathing: the fractional hitch at the end of each exhalation, the tiny motion of his lips against her shoulder. He had always been the one who counted; he had counted the steps of the barracks as a boy, and the men on a parade-ground as a man, and the knots on a rope in a village

square that morning, until the numbers ran out. He counted the steps of the stair now as another man might have said a prayer.

"Two hundred," he murmured, somewhere below the first long turn. And later, in a smaller voice: "Three hundred." And later still, after a spiral so tight that the lamp made a wheel of shadows on the wall, and Aashi felt a creeping unreasoning dread begin to climb up her back: "Four hundred."

He stopped talking. The silence stretched.

"Antim?"

"Four hundred and ten," he said. Then, with an odd, strained, scraping note in his voice: "Aashi. Look down."

She looked.

The stair ended one step below them, in a flat floor of beaten earth, and a low round arch, and, beyond the arch, a darkness so absolute that the lamplight seemed to stop at its edge as water stopped at the lip of a well. She did not need to count. She knew, as a mother knows her child's face in a crowd, what the number would be.

"Four hundred and eleven," said Antim.

It was the number of steps up to the barracks at Bhanjyang, where a boy of eleven had once counted every stair with his hand in his father's and made him promise never to take a different path. It was the number of steps he had said once, in his sleep, to his wife, in the first week of their marriage, and then wept, and not remembered it in the morning. He had never told it to the kinnar. He had never told it to the old woman on the bus. He had told it to one person living. And in his dream, in the dark, in the night just gone, a thing with his father's voice had said it to him again.

"It's reading me," said Antim hoarsely. "It has been in my head since the bridge. It has been *reading* me, Aashi. All the way down. It's been making the stairs match."

"Then we do what we were told." She turned her head and looked into his face. In the lamplight it was grey, wet with sweat, strained at the corners of the mouth. She had never seen him afraid for himself. She had seen him afraid for her, a hundred times, in a dozen small ways; this was different. "We hold on. We watch the flame. We do not let go."

"I will not let go."

"Then it can read you all it likes." She tried a small smile, and was a little astonished that it came. "It will find nothing there it can use. It will find a very ordinary man who is frightened and loves his wife."

His breath caught, and half-laughed, and steadied. "That is the whole of the report."

"It is the only part that matters."

They went down the last step hand in hand, in the little ring of light, and passed under the low round arch, and entered the dark.

The smell reached them first.

It came out of the dark beyond the arch like a hand over the mouth, and Aashi, who had been brave for forty minutes, nearly lost her supper on the threshold. It was not one smell but many, laid one on top of another like layers of a rotting cake. There was the marigold that had followed them down the stair, but here it was the marigold of a funeral pyre the morning after, sweet and sodden and gone to slime. There was wet earth, and wet rope, and the thick brown reek of long-standing water. There was iron, which she knew, and which she did not wish to know. And under all of it, steady and heavy and faintly sweet, there was a smell she had met only twice before, once in a flooded cellar in Bhanjyang when a family had been missing for a week, and once at the foot of the Trishuli bridge in the year of the great landslide.

"Breathe through your mouth," said Antim thickly. He had pulled his muffler up over his nose, and he had put one hand to his belt, as though checking that the khukuri was still there.

"I am."

"Breathe slower."

"I am *trying*." She pressed the back of her wrist against her lips. Her stomach rolled, once, enormously, and settled. Seven weeks, said a small cold voice in the back of her head: of course it would be the smell. There had been a hundred smells for weeks, cooking oil and wet wool and Antim's boot-polish, each of them an enemy; and here, in this cavern, was the king of all smells, and her body had decided to take it personally. She almost laughed. She held the lamp a little higher, and looked.

They stood at the edge of a long, low cavern, and it was not a cave that a god would have chosen.

It was raw. It was a thing newly opened, and wounded, and not yet healed over. The ceiling, only a head above Antim's, was not rock at

all, but earth, black damp earth, glistening in the lamplight and pricked all over with the white tips of roots, and from the earth hung the roots themselves in thousands, pale and thin and thick as a man's arm, twisting down from the dark in great ropy braids. They were the pipal's roots, she understood. They had come down through a hundred feet of mountain to find the water. And they hung in the air of the cavern like the hair of some enormous drowned woman, dripping, gleaming, swaying very slightly in a draught that she could not feel.

The floor was mud. It was thick, grey, cold mud, mixed with leaf and bone and rot, and it sucked at their boots with each step and let go reluctantly, with small obscene sounds. Water stood in dark pools between the ridges. Things moved in the pools.

She saw them first at the edge of the lamplight, and for a moment thought that the floor itself was alive. The mud crawled. It was alive with insects, with pale cave crickets as long as a finger, springing blind and weightless from stone to stone; with centipedes, red and brown and shining, as thick as pencils, that poured away from the lamp in rippling lines; with beetles with wet green backs; with white worms that rose from the pools in slow knots and fell back; with great pallid slugs that left silver roads across the dark. And over the whole carpet, in a thin, steady, continuous whisper, went the sound of their feeding: a dry soft *tick, tick, tick*, ten thousand tiny jaws, which she had last heard in a dream with a rope in it.

"Don't look at the floor," said Antim. "Look at the flame."

"I'm looking at the flame."

"Then do not tell me what you see."

"I am not going to tell you what I see." She was whispering. A centipede had run across the toe of her boot, and she had not even flinched, which frightened her more than the centipede. "I am going to put one foot in front of the other. If I put it down on something that crunches, I am going to go on."

They went on.

The first of the dead was a goat.

It lay in a hollow of the mud with its legs folded under it and its head thrown back, a black goat with a white blaze, and it had been dead for perhaps a week. Its belly was swollen like a drum. A red thread was tied around its neck, and from the thread hung a single small brass bell, and the bell tinkled faintly, as the maggots in the carcass heaved and

subsided. Beyond it was a second goat, much older, mostly bone, with scraps of grey hide clinging to its ribs like wet paper. And beyond that a third, and a fourth, a dozen, in a long uneven line along the edge of the passage, each of them with its bell and its thread, each in a different state of decay, as though somebody had been bringing the Lord a goat at regular intervals for a very long time, and had never once taken away the last one.

"Offerings," said Aashi.

"It does not eat them."

"No." She looked at the swollen belly, and the bell, and the thin red thread, and her mouth was dry. "The first gift was a goat. The kinnar said so. Then a pot of milk. And then, later, the hair. A rope for a son, and a gift with the knot. But the goat was first, and it never stopped."

There were other animals. They found a dog, a thin brown pariah dog with the ruff of its neck gone black, lying quite peacefully on its side as if asleep, and a litter of kittens in a heap, and the delicate ribcage of a small deer. They found a monkey with its hands folded over its chest. They found, in a puddle, a fish, a long silver fish of a kind that could not have lived within a day's walk of the mountain, floating belly-up on the black water with a red thread through its gill. Everywhere, in the mud and on the stones, were marigolds: marigold garlands, long strings of them, rotted to a dark brown pulp and trodden into the earth, and fresh marigolds on top of them, orange as a flame, laid out in neat circles by someone with a good eye and a steady hand. It seemed to Aashi that the whole cave had been decorated for a wedding at which the guests had died.

"Someone comes here," he said.

"Someone comes here *often*."

"Then there is a way other than the Throat. A person who brings fresh flowers every day does not wait for the lamp-lighting hour." His voice was beginning to rise, tightening with something that was very nearly relieved. "A man with a key, Aashi. A path. A lorry track, a smuggler's road — it does not matter. There is a *man* —"

"The flowers are fresh," said Aashi gently, "and the goats are dead, and the door was a wall behind us, and I do not think that anyone brought them in by a path."

He stopped. She felt his hand go slack in hers and then, with an effort that she could feel in the whole length of his arm, tighten again.

"I know," he said. "I know that. I am only —" He made a small helpless gesture with his free hand. "I am only reaching for something to hold."

"Hold me."

"I am."

"Then that is enough, for now."

They walked on, past the animals, past the pools, through a forest of dripping roots that brushed their faces and clung to their hair like wet fingers, and the cavern narrowed and began to climb, and then fell sharply away into a low passage with niches cut into its walls, on both sides, in a long straight row.

The niches were the size of a man. They were cut into the living earth, each with a little arch of stone above it, and in each a figure sat upright in the dark, with its knees drawn up and its arms folded, in the composed posture of the dead who have been put to bed by those who loved them. They were old. The oldest were no more than a brown husk in a bundle of rags, a leathery skull showing through its wrappings, but the newer ones, deeper in the row, were more terrible. They had kept their faces. They were smiling. Every one of them was smiling, a dry, stretched, tight-lipped smile, for the skin had drawn back from the teeth with the years; and round the neck of every one, snug against the throat and tied with a neat little knot, was a loop of braided red rope.

"The first families," said Aashi. Her whisper was only breath. "These must be the first of them. The ones who made the pooja, and the ones who came after."

"They didn't die from the rope."

"No?"

"Look at them." He had lifted the lamp, with his free hand over hers, and was holding it close to the nearest, a woman in a rotted red shawl with a child's skeleton cradled in her lap. "They are sitting. They have been *laid* here. They've been put here after, in order, and the rope was tied on as a — a courtesy. As a sign." He turned his head, and she saw in his face the glimmering of something that was not fear and not quite anger. "They were *given* to Him. After they were dead. As you'd bury a woman in her wedding clothes."

"Or before."

"No. I looked at the wrists. Nobody is bound."

"Antim." She had stopped walking. She was staring along the passage, at the row of smiling dead, at the little arches, at the ropes. "Look at the *last* one."

It was the last niche in the row, the nearest of them to the deeper dark, and it was empty.

It was not neglected. The earth floor had been swept, and a mat of clean new straw laid down on it, and a fresh garland of marigolds draped across the arch. A pair of small clay lamps stood on the sill, with oil in them. It was a bed, made up with great tenderness, for someone who had not yet arrived.

And the niche beside it was empty also, and the one beside that, and the next. All the way down the passage, the dark arches yawned in a long unbroken row, swept and straw-lined and garlanded, a hundred beds at the least, a whole dormitory waiting for its guests.

"How many families did you say there were?" said Antim, in an odd, strangled voice.

"Forty."

"And how many sons has this village borne in seven generations, Aashi? How many knots did I stand under today?"

She did not answer. She did not need to.

"It has been preparing," said Antim. "For a very long time. It is not killing at random. It is not killing out of rage. It is *keeping house.*"

❦

The shoes were at the end of the passage.

They stood in a long straight row against the left-hand wall, in front of the last of the empty beds, set down neatly side by side, toe to the wall and heel to the walkway, the way that shoes are set at the door of a temple or a house of mourning. There was no light to see them except the lamp, and for a long moment neither of them understood what they were looking at. It was only when Aashi lowered the flame to the first pair, and the leather gleamed, that her breath went out of her all at once, as if she had been struck.

They were boots. They were black, laced, polished boots with steel heel-plates, the Nepal Police pattern that she had worn herself for eleven years, and they had been polished that morning. She would have sworn to it. They shone like water. Beside them stood another pair, and

another, a long file of them down the wall, eleven in all; and in the fourth pair, with the heels worn down on one side, she recognised, with a small distant jolt like the pain in a limb that has gone numb, the left boot of a man who had walked with a limp from an old fall. She had seen him cross the parade-ground at Bhanjyang a hundred times.

"Rai," whispered Antim. "Inspector Rai's second constable. The limp."

"And that pair, with the brass eyelets —"

"Pandey's." He did not touch them. He stood with his free hand clenched against his thigh. "Pandey always had them done by the cobbler from Kathmandu. He said a man who could not afford good boots could not afford to be a policeman."

After the eleven came more. Beyond the boots stood a row of plain leather sandals, scuffed and cracked at the toes, worn by men who had worked on a hillside; nine pairs, thick-soled, well-mended, the soles still caked with the red earth of the lower terraces. A farmer's slippers. A carpenter's shoes with a mended strap, mended by a man who had mended everything he owned. And beyond them, still in the same straight row, the smallest shoes. Nine pairs again. They were child's shoes, rubber sandals and cloth slippers and one pair of worn school-shoes, with the laces still neatly tied in a bow.

"Twenty-nine," mouthed Antim. No sound came; his lips shaped it. "Twenty-nine pairs."

Aashi could not look at the school-shoes. She looked at the floor beyond them, and her eye fell on a thing that had been lying in the mud at the end of the row, half-hidden by the last of the small slippers, and she knelt, with the lamp in her right hand and her left still locked in her husband's, so that he had to kneel too, and she set the lamp down in the mud beside her knee, and put out her fingers and lifted it.

It was a slate. A small one, with a wooden frame, such as every child in the hills brought to school in a cloth bag, and on it, in a neat, laboured, careful child's hand, was the letter *ka*, written again and again and again, in rows. She counted forty. She could not stop herself. She counted forty, and at the end of the fortieth, where the line should have trailed off the edge in a long white scrape, as it had trailed on a porch in Dhuwakot fourteen months before, in a house she had never seen and a tale that had been told to her in an office with a typewriter, there was a forty-first. It was finished. It was complete, and straight, and tidy, and

beneath it, drawn with the same careful hand, was a small round shape which might have been a face.

"It is not the same slate," said Aashi.

"No."

"It can't be. Karna Bahadur's boy was taken from his porch. The slate was *left on the porch.* The midwife saw it. It was in Thapa's report. It was —" Her voice cracked. She took a breath. "There must be a hundred slates in that village. They all have the same letters. They are only *children*, Antim. Children all learn the same letters."

"Yes."

"It isn't the same slate."

"Aashi." He had put out his hand and, very gently, turned the slate in her fingers, so that the lamplight fell on its back. On the pale wood, in the corner, there was a small scratched mark, a notch and a line, like the first two strokes of a letter. And beside it a name, cut with a nail, in a child's uneven capitals.

BISHAL.

She knelt for a long moment, without moving, with the slate in her hand and the cold coming up through her knees, and a sound came out of her that was not quite a word. Then she wiped her face on her sleeve, quite carefully, and put the slate back where she had found it, a little straighter than before, so that the child who had written on it, when he came for it, would find it in its place.

"He finished the line," she said. "Whoever he was with, wherever he was. He was left in peace long enough to finish the line."

"Do not build a hope on it."

"I am not. I am making a *note* of it." Her voice shook, and steadied. "You taught me that. Make a note. Put it in the file. We will come back to it."

He gave no answer. But he put his arm around her, and for a moment they stayed so, the two of them kneeling in the mud at the end of a row of shoes, in a ring of lamplight in the stink and the dark, with the roots dripping above them and the tiny jaws going tick, tick, tick across the floor. Then, from somewhere a long way behind them, up the passage and through the roots and the goats and the arch and the stair, they heard a sound.

"Tap…"

It was a small, dry, careful sound. It was a stick on stone.

"Tap…Tap…"

And with it, very faint, so faint that it might have been the breath of the cavern itself, somebody humming.

"The niche," breathed Antim.

He did not say another word. He took the lamp from her hand, cupped it close against his chest, and dragged her sideways into the last of the swept and garlanded beds, so quickly that her shoulder struck the arch. It was very narrow. They stood in it with their backs to the cold earth and their bodies pressed together, with the lamp sheltered between them in the hollow of his free hand and her fingers, so that the only light in all the passage was a faint orange glow leaking through his fingers like the glow of a coal in a fist.

It was the worst place she had ever stood in her life. The earth wall at her back was damp and gave a little, like a thing that was breathing. The garland across the arch brushed her cheek, rotting and sweet. And at her left shoulder, in the next bed, no more than a hand's breadth away, she could feel the leathery presence of the dead woman in the red shawl, smiling, patient and attentive, with the little skeleton in her lap.

"Do not breathe," said Antim, without sound.

"Tap…"

It was closer. It came along the passage in no hurry, a slow, dry, unhesitating rhythm, with the soft slap of sandals between the taps, and the humming went with it. It was a single tuneless line that rose and fell and rose, as a woman hums at the stove with her mind elsewhere. Aashi knew it. She had heard it that morning, in a courtyard in the sun.

It is a lullaby, she thought. *It's the lullaby the rope sang last night.*

The tapping stopped.

She heard the little cavern drip, and the crickets spring, and the maggots turn in the belly of a goat. And she heard breathing: a thin, wheezing, labouring breath, rough as a saw, the breath of someone very old who had come down a long stair at a pace that was beyond her.

Through the veil of marigolds, in the faint leaking gold, she saw her.

She was a small white shape in the dark: a bent woman in a white cotton sari with a wide red border, standing at the edge of the pool with a stick in one hand and in the crook of the other arm a bundle wrapped in red. She stood quite still. The roots of the pipal hung round her like the bars of a cage, and her wet white hair was plastered to her skull, and

her face, tipped up toward the ceiling, was calm, and wide-eyed, and perfectly blank. The white eyes shone in the dark like two pieces of boiled egg.

She cannot see us, thought Aashi. *She cannot see anything. She came all the way down in the dark, with no lamp, and no one to lead her, and she has not once put a foot wrong.*

"Chori," said Hajurama.

It was said so softly that for a moment Aashi thought she had imagined it. Antim's fingers closed on the lamp, and the glow went out between his fingers. In the sudden blackness she could hear her own heart, and the dripping of the roots, and the thin labouring wheeze of someone very old who has come a long way down.

"I can smell your lamp, chori." The voice was soft and a little breathless, and quite without menace. It might have been calling a child out from under a bed. "Mustard oil and cotton wick. And ginger, from the tea this morning. You were frightened in my yard, and you are frightened now, and it is the same smell. I am glad of it. A woman who is not frightened in this place is a woman I would worry about."

Nobody answered.

"You need not come out. I would not, in your place. I would stand in the bed and breathe small and wait for the foolish old woman to go away." She lowered herself, with a grunt, onto a flat stone at the edge of the pool, and laid the stick across her knees. The bundle went into her lap. "But I am old, and my knees are older, and I would like to sit. You will forgive me if I talk while I do it."

She tilted her head, as a bird does, and turned her blank white face, with perfect accuracy, toward the niche.

"The lantern-bearer called after me, at the mouth. Hajurama, stop. Did you hear it? They have never in their life raised their voice to me." The thin mouth bent. "I did not stop. They would not put a hand on me. That is the oldest law of the Throat, that no hand is raised against the eldest mother, and I have been the eldest for forty-one years. I walked past them as one walks past a child who is crying, and I could hear them crying behind me all the way down the first stair. They are a better soul than any of us. Nobody has ever told them so."

She said they, thought Aashi, with sudden, appalled understanding. *Not* she, *as the women at the tap say it. She has always known exactly who the kinnar is, and she has never once said so.*

"I am not here to hurt you," said Hajurama. "I would like you to know that first. I know that the man has his hand on a gun. I can hear his coat. Put it away, Superintendent. A gun is a cold thing, and I am too old to be afraid of one."

There was a very long pause.

Then Antim stepped out of the niche, the revolver in his free hand, pointed at the ground, and the lamp, passed back to her, shuttered in Aashi's other hand, and Aashi, because their hands were locked, came with him.

❦

"There," said Hajurama, as a woman whose guests have at last consented to sit. "That is better."

They stood in the mud at the edge of the lamplight, a few paces from her. Aashi had unshuttered the flame, and it rose straight and gold in her palm, and in its light the old woman looked less than she had in the sun: smaller, softer, more wrinkled, a grandmother in a village photograph. The red bundle lay in her lap, closed and still and silent. The blind eyes were turned a little to the right of Antim's head, as they always were, as though she saw something just behind his shoulder.

"How did you find us?" said Antim.

"I did not find you. I walked." She lifted her chin. "I have come down this stairs every Dashain since I was a girl. Sixty years, in the dark, with a stick. A woman who has walked a path that long does not need her eyes."

"You told Aashi that He took your eyes."

"He did."

"Here?"

"Not here. At the place where He sits, at the heart of the hill. I was nineteen. I was told, as all girls are told, *do not look when the rope is moving*. I looked." A small dry breath that was almost a laugh. "I wanted to see what it was that I served."

Antim said nothing. Aashi saw his jaw move.

"I will tell you why I am here," said Hajurama, "and I will tell it badly, because I am tired, and because I have never said it aloud. You may stop me. I would rather you did." She smoothed the red cloth on her lap with one thin hand. "You came to the tap this morning, and you

were met by the women, and they were kind to you, and they made a fuss. Do you remember the tea? Nobody asked Tilmaya to ask you to her house. Nobody asked the girl with the plait to speak to your husband. I did. I sat in my room with the shutters closed and I said, *go to the tap, find the schoolmaster and his wife, be kind to them, make them stay.* Make them stay, and make them feel at home, and let them wander about the village in the sun until the bell." Her voice did not change. "That is how it is done. I learned it from my mother-in-law, and she from hers. We do not hunt. We welcome people."

"You invited us up here," said Aashi, quite quietly.

"Yes."

"The tea in your yard. *Come back by the lamp-lighting hour.* You wanted us to come."

"At dawn, I did." The old woman's face was perfectly calm. "God forgive me, I wanted it at dawn. I wanted it as I had wanted it for nine policemen, and for two men from Kathmandu who wanted to photograph the tree. It is not a wish that feels like a wish. It feels like laying on a table. You smile, and you pour, and you tell yourself that it is only hospitality, and in the morning the guests are gone." She paused. "And then I put my hand on you, in the yard, and I felt the little one."

She was silent for a moment.

"A woman does not give a carrying woman to Him," she said. "Not even I. Something in me turned over like a fish. I sat down in the back room with the bundle in my lap and I thought, *no. Not this one. Anyone but this one.* So I did what an old woman does. I tried to keep you. I said you must stay in the Mothers' House by the fire, with the babies, where it is warm. You said no. I gave you jaggery and told you to go home, and you said thank you, and you did not go." Her mouth trembled and was still. "You are a very good girl, and a very stubborn one. I thought, *well, then.* And I took my stick."

"To do what?" said Antim.

It was the first thing he had said since she began her confession. His voice was flat and quiet, the voice of a man reading a charge sheet to himself.

"To turn you round." Hajurama lifted her face. "I will tell you what I am going to do, and you may take it as a kindness or a trick, it makes no difference to me which. There is a place past the end of this passage where the old stair comes up from the heart. I can stand there and call,

and He will come. He comes when the eldest calls. It has always been so."

"You can *call* it?" said Antim.

"I can call Him up. I cannot send Him back." She said it with the dull weariness of a woman admitting to an old debt. "He will come slowly. He will pass the mouth of this passage on His way to me, and you will be standing in it with your little flame, and you will *feel* Him go by. You will not see His face. That is not permitted. You will see only what any creature may see, a shadow on a wall, and you will hear it, and smell it, and it will go through your teeth and your knees and the roots of your hair." She drew breath. "And you will not stay. Nobody stays. I have done it three times, for three men who would not be turned. Two of them ran. They still live in Bhanjyang. One has not touched a drink since. One sleeps with a lamp lit. It is a poor sort of salvation, but they are alive."

"And the third?" said Aashi.

"The third sat down in the mud and asked to be shown the way." The old mouth closed on it. "I showed him."

Nobody spoke.

"So that is what I have come to do, chori. Not to hurt you. To frighten you so badly that you will forget the word *brave*. I would rather you hated me for it, all your life, in Bhanjyang, with a child on your knee, than that I should weep for you here." Her hand moved on the bundle. "I am afraid, chori. I want you to know that too. I have been afraid since I was nineteen. When you hear Him, run. Take the lamp and your husband and the stairs. I will hold the door for as long as an old woman can hold a door. It will not be long. Do not look behind you. Do not wait for me."

Aashi's throat was tight. She looked at the thin, bent shape in the mud, at the wet white hair, at the quiet hands, and she felt something loosen in her breast that she would afterwards be ashamed of. It was a pity. It was nothing so grand as trust.

"The eleven," said Antim.

He had not moved. He stood with the revolver down, a little apart from his wife, and the lamplight lay on one side of his face and left the other black.

"Tell me about my eleven."

"Ah." Hajurama breathed out. "I wondered when you would."

"*Tell* me."

"Very well." She folded her hands, and for a moment the old, soft, grandmotherly voice altered, grew plainer, more careful, like a woman reading from a ledger. "They came on different days, but it was always the same. The first was a tidy young man, Thapa, with a notebook. He was polite. He asked for a second glass, and told a joke about his mother-in-law, and my girls laughed. The one with the moustache, Rai, brought four men with rifles. They sat in my yard in a row on the mats, and the big one, the constable with the limp, sang an old Gurung song, very badly, and wept in the second verse. The two from Kathmandu wished to take pictures." The thin finger stroked the bundle. "They were such *polite* men. They said thank you for the tea. Every one of them. I do not know why that is the thing that I remember."

Antim's face did not alter. But Aashi, looking at him, saw the muscle jump at the corner of his jaw, once, and again.

"And the last?" he said, in a voice that was hardly a voice at all.

"The last was an old soldier with a great grey moustache. Pandey." The blind face turned a little toward him, with something very like tenderness. "He would not drink it at first. He took the glass and he looked at it, and he said, *Hajurama, I know what this is.* I said, *Then do not drink.* And he said, *A man must see where it ends.* " He drank it all, and thanked me, and then he stood up in my yard and he *saluted.*" She shook her head slowly. "An old woman! In a white sari. I have never been saluted before or since. And every one of them went up the hill at the bell, singing, with their boots in their hands, and I stood in my gate and watched them go."

"You watched them go."

"I did."

"You poured the tea, and you sang to them, and you watched them walk up the mountain, and you did *nothing.*"

"I gave them tea, Superintendent. He took the rest." Her voice was quite steady. "It is a different thing. Perhaps it is not a better one. But a man who walks up that stairs singing does not feel the rope. A man who goes in cold and afraid feels everything. I could not save them. I could only make it gentle. It was the one thing in my gift."

She stopped. She seemed, for the first time, to feel the silence she had made.

"Hajurama," said Aashi, very softly. "You said there were things you would tell a policeman. I am a policeman. Tell me who it was, who failed to tie the first knot at Dashain. The night Karna Bahadur's boy was born. That is where it began. Whose hands were they?"

"That," said Hajurama, "is mine to carry."

"Hajurama —"

"I will not say. Not to you. Not here." The thin mouth trembled. "There are things I will tell a policeman, and things I would tell a priest, and things I have promised that I will never say to any creature that has not been counted. You are not counted. It would be the cruellest thing I could do to tell you. Believe me, chori. It would be the cruellest."

She has told me five true things and a sixth that is a door, thought Antim, with the cold clear terrible certainty of a man who has sat twenty years across a table from liars. *She invited us. She poured. She calls it, and it comes, and she walks in the dark without a lamp. She is the eldest of the mothers and the keeper of the knots and the maker of the lie that nine women recited to my wife. She has fed it for sixty years. She had just told me so, in her own voice, with her hands folded in her lap, and wept a little, and I was about to be moved. I was looking for a man with an accounts book. I was looking at the wrong sex. That is all. It is her.*

"Antim," said Aashi.

She had never heard her own voice sound so small.

"Hajurama, I believe that you want to help us. But I do not think that we can go back. There are boys in this place, and men, and I do not think they are all dead. I found a slate. It had a name scratched on the back, and a finished line." She drew a breath. "If you know where they are —"

"I know where they are."

It came so quietly that neither of them was sure she had spoken. The old woman had turned her face down toward the bundle. Her hands, which had been quite still, had begun to move over the red cloth, stroking it in long, absent, dreaming strokes.

"Hajurama?"

"It does not matter where they are." The voice was a thread. "It matters only what you carry. You do not know what you carry, child. You have been so brave, and so clever, and so very much in love, and

you have not once asked what it *is*." She lifted her face, and the blank white eyes were wet. "A boy, I said. I am seldom wrong. And you, standing there with your hand in his hand, with a son between you, and the night of his birth already written. A father and a son. He has a place set for both. And while one thread holds, He cannot pass the gate; I have kept Him behind it forty years. Do you understand what stands behind you, if I fail? Not a village, child. A road."

Antim's breath stopped.

"I am sorry. I am so very sorry. I have said it badly." She was rising, with the red bundle held to her heart and her free hand lifted, palm up, with the thin fingers spread. "There is one thing I can do. It is not much. The touch of the eldest mother, laid on a carrying woman, will turn His eye away from her for one night. That is all it will buy. One night, and the start of a road. Come here, chori. Come close. Let me put my hand —"

And she reached out across the lamp-flame, with her palm open, toward the place beneath Aashi's shawl.

It began with the sound.

It was a very small sound. It was nothing: the whisper of a dry palm lifting out of a red cloth, the soft creak of old knuckles, the little hiss of breath from an old woman who had stood up too quickly. In a courtyard in the sun it would have been a sound that no one noticed. But the cavern had been listening to them for an hour, and the dark had no other noises to put in its place, and in the quiet it was the loudest thing in the world.

"Creeeeak..."

It was a rope.

Antim heard it quite distinctly. It came from the old woman's open hand, from the stretched tendons of the wrist, from the long slow lift of the arm, and it rose in his ears and swelled to fill the whole cavern, a long, patient, intimate groan of rope taking a weight. And the weight was not an old woman. He saw that at once. In the lamplight, in the yellow ring of the flame, the thing before him had begun, very slightly, very slowly, to *hang*. The white sari lifted at the hem. The stick that had slid from her lap lay in the mud at her feet. The small bent figure rose by an inch, by a hand's breadth, on tiptoe, on the very tips of her toes, in the stance of a creature suspended from a branch, with the ground just under it, and the face tipped back, and the blind eyes wide.

It has found me, thought Antim. *It has been walking beside us all this while.*

"Antim," said somebody's voice.

It was not his wife. It was a flat, hoarse, military voice, with the vowels of a man who had learned his letters in a barracks, and it came from the left, from the row of niches, from a hand's breadth beyond his shoulder. He did not turn. He knew that it was no use turning. He knew what he would find there if he did, because he had been finding it, every night for twenty-six years, at the end of a bridge in the sun.

"Babu," said his father. "Count."

"I am counting."

"You have always been the one who counted." There was something terrible in the warmth of it. "Eleven policemen, nine fathers, and nine boys. I counted them for you, so you would not have to. Twenty-nine. It is a good number, Babu. It is an honest, round, tidy number. And the rope has such a *long* way to go."

Do not answer, said a voice in his head, that was the kinnar's, that was Aama's, that was his own. *Whatever calls you, in any voice, do not answer.*

He did not answer. But his lips had begun to move, and with them the old furious arithmetic, the numbers coming of themselves, each with its face.

One. Sub-Inspector Rajan Thapa, in his tidy uniform, with a notebook and two constables. He had shaken Antim's hand too hard at the Dashain parade, and said, with a joke, that he would write the report in verse. He had gone up the hill one morning with the sun in his eyes and sent a message down to the runner from the last bazaar: *Going up now. Will report by Friday.*

Two. Inspector Bhim Bahadur Rai. A good moustache. Four men and a week of rations. He stood in the district office with his heels together and said, *I will bring them back, sir, every one,* and Antim had said, *I know you will,* and *I know you will* was the thing that he had written, in his mind, on all the letters since.

Three. Four. The two plain-clothes men from Kathmandu. He had never learned their names. He had not asked. He had signed the chit that allowed them a week's leave of absence on the grounds of a *quiet inquiry*, and sent them up, and had not looked at their faces, and now he

saw both of them with perfect clarity, hanging in the white beneath a bridge with their hats on.

Five, six, seven, eight, nine, ten. The constables. Four with Rai, two with Thapa, whose names he did know, because he had written every one with his own hand, in a register, at a desk, beneath a crooked portrait of the King. Chhetri. Gurung. Basnet. Lama. Their mothers' addresses.

Eleven. Pandey. Devendra Pandey, with thirty years in uniform and a great grey moustache, who had looked at a list of ten dead men and decided that the trouble had been teamwork; who had taken a flask and a notebook and sat down under the pipal in the dark and *saluted it.* He had been Antim's own commanding officer, once. He had taught Antim to read a report. And Antim, when the file came, had sat and looked at it for three days, and then, God forgive him, had thought: *there is nobody left to send.*

Twenty-nine, said his father's voice, and the rope began to sing.

It was all in the room with him. It was all in the cave. The goats with their little bells, the swollen bellies, the sweet black rot; the long smiling row of the dead in their beds; the shoes. *The shoes.* He had stood and looked at a pair of boots with brass eyelets and had thought, calmly, with a clear head and a steady hand, that he was a rational man. He had counted. He had made a note. And all the while, beneath the counting, something else had been going on in him, something that had begun a long time ago on the bank of a river on a bright morning, a small cold thing that had waited twenty-six years for a night like this one to come and open its eyes.

You sent them, said Thapa, from the dark, quite gently, in his cheerful voice. *You signed the chit.*

You were very busy, sir, said Rai.

Thank you for the tea, said Pandey, and saluted.

A father, said the old woman, *and a son. He has a place set for both.*

Antim stared at her.

She stood with her face tipped up in the lamplight, with the white sari lifted around her ankles and the red bundle clutched against her breast, and her free hand was out, open, palm up, with the thin fingers spread: a small dry brown hand, the colour of a leaf, quite steady. It was reaching for his wife. It was reaching, across a gap of three feet of mud

and a lamp-flame, with the tender, dreaming, unhurried gesture of a woman about to lay a blessing on a head, for the place beneath Aashi's shawl where his son, his Subodh, a thing no larger than a grain of rice, was sleeping.

He knew that hand.

He had known about it since the morning. He had seen it, in his mind, flat against Aashi's shawl in a courtyard that he had not been permitted to enter, and he had known what it meant. It was the hand that tied the knots. It was the hand that lifted the cup. It was the hand that had held a brass pot over eleven men and poured, and sung, and sent them up a hill in their stockinged feet to be hung.

I will not, said something in him, quite quietly, in a voice he did not know. *I will not be the one who stands and counts.*

"Antim," said Aashi.

She was looking at him. She had seen his face, and she was saying his name in a clear, sharp, urgent voice, and her hand was crushing his. "Antim, look at me. She is only an old woman. She is *only* an old woman. Antim —"

He heard it, and it was a long way off. It came to him through a wall of water. He felt her fingers closing on his, hard enough to hurt, hard enough to bruise, with the fierce warm determined strength of a woman hauling a pot off a fire; and in some unlit corner of his mind a voice that smelled of ghee and woodsmoke said, with great clarity and great distress, *you do not separate*, and he thought, with the perfect cold simplicity of a man in a fever: *I know, Aama. I know. But I cannot do both.*

He let go of her hand.

It was the easiest thing he had ever done. It took no effort. His fingers opened, as a child's open when it falls asleep, and her hand slid out of his, and he felt the warmth go out of his palm. He felt the cold come in. And the revolver was in his right hand, heavy and familiar, the one thing in all that stinking dark that had weight and edges and made sense, and his thumb found the hammer and drew it back, and it clicked, quite distinctly, in the silence, like a bone.

"*No!*" cried Aashi.

"Stand back," said Antim.

"Antim, *don't* —"

"Stand *back*, Aashi."

The old woman had not moved. She had not drawn her hand away. She stood, quite quiet, with her palm out, and the blind white eyes turned a little to the right of his face, and she said, very softly, in a voice from which all the sweetness had gone out and left only a kind of worn, patient astonishment: "*Oh. I think, now, I can rest peacefully* ."

He fired.

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The sound was enormous.

It was not like any shot he had ever fired on a range. It rolled out of the revolver and struck the roof of the cave and came back from everywhere at once, a single vast flat hammer-blow of noise that slammed into his ears like the closing of a door and left behind a high, thin, ringing whine, and under the whine, a silence. A great shaking went through the roots. Mud fell from the roof in clots. In the pools the insects went still, and then all together, in a single rippling wave, ran for the walls.

For a long moment, nothing moved at all.

Then the old woman sat down.

She did it quite slowly, with a kind of dignity, as one sits who is tired after a long day. Her knees folded. Her sari spread around her in the mud, white as milk. The red bundle was still held against her breast, and her other hand had come up to press itself against her side, below the ribs, and when she took it away it was black in the lamplight, and wet, and shining.

"Oh," she said again. It was a small, surprised sound. "Oh, that is — that is rather —"

Aashi was on her knees beside her. She had dropped the lamp. It stood upright in the mud where it had fallen, and miraculously burned on, a tiny steady flame, and she did not so much as glance at it. She had her hands on the old woman's side, pressing, tearing at the cloth of the sari, and blood was running between her fingers, hot and quick and ordinary. It smelled of copper. It was entirely, absolutely real.

It is real, she thought, with a kind of terrible lucidity. *It is not a mimic. It is not a voice in the dark, wearing a face. She breathed. She sat down. She is bleeding on my hands.*

"Hold on," she said. "Hold on, Hajurama, I have a — I have a cloth, I will — Antim, *help me!*"

He did not move.

He stood where he was, with the revolver lowered, in the mud, in the ring of thin gold light, and looked at the thing that he had done. His ears were ringing. The ringing was dying away, slowly, like a bell, and as it faded, the noises of the real world came creeping back into the silence: the dripping of the roots, the small wet sounds of the goats, a woman's quick labouring breath. It was a very clear and quiet and ordinary picture. An old woman in a white sari sat in the mud with her wet white hair stuck to her face, and a young one knelt beside her with her hands full of blood, and neither of them looked in the least like anything but what they were.

The cave was empty. There was no father in the niches. There were no dead men's voices in the dark. There was only a cold, wet, stinking stretch of earth, and a lamp, and the clean white shape of a very old woman, who had been blind for sixty years and had come down a mountain in the dark to ask two strangers to go home.

Oh, thought Antim. *Oh, God.*

"You," said Hajurama.

Her head had turned. It had turned, with great effort, to where he stood, and her wide white eyes seemed for a moment, almost, to see him. The thin mouth worked. There was blood on her lip.

"You have the... the heaviest... hands of any man I ever..." She coughed. It was a small, wet, terrible sound. "You have been — carrying something. Haven't you. A very long way." A thread of dark ran down her chin. "I knew it. I smelled it on you at the... at the tree. I thought: *there is a man who has a rope in him.* I thought... I would be gentle."

"Hajurama," said Aashi desperately. "Please. Please don't speak."

"Be quiet, chori. I have... a little... left." The old woman's hand fumbled out from her side, and found, with perfect accuracy, Aashi's wrist, the wrist on which a red thread had been tied by a woman in Bhanjyang with a ladle in her other hand, and closed round it, very lightly. "Listen. I told you. I told you to... to *go.* It was a... a ruse. A fright. Only... to turn you. And the hand..." Her fingers twitched on Aashi's wrist. "The hand was only... a blessing. One night. That was all... I had to hold..."

"Hold what?"

"The knots," said Hajurama, and her face, in the lamplight, did something strange. It softened. It smoothes, as a pillow smooths when a hand has been taken away. "I held them. All of them. Seven times seven... all my life. I held... the door. I thought... it would be... a hundred years before..."

"Before what?"

But the old woman had turned her head a little, and seemed to be listening to something a long way off. The grip on Aashi's wrist loosened and tightened and loosened again.

"Now who," she said, in a clear, surprised, almost childlike voice, "will tie them?"

Her hand fell away.

She sat for a moment longer in the mud, in the circle of the lamp, quite upright and composed, with the red bundle held to her breast, and her blank white eyes turned up toward the black roots of the pipal. Then the chin sank very slowly onto her chest. The sari settled. And the bundle slipped from her arm, and rolled, with a soft muffled thump, onto the floor of the cave, and lay there, wrapped and red and perfectly still.

It did not cry.

Aashi would remember that. She would remember, afterwards, in the days that followed, with a cold exactness she could not account for, that a gunshot had gone off in a stone cave three feet from a newborn child, loud enough to shake the mud off the roof, and the child had made no sound whatsoever. It had not startled. It had not woken. It had not so much as whimpered. It lay in the mud with a fold of the red cloth fallen over its face, as quiet as a stone, as quiet as a thing that had never in its life been alive enough to be afraid.

But that came later. At that moment, Aashi saw nothing at all. She knelt in the mud with the old woman's blood going cold on her hands, and her husband's breathing loud and wrong behind her in the dark, and a thin high ringing in her ears, and she did not look at the bundle. She only looked at the hand, the thin brown leaf-coloured hand, lying open in the mud with its palm to the sky.

It had been reaching for her. She was almost certain that it had been reaching for her, and that it had meant nothing but kindness.

"Hajurama?" she said.

There was no answer.

"She was blind," said Aashi.

She had not turned around. She was still kneeling in the mud beside the body, with her bloodied hands held a little away from her sides, as a surgeon held them, and she said it in a low, level, dreadfully quiet voice, to the dead woman's face.

"Aashi —"

"She was blind, Antim. She was seventy, perhaps eighty. She was five feet tall and she weighed what a child weighs. She had a stick, and a bundle, and she had walked down a mountain in the dark to ask us to go home. And you shot her."

"She was reaching for you."

"She was *blessing* us."

"She was reaching for *the child.*" His voice cracked, and rose, and he dragged it down again by main force. "Did you not hear her? Did you listen? *A father and a son. He has a place set for both.* She said it to my face. She told me what she meant to do. She told us she had lured the Lord up the stairs, three times, for three men, and that she had put eleven of my people to sleep with a pot of tea, and *walked them up the hill like a wedding.* She said they said thank you. She said it Aashi, you were *there.*"

"I was there."

"Then you heard her."

"I heard a frightened old woman who had done an unforgivable thing for reasons I do not understand." She turned at last. In the lamplight her face was grey, and quite still, and her eyes were dark and enormous and wet. "I heard someone who was trying, in the only way that she knew, to keep two strangers from walking into the mouth of a god. I heard her say she was *afraid.* And I heard you did not hear it."

"She was lying."

"She was dying, Antim. People who are dying do not lie. They do not have the time."

"Then what was she doing here?" He was shouting now. The cavern took it and tossed it back at him from the dripping roots, *here, here, here*, in a long, hollow, mocking diminuendo. "Tell me! She is the eldest mother. She keeps the knots. She walks down here, alone, in the dark, with no lamp, blind, on a path that nobody else may walk, with a red bundle that nobody may see, on the one night that two police

officers go into the hill. She comes after us. She *waits* for us. She tells us where the Lord sits and how he comes and that he comes when she calls. And you want me to believe that a woman like that is only a poor old *innocent* —"

"I want you to believe that you will never know."

It fell between them like a stone.

"That is what you did," said Aashi. Her voice shook. "You took the one person in this whole cursed valley who might have told us what happened, who was *about* to tell us, who had said, I know where they are, and you shot her before she could finish her sentence. We will never know now. We will never know what she knew. We will never know *who tied the first knot.* You made yourself the only witness to her death and the sole author of her guilt, and you did it because a voice in the dark said *father and son*, and you stopped being a policeman."

"I have been a policeman for twenty years."

"You were not a policeman tonight." She came up off her knees. She stood in the mud with her hands red to the wrist, shaking from head to foot, and it came to him, with a sudden sick certainty, that she was no longer frightened of the cave. She was frightened of him. "You were your father's son. You were a little boy on a riverbank. You were so busy counting the dead that you killed the first living thing that came within reach of the numbers."

"Do not."

"You let go of me."

He opened his mouth. He shut it.

"You let go of my *hand.* I said your name. I held on. I was holding on as hard as I could, and you opened your fingers one by one as if I were a stranger. Do you know what that felt like? Do you know —" She stopped. She pressed her fist hard against her mouth, and took it away. "We had one rule, Antim. We had *one.* It was the only thing that anyone told us. The kinnar said it, and your mother said it, and I do not care how many ropes it is tied to or what kind of a thing is waiting at the end of it, it was the one thing in all of this that I trusted. We hold on. We do not separate. And the first time that it was hard —"

"The first time it was *hard?*" He had crossed the mud in two strides, and he was standing over her with his face quite white, shaking with a rage that was, she saw, a kind of grief. "Do you think I did it because it was *easy?* Do you think I wanted to do it? I looked at that

hand and I saw my father walking out onto the bridge. I saw *Pandey.* I saw your belly open on the floor of this place like a wet cloth, Aashi, I saw it, I could not have not seen it, and you tell me that a man with eyes should have stood still and let a woman who feeds the thing —"

"I do not *know* that she fed it!"

"I do!"

"You *think* you do!" Her voice cracked clean across. "That is the difference. That is the entire difference between what I am and what you have made of yourself in the dark. I think. I wait. I made a note. And you —"

"And I what?"

"And you hold a gun to the one question in this valley that could have been answered, and call it *justice.*"

He stared at her. His mouth was working. In the lamplight the sweat shone on his face like oil, and his whole body seemed to lean toward her and away, like a man standing at the edge of a cliff who has just realised, a moment too late, which way the ground slopes. She saw him begin to answer, and saw him not, and a dreadful stillness settled over his face, the stillness of a man hearing, for the first time, the noise of what he has done.

"I killed her," he said.

"Yes."

"I killed an old blind woman."

"Yes."

"Aashi —" He lifted the hand with the revolver, as if to show it to her, and stopped, and looked at it. It hung at the end of his arm, black and heavy and foreign. Slowly, as if it burned him, he let it drop into the mud. "Oh, God. Oh, my God, what have I —"

"Antim."

He was weeping. She had never once seen it, not in nine years; it came out of him without a sound, running down his grey face and into the stubble, and he did not lift a hand to wipe it. "I could not *help* it. I could not stop. It was like watching someone else's hand —"

"I know." And, in spite of everything, in the terrible quiet of that wet and stinking dark, she did. She saw it plainly. She saw the twelve-year-old boy on the bank of the river, who had counted every plank of a bridge and had not been able to count it back. She saw a good man, a kind man, a man who had walked up a mountain beside

her without once saying that they should turn back, who had put his hand in a fire and was only now learning that it had burned. And she hated, with a hot sick helpless hatred, that she saw it. Because it did not make her any less shaken. And it did not make the old woman any less dead.

She put out her hand.

He looked at it. It was a small hand, brown and steady, with a thread of red cotton wound round the wrist, and the old woman's blood drying on its fingers. He looked at it as though it were something he had no right to touch.

She was crying too. She had not noticed when it began. "We will talk about it later," said Aashi, quite gently, through it. "Whatever happens. We will talk about it for the rest of our lives. But we cannot do it here. We cannot do it *apart.* Take my hand."

He started to reach for it.

And the flame of the lamp went flat.

❦

It did not go out. It simply lay down, sideways, flat against the mud, as a candle lies when a window is flung open in a gale, a thin bright smear of yellow, stretched and trembling and pointing at something. It was not windy. There was no wind. The air in the cave hung perfectly still, and thick, and cold, and over it, from very far off, from the other end of the passage, came a long low sound that she felt in her breastbone before she heard it, a vast patient creak, like the straining of a mast.

"Creeeeak…"

Aashi's hand dropped. Her blood went to ice.

"The lamp," said Antim, in a whisper. "Pick up the *lamp* —"

She snatched it from the mud. It was hot in her hand, and slick with grease, and she held it low in her right hand, and the flame, in the circle of her fingers, struggled up, quivering, and pointed again: not up, as a flame points, not toward the roof, but down the long dim passage of the dead, at an angle, toward the dark.

The lamp is what tells the rope which way is down.

It was pointing the way that was down.

All along the row, in the niches, the dead began to stir.

It was slight. A breath, a shiver, the faint dry sound of old cloth rubbing on old cloth. The smiling brown faces did not turn. But the ropes at their throats moved, every one, the little red ropes in their neat knots, rising a little and tightening and swaying, and the dry heads nodded forward very slightly, like the heads of sleepers who have heard their names. At the far end of the passage a darker blackness stirred among the roots, and a smell came rolling out of it, so thick and sweet and dense that Aashi gagged: marigold, marigold and rot and wet rope and a hot rank salt animal stench, like the breath of an enormous sleeping beast.

"Antim," she whispered. "Take my hand."

"Aashi —"

"*Take it.*"

She felt his fingers close on hers, wet and hard, and the old strength came back into the grip. It was not enough. Even as she thought it, she knew that it was not enough; that something was already broken, and that no clasp of hands in a darkened cave would put it back as it had been. The ring had been opened. It had been opened by the one hand in all the world that she would have trusted to hold it. But she held on, and he held on, and together they stood in the little rocking circle of the lamp and turned, and looked down the long black throat of the passage, and saw Him.

He was not coming.

Jhundiyeko Prabhu, thought Aashi, and the name that the kinnar had begged them never to say after dark sat in her mouth like a stone. *The Lord who hangs.*

That was the first thing. He was not coming up the passage toward them, as Hajurama had said, as the kinnar had said, as the old dreadful stories had said, with arms out and a face like a lantern. He was *there.* He had been there all the time. He had been hanging at the end of the corridor, in the dark, in the place where the niches ended and the mud ran away into nothing, quietly, patiently, since the night of the first knot, and the dark that she had taken for a wall was the dark of a thing so large that it filled the whole width of the way. The cold came off Him in slow waves, the cold of a well, of a grave opened in January, and it did not touch the skin so much as the teeth. The lamp-flame shrank from it. Even the shadows of the roots, on the walls, bent away from Him, as animals bend from a fire.

And He had His back to them.

It was vast. It was the back of a man, the broad, bowed, hunched back of an enormous man who had been hanged from a bough and had hung there so long that He had forgotten what it was to stand, a back as wide as a door and twice the height of Antim, with the shoulders drawn forward and the head bowed so low upon the chest that the neck was lost. He wore a long garment that might once have been red, and had rotted to the colour of old liver; it hung in tatters, and through the tatters showed skin, pale and wet and grey as the belly of a fish, and stretched so tight across the bones that every rib stood out like the staves of a cask. The skin was not still. It rippled, faintly, here and there, as a pond rippled under rain, and Aashi understood, with a lurch of her stomach, that it was the weight of the rope that every knot upon him was pulling. Down the length of the spine ran a ridge, a high knobbed ridge, like a second backbone, and Aashi saw, with a spasm of horror that came up through her like sickness, that it was a *rope*: a thick braided rope, thick as her arm, that grew out of the nape of the neck and rose into the roots above his head and was lost in them, and that every inch of it, from the shoulders to the roots, was knotted. Every knot was fist-sized. Every knot was bound with a lock of hair.

His arms hung down before him, out of her sight, and she was thankful for it. She saw only the shoulders, and the long grey fingers of one hand curling past His hip, each finger as long as her forearm, the nails black and split, and from the tips of them, slowly, one after another, fell drops that struck the mud like heavy coins.

His own hair was white, and long, and matted with marigolds. It hung to the ground behind him in a great wet curtain. And his feet —

His feet were bare. They hung in the air, a hand's breadth above the mud, long and narrow, with the toes pointed down like the toes of a dancer. And under the toes, very gently, brushing the earth at every sway, they touched the ground, and went away, and touched it, leaving small deep points in the mud, a single track of them, round and round, and round. Something in the dark beyond His swaying was breathing, slow and wet and enormous, and every time it drew in, the lamp-flame leaned toward him, and every time it let go, the flame fell back, as if the whole cave were a lung and He was the thing inside it.

Seven times, thought Aashi. *He walks the circle seven times.*

She could not breathe. She could not move. She could hear the faint, thin, high-pitched whimpering of somebody, and realised, after a moment, that it was her.

He swayed. He did it very slowly, a long, tired, patient swing out and back, as a weight sways at the end of a rope, and the rope above him creaked, and the dust of two centuries sifted down from the roots. He did not turn. He did not seem to know they were there. He hung with His great white head bowed and His back to them, in the thick yellow reek of His own presence, as a man hangs who has been waiting a long time, and whom no creature on earth has ever been able to look in the face.

You will not see His face, the old woman had said. *That is not permitted.*

It is not that He will not show it, thought Aashi wildly, with sudden terrible comprehension. *It is that nobody has ever been brave enough to ask Him to turn.*

Nothing in the cave moved. The lamp-flame lay flat in the mud. The dead leaned toward the dark in their niches, and the roots dripped, and far above them, in the rock, something that was not wind drew one slow breath.

Then the Hanging Lord spoke.

He did not turn. His head did not lift from his chest. The voice did not come from his mouth at all; it came out of the rope, out of every knot at once, a long, low, patient groan, like a bough taking a weight, that shaped itself, as it rose, into a word. It was not a man's voice, or a woman's. It was the sound a house makes at night when it is very old and someone is walking in it. And it said, quite softly, to the two of them, as one speaks to guests who have taken a very long time on the road:

"Come."

Aashi felt her husband's fingers close on hers, wet and hard and shaking. Neither of them let go.

And above them, in the roots, the great rope began, very slowly, to creak.

❦

End of Chapter Three

CHAPTER FOUR

A Rope for a Son

The floor left them first.

There was no warning, and no violence in it. The mud simply let go of their boots, as a child lets go of a hand, and the whole dripping length of the passage began to slide away beneath their feet in the dark. Aashi felt the lamp swing in her fist and clutched it. Antim's palm, wet and shaking, slid in hers and found its grip again. Then the ropes took them.

They came down out of the roots like the arms of a sleeper turning over: braided, red, and warm. One looped easily round her waist. One passed beneath her arms. Two more went about her husband's shoulders and the small of his back, with a slow, absolute, unhurried strength against which it would have been foolish even to struggle, and Antim, who had been born to struggle, did so anyway, for exactly as long as it takes a man to understand that he is a fish on a line. He went limp. His breath sobbed once in his chest. "Aashi," he said. "Aashi, the gun. I dropped the —"

"Let it lie."

"It is the only —"

"Antim. Let it *lie*."

He did. Behind them, in the mud, among the goats and the insects and the little patient bells, the revolver that had killed an old woman lay on its side with its barrel to the wall and was left to its rust. Aashi saw it as they were drawn away, one small black shape in the lamplight, and then the dark folded over it, and she was surprised, and a little ashamed, at how little she minded.

They went down the passage of the dead feet first, like people carried to a bed. The smiling faces passed over them in their niches, row upon row, the rotted shawls, the dry brown fingers folded in the laps, the little loops of red at every throat; and every head, as they passed, inclined by the smallest of margins toward the lamp. The smell lessened. She did not know why, and then she did. It was the marigold. It had thickened and sweetened until it drowned the rot beneath it, as incense drowns a corpse in a temple, and she understood that the thing which hauled them was not covering a stench out of shame but out of hospitality. One scents the room before a guest.

It is preparing us, she thought, and her hand tightened on her husband's until the bones ground. *It is making us comfortable.*

Behind them, from a long way off, something heavy and soft was following. She did not look around. She did not need to. She heard the hiss of the old woman's white sari dragging on the earth, and a pale thread of the same braided red lifting it, little by little, out of the mud, and the soft rolling thump of a small bundle carried after. The Lord had not left Hajurama in the dark. Whatever else the Hanging Lord was, He did not leave what was His. He did not let anything go.

The passage dropped.

It did not do so gradually, as the stairs had. It simply ceased to be a passage and became a shaft, a smooth steep throat in the living earth, spiralling down and down with the roots twisting past in a blur of white. Their feet had left the ground entirely. They hung on their cords, their joined hands the only fixed point in a universe that was falling, and the lamp-flame bowed and trembled in the hollow of Aashi's palm and did not go out; and she thought, with the odd cold clarity of the very frightened, *the lamp is what tells the rope which way is down.* It was true. Down was where the flame pointed when she turned it sideways. And down was where they were going.

Antim was whispering. She bent her head to him and heard it. It was the number. It was not four hundred and eleven this time, nor twenty-nine, but a smaller, steadier, older sum, the one he said when he could think of nothing else. *One. One, one, one, one.* One wife. One hand. One lamp. One of everything that mattered.

"I am here," she said. "Antim. I am here."

"I know."

"Say it."

"You are here." His voice cracked. "I am here. I will not let go."

You let go once, said a small cold unfair voice in the back of her mind, and she put it down, as one puts a sleeping child in a cot, and did not look at it again that night.

Then the walls fell away and the shaft opened and they were out.

❦

She would never afterwards be able to say how large it was.

She would tell it to herself in a dozen ways. It was a temple. It was a palace, if palaces were built of living wood and filled with the dark of the sea. It was the inside of the world, and the world was hollow, and hung with ropes. But none of the words held, because nothing in her life had given her a measure for it. The lamp-flame in her fist threw its small gold ring out into a night that took it and gave nothing back. Above her the roof was lost. Below her was the dull wet gleam of a lake. In between, wherever the light fell, wherever it failed to fall and she merely *felt* the presence of the thing, there was rope.

It hung from the invisible ceiling in rows. It hung in thousands, straight and pale and motionless, as the stems of some enormous upside-down forest might hang, each one as long as a street, and every one was knotted. Fist-sized knot upon fist-sized knot ran down its length like beads, a lock of hair in the heart of each, and at the lower end of every rope, not one hand's breadth above the black water, there swung a little parcel of red cloth.

It was small. It was no bigger than a loaf. It had been wrapped by someone with careful fingers, and tied with a twist of red thread, and set to hang in the dark, swaying with the slow imperceptible motion of a thing that is being rocked.

They were *cradles.*

She saw it at last, as they were borne through the ranks of them, with the dim shapes turning on either side, and a hundred, and a thousand, and thousands more going off beyond the lamplight into the dark. Each of them was a hair-lock in a swaddle. Each was a boy. A scrap of brown down from a newborn in Dhuwakot who had been carried by his mother to the foot of a pipal tree in a year before Aashi's own grandmother was born, while an old woman with a ladle in her hand tied a knot in a rope and said a word; and the knot had gone up,

and the hair had gone *down*, down through the tree and the stone and the hill, and had been wrapped, and hung, and kept.

For seven generations, she thought. *Somebody has been collecting them.*

"Antim," she said. "Look."

"I am looking." His voice was hoarse. "I am looking, Aashi, and I do not think I can bear it."

"Not the cradles. Past them."

A hundred paces on, where the forest of ropes ended, the ground rose from the water in a broad shallow dais of beaten earth, and on the dais, with its back to the far wall of the world, there stood the chair.

She had pictured it only once, in the cave, for the length of a breath. It was vast. It was more so now. It was built of root and bone and braided rope, in the plain, upright, unornamented pattern of an old village seat, such as the head of a household sits on to be obeyed; but every plank of its back was a thighbone, and every spoke of its arms a rib, and the great knotted roots twisted up from its feet and over its shoulders like the coils of a throne in a dream. It was worn smooth. It was worn smooth at the arms by hands, by the long slow stroking of two hands, laid down side by side and moved over and over the same polished curve for longer than the oldest of the Hajuramas had lived, in the way a man's fingers will wear a groove in the rail of his father's porch.

It was empty. And above it, hanging from the roof in the dark, so high that it was lost in the gloom, swung the single noose.

The ropes brought them down gently upon the earth.

It was so soft that she hardly felt it. Her boots took her weight. The red cord that had circled her waist drew away, uncoiling and slipping up into the dark as a bandage slipped from a healed arm. Antim's followed. For an instant they stood in the empty air of the dais, unbound, with their hands still locked in a fist between them and the lamp upright in her palm, two small figures on a great bare floor, and the quiet came down around them like the lid of a box.

Behind them, with great delicacy, another cord set Hajurama down.

It laid her upon the earth at the foot of the chair, on her back, her white sari straightened, the red border laid out smooth on either side like a road. It folded her thin brown hands upon her breast. It closed, with a touch so light that Aashi saw it only because she was looking,

the blind and staring eyes. Then it brought the bundle, the red bundle that had rolled into the mud, and it laid that, too, at her side, within the circle of her arm, as one lays a child beside its mother in a bed.

It did not unwrap it. It did not need to. Antim's face, in the lamplight, turned the colour of paper.

"Why is it —" he began.

"Hush."

"She is *dead.* I shot her. Why would it — why would it do that?"

"Antim, hush."

For there was a presence in the hollow now that had not been there before. It had not entered. It had been there all the time. It was only that, as a man who has been staring at the dark for a long while becomes aware, with a small chilling lurch, that the shape in the corner of the room is not a coat on a chair, she became aware of Him.

He hung before the chair.

He hung with His back to them, a little way beyond the lamp's reach, between the dais and the roof. The vast bowed shoulders. The long wet curtain of white hair that swept the floor, and swung, very slightly, with the slow rhythm of the rope that held it. The great grey hands hung loose at His sides, and from the tips of the fingers, one by one, fell drops that struck the earth like heavy coins. He had come ahead of them. He had led them here. He had been waiting for them to be set down, as a host waits for guests to be seated, or a cat for a thing to stop running; and now that they were still, now that the dust had settled and the ropes had drawn away and nothing in the world remained but a married couple and a dead woman and a lamp, He turned His head.

He did not turn it far. It was the barest quarter of an inch: the tilt of a head that hears a name. But the breath went out of Aashi's lungs as if a hand had closed on them.

And in the hollow, from somewhere in the roots, from the thousand knots at once, from the chair and the cradles and the black wet floor and the roof of the hill, there rose a voice.

It was not loud. It had not been loud, in the passage, when it said *Come.* It was not the voice she had imagined for it. It was an old, slow, level voice, courteous, rusted with disuse, like a well-rope drawn up for the first time in a century; and it was not one voice. That was what she heard last and understood first. Under the courtesy there was a second

voice, thin and high and wet, like a child with a cold, and under that a third, flat and heavy and male, a headman's voice, and they took turns, without a seam, as hands take turns on a rope. It was not a man's, and it was not a woman's. It spoke in a tongue older than any she had learned, a tongue of long vowels that no mouth in the valleys had shaped in two hundred years, and she understood it at once, in the way that one understands, in a fever, the speech of one's own mother. She knew what every word had once meant. And when it was done she found that she had been told, plainly and courteously, in the manner of a king receiving ambassadors:

"Well done. Well done. Blessed are these two beings, who found the courage to walk into my mouth."

She could not speak.

"I tell you the truth: seven generations have passed, and no one has come here on his own feet. All were dragged by their fear. You have come."

On our own feet, thought Aashi. *We came in a ring of lamplight, holding hands, because a person in a scarf taught us how. We did not come on our own feet at all.*

But she did not say it. A child could have told her that this was not a thing to correct.

Beside her Antim had begun to shake. It was not the shaking of fear. She knew his fear, every register of it, from the sudden stillness to the glassy politeness, and this was none of those. It was a deeper, slower trembling, such as a great beam shows in a house when a heavy cart goes by in the road; and she understood, with a sinking heart, that her husband was hearing a thing that she had not. He was listening to the *tone.* He was listening to the voice that had said, *Count,* in the dark, in his father's mouth. It was the same voice. It was exactly the same, with the barracks taken out of it, and something else put in.

"You," Antim said. It came out in a croak. "You. In the cave. You were — you spoke to me. With —"

"No, my son."

The word hung in the air between them. *My son.* It was said so plainly, so tenderly, that Antim's mouth fell open and nothing came out of it at all. And it was only afterwards, when she went back over it, that Aashi understood what had been wrong with the tenderness. It was too exact. It was a tenderness that had been learned from watching, as a

mimic learns a voice, and it fitted the word as a mask fits a face: perfectly, and with nothing behind it.

"You showed me. I only listened. A father always walks behind the son. That is all I know. And what walks behind a man," said the voice, softly, "can always be found."

"I don't —"

"I think," said Aashi slowly, "that He means your father was never in the cave."

Antim stared at her.

"I think He means you brought him. He was already in you. It only —" She searched for the word, and was a little frightened to find that she had it. "It only *heard*."

The great head tilted a little further. Somewhere above them the rope creaked.

"Ah. This woman is wise."

It was said with a kind of dry, rusted, delighted approval, as a teacher says it who has waited a very long time for a pupil to ask the right question. And then, softly, as though the whole of the vast hollow had leaned in with Him to hear:

"Now, my children: listen to this story. Until today, no one has heard of it. Those who were dragged here did not live to understand it. I did not wish them to. I wish *you* to. A curse that is not understood is only a misfortune. I want to have a witness."

The lamp stood straight in her fist. Hajurama lay at the foot of the chair with her hands on her breast. And the Hanging Lord of Dhuwakot, who had been spoken of in the valleys of Nepal in whispers for two hundred years, did a thing that none of the village's mothers, in all their generations of fear, had ever imagined He might do.

He waited for them to sit.

❦

Two seats came down out of the dark.

They were plain, small, and slung from rope. Each was a broad flat plank bound at the corners with four hanging cords that rose and rose and vanished among the roots, such as one sees at the Dashain fair in any hill village in Nepal, hung from a bamboo frame and pushed by

laughing hands. They came to rest, side by side, a hand's breadth from the earth, and swayed a moment, and were still.

Antim looked at them as a man looked at the scaffold.

"No," he said. "Aashi. No."

"It is a chair," said Aashi.

"It is a *swing*. It is the same, it is the one in the — the one they —" He could not get the sentence out. "The eldest boy of the oldest house, sat down in a loop and pushed three times —"

"I know." She was looking at the seat, not at him. Her voice was very quiet. "I know what it is. He knows that we know. That is why He has sent two." She drew a breath. "He has not sent one, Antim. He could have sent one."

It took him a moment. Then, slowly, the rigidity went out of his shoulders. They sat. The planks took their weight without a creak. Their joined hands lay in the narrow space between the two seats, in the circle of the cords, as a letter lies between two readers, and they hung there, a foot above the earth, rocking very faintly, in the full cold breath of the Hanging Lord, and waited to be told what they were for.

The swings moved of their own accord. Once, a long slow push from nowhere, so that Aashi's stomach rose; and twice, higher; and then, before the third, they stopped, and hung quivering, as a hand stopped that had decided to wait. She understood that she had been shown something. It was not a threat. It was a reminder of who owned the rhythm.

She had not meant to speak. She had meant, at that moment, to say nothing. She had been taught to say nothing in rooms where the other person held the power, to take notes and keep her face still and let a man talk until he hanged himself with his own sentences. But the great grey back was before her, with its knotted spine and its bowed white head, and the voice had said *this woman is wise*; and a thing rose in her chest from a place she had not known she kept, and she said it before she could consider it.

"May I ask you something?"

The rope creaked. The head did not move.

"I have been speaking behind my back," said Aashi. She was astonished at how reasonable it sounded. "For a few minutes. We were told that nobody sees your face. We were told it was not permitted. I do not mean to be a bother to you. But I have sat across a table from a

great many people in my life, and I have never once managed to understand a person who had his back to me." Her fingers were crushing her husband's. She took a breath. "Will you turn around? I would like to see who is speaking."

There was no sound in the hollow at all.

Not the rope, not the drip, not the whisper of the cradles. It was as if every one of the thousands of red parcels had stopped swinging in the dark to listen.

Then, from the ceiling, from the roots, from the knots, there came a sound that she would remember as long as she lived. It was not a growl, or a roar, or a cry. It was a sob, a small, dry, astonished catch of breath, such as a child who has been shouted at all his life, and is suddenly addressed by name. And it was followed, without a pause, by a giggle.

It was a high, light, delighted giggle, and it stopped as if a hand had been laid across its mouth.

"No one has ever dared to ask me."

"No one has ever wanted to. They were told: do not look. The women wrote that law. I made it because I was ashamed. And then I kept it because I liked it."

"But you have asked."

The great shoulders moved. They rose, and then, slowly, with a sound like a very old door, they came about.

She had prepared herself. She had thought of every face it could be. She had seen the faces in the niches, the dry brown masks with their stretched grins; she had heard of the thing her husband had dreamed on the bridge, with its blank, rope-lined face; she had seen the faces in the pages of the old books at the police academy, in the chapter on rural superstitions, that the instructors had passed round with a snigger. She had been ready for horror. She had been ready for a skull, for a rictus, for a mouth that opened in the dark.

She had not been ready for a face that she would have known in a crowd.

It hung before her, a little above the level of her eyes, in the yellow ring of the lamp. It was long, grey, and terribly thin. The cheekbones stood out of it like the ridges of a hill after rain. The neck below it was bent a little to the left, at the angle that a neck takes when a rope has been round it for a very long time, and round that neck, deep in the skin, ran the groove, pale and shining as a scar, where the braid had

bitten. The hair was white. It hung in great wet ropes about the shoulders and was heaped, here and there, with marigolds that had never faded. The garment was the colour of an old liver. It had been a woman's sari, once, a red one, wound over a coarse blouse in the manner of the hill women, and the tatters of it still hung from the left shoulder, and clung to the ribs, and floated softly behind in the cold.

But it was the eyes.

They were large, and dark, and very long, with heavy lids; and they were rimmed, still, after all the centuries, with black. The kohl had run. It had run down the cheeks in two thin streaks and dried there, in the hollows under the bones, in the way that a girl's does who has cried through a wedding. The left eye was wet and shining and full of an old, old grief. The right was dry. It was bright and fixed and it was not looking at anything in the room; it was looking at something that had happened two hundred years ago, and it was perfectly, patiently, unforgivingly glad.

And the lips, thin, cracked, faintly stained with something that had once been red, were parted in a smile.

It was the smile of the niches. It was the smile on the old brown faces, the stretched dry grin of the dead, and she had thought it a mockery; and now she saw that it was something worse than a mockery. It was *held.* It was a smile put on by will, over and over, like a man putting his shoulder to a door, and it trembled at its edges as though it hurt. It was the smile of one who had been told, all his life, that he must not smile, and who had learned to do it anyway, as a weapon, as a wall, as a way of saying: *you will not see what you have done to me.* Every few breaths it slipped. For the length of a heartbeat the face behind it was not sad at all. It was blank, and white, and utterly without love; and then the smile was found, and put back, and the face was courteous again.

She saw, on the wrists, where the arms hung, a ring of green glass bangles, fused with the grey flesh, a dozen at least, whole and unbroken. They tinkled when the arm moved.

"Oh," said Aashi. It was nothing, a breath, hardly a word. "Oh, you poor —"

The hollow went black.

It did not darken; it went black, all at once, the way a room does when a man shuts a shutter. Antim's hand clenched on hers like a vice.

Overhead, in the roots, every rope in the cave drew taut together with a sound like a hundred bowstrings, and in the lamplight the Hanging Lord's eyes were wholly dark, and the smile was a thing she did not wish to look on.

"*Do not.*"

It was the headman's voice. Flat, and low, and heavy.

"Do not say it. Not that word. Not here."

The cords hummed. A single red strand had come down out of the dark and was hanging, quite still, a hand's breadth from her husband's throat.

Then it passed. She watched it pass, as one watches a wave go down a rope. The eyes cleared; the face smoothed; the smile was found and put on, and the old courteous voice came back, a little breathless, like a man recovering his manners after a stumble on the stairs.

"Forgive me. I have heard that word before. It is a word that I dislike. I would so much rather hear the end of the story before I do what I do to those who say it. Will you let me?" The smile widened by a hair. "Thank you."

The red strand rose, without haste, and was gone.

"I am the Hanging One. That name, at least, your people gave me."

"But before I hung, I was something else."

"I was neither man nor woman. I was of the third nature."

Aashi's heart turned over once, heavily, in her chest.

"Yes," said Antim.

He said it so quietly that for a moment she did not know what she had heard. He was staring at the hanging face with his own grey, and the words seemed to come out of him without his permission, as a man says *yes* in his sleep. "The — the one with the lantern. They told us. They said — the Lord looked at them for three days, and could not decide what He was looking at. A son, which He was owed. A daughter, which He was not." He swallowed. "They said He turned them over like a coin. And in the end set them down."

The Lord's smile deepened a little.

"Yes. The lantern-bearer is mine. I do not kill my own kind. It carries a light from house to house for my little ones, and it is useful, and I do not destroy what is useful."

"I see it all. In that one I see a sister. A sister who might have been me, who stayed, and carried the lamp for the ones who spat. I do not forgive that. But I let it live."

My little ones, thought Aashi, and something went through her, very cold, very slow, like water entering a boat. *He said* my little ones.

She did not say it aloud. She only looked at the ranks of the red cradles, going away into the dark, each one swinging on its knotted rope above the water, and she thought: *he calls them his own. He means that nobody else may.*

"Prabhu," she said. It was the first time she had said it without fear. It was only a word. "Will you tell us how it began?"

And the Hanging Lord, who had never been asked, gathered the ropes of His long white hair in a hand like a bundle of dry twigs, and settled, and began.

"Before the seven generations, before your people came, where your village stands today, there was a little settlement. It was called Pipalthan. Seven houses, or eight. A headman. A swing. A pipal tree."

The voice went on, and the words with it, but a strange thing began to happen as they listened. The old tongue did not grow plainer; it was they who grew more at home in it. As the sentences drew themselves out, long and rolling, in a voice like a rope drawn through a pulley, the meaning ran ahead of them, in advance of the words, and coloured the dark. Under the old speech there was another, wordless and clear. It was the rope. It hung over the dais in its thousands; it carried the Lord's breath; and as the voice spoke, the knots began to *turn,* all of them, slowly, and the cradles to rock, and the great hollow filled with a dim, trembling, amber light that was not the lamp's, and was the colour of a morning that had passed two hundred years ago.

She saw it as one sees a thing in a dream, through the rope, through the voice. A ridge in autumn. Terraces the height of a man, cut by hand, green with late millet. Seven low houses of stone and thatch. A smoke rising straight. And on a shelf of grass at the head of the settlement, a young pipal, no taller than a barn, with a swing under it, raised on four bamboo poles for the festival, and a rope that hung from its lowest bough and was not yet knotted.

"I was the headman's second son. That is what they said I was: a son."

The pitch of the voice did not change; but a silence fell round it like a cloth.

"But I was something else inside myself. The first time I knew it, I was seven years old. My mother's cloth, a red cloth, was drying in the yard. I touched it. I wept inside, for I felt I had come home."

Antim made a sound. It was very small. He had lowered his head, and his free hand had come up to his mouth, and Aashi saw, with a shock, that he was not afraid. He was listening. He was listening as a man who has stood all his life at the door of a room where his own father was not allowed to weep.

"Mother knew. Mother knew everything. She gave me that cloth, when no one was in the house. We kept a secret together, red as a ring: my mother and I."

She saw it. She could not have helped seeing it. A low dark kitchen. A woman of thirty with strong brown arms and a mouth that was too wide for her face, bending at the hearth with a ladle in her hand, glancing over her shoulder, and from the shadow of the corner a boy of eleven, thin, long-legged, with eyes too large for him, stepping out into the firelight with a red cloth wrapped about his waist and over his shoulder, in the manner of a bride. The woman put down the ladle. She came across the room. And with a gesture of such tender and fearful haste that Aashi, who was herself carrying, felt it in her own body like a blow, she tied the cloth tighter, and smoothed it, and kissed him once on the forehead, quick, like a thief.

Aama, thought Aashi.

The picture shook, like a reflection in a pool.

"At fourteen, on the night of Vijaya Dashami, I could not help myself. It was the night of the swing. The whole settlement had come out to dance, women and men both. I put on a red cloth, and I danced in the women's line."

The amber light seemed to quicken. Aashi saw it all, and her stomach tightened with a premonition that was almost a memory. A ridge in the dusk. A fire in a great ring, and the drums beating, and the smoke going up straight. The women in their line, circling, with their bangles ringing and the red cloths bright against the flame; and in the middle of the line, with his thin arms lifted and his head thrown back and his eyes shut, a tall young person whose face she could not see, dancing with a joy so perfect and so unguarded that for a long moment,

for the length of a drum-roll, it seemed to her that nothing in the world could ever hurt him.

"I was happy. For one moment in my life, I was wholly happy."

There was a pause, in which the voice did something she had not expected. It sighed, a long, slow, shuddering sigh, as of a man easing into a warm bath; and she understood that the Lord was *enjoying* this. He was savouring the moment. Of everything that was to be told, this was the part that He loved best to remember, and He loved it because of what came next.

"A man saw me."

The drums went on, in the vision, a beat, two beats, three. Then one drum faltered. Then another. Then, one by one, as a wave of silence went through a field of grass when the wind dropped, all the dancers stopped.

"Laughter. First one man's. Then everyone's. Laughter, laughter, laughter. I did not know what to do. I stood where I was. My father came forward."

He did not shout. That was the worst of it, the thing that Aashi felt in her whole body as the vision gave it to her: that the headman of the settlement, a heavy bearded man with a ring in one ear and the lines of the harvest in his face, did not shout or strike or curse. He walked across the firelit ground in the sudden silence, with the whole village behind him, and looked at the dancer in the red cloth for a long time. Then he turned to the elders. And he said, in a voice that was low, and flat, and clear, a sentence of two short parts.

"My son is dead. Who this is, I do not know."

The voice that told it was the headman's own. It had slipped into it unawares, the way a tongue goes to a broken tooth; flat, and heavy, and without heat. And then, in the same breath, in the thin wet voice of a child:

"Mother stood among the women. Mother looked at me. Mother lowered her eyes."

Nobody in the hollow said anything. A great way off, in the dark, a drop of water fell from the roof into the lake, and the sound ran away in a long, thin, widening ring.

"I have forgiven all the men," said the Lord, in the courteous voice. "I say so, and you will see that I have: I have not forgotten one of them,

and I hurt them all. But my mother, I have never forgiven. Of all of them, her. Remember that. It will be useful to you."

"That night they decided: because of this child, blight would come upon the crops. The Goddess would be angry. We cannot keep this in our settlement. And they led me to the pipal."

❦

The vision wavered. The amber light dimmed, as a lamp dims in the draught of an opening door, and when it steadied, the dais was gone.

They sat in their rope seats in the cold of the great hollow. But around them, laid over the dark like a painting on glass, hung a hillside in the dusk. The air was blue. A young pipal, not yet the monster that it would become, spread its first great boughs over a shelf of grass, and at its foot, in the grey stone hollow of a shrine whose god had been carried off long ago, a figure crouched with its knees against its chin, wrapped in a goat-skin, shivering.

It was a boy of fourteen. It was a girl. It was a tall, thin, dark-eyed child with a shaven head, the stubble just beginning to come, and the tatters of a red cloth knotted about its waist beneath the goat-skin like a flag of truce. Beside it, on the stone, someone had left a wooden bowl. Rice, a handful of salt. No one had stayed to see it eaten.

"For three days I shook with hunger and cold. That was the first Dashain. The whole settlement feasted in the houses. I sat here beneath the pipal and looked at the smoke from my own father's roof. Seven Dashains I sat here. Seven years."

The picture ran forward like water. The pipal grew a hand's breadth. The goat-skin was patched, and patched again, with scraps of other skins. A hut of branches rose against the trunk and a fire-circle of black stones beside it. Snow came, and went, and the young person under the tree grew a head taller and learned to set a snare, and to read the weather in the shape of the cloud; and every year, at Dashain, there came a morning when the terraces below began to hum with voices.

"The swing was raised. Everyone came. That swing was for me."

She knew, even before it was shown, what they had come for. She saw the poles go up, and the long rope fed down through the bough, and the plank bound at the end. She saw the men gather. The headman's face, heavy and shut; the elders, in their white caps; the young men

with their arms linked, shoving and laughing, with a flask passed between them; and behind them the boys, a little cluster of boys of eight and ten and twelve, their eyes huge, craning to see.

"The first year they said: *Come, queen.* I ran. I was caught. I was tied to the swing. I was pushed three times."

"Three times. One, two, three. Everyone cheered. The whole settlement sang."

Aashi's nails had gone into her palm. She did not feel them. The vision had her by the throat: she saw the swing go up, higher, and higher, against the blue evening, with the figure on it small and rigid and bound at the wrists, the head thrown back, the mouth open; and she saw the men laughing, and the boys laughing, and the women in a knot at the edge of the crowd with their hands pressed to their faces and their eyes on the ground. *Three times,* she thought. *Three. The eldest boy of the oldest house, pushed three times, while the whole village sings.* In the kinnar's story it had been a festival. It was Thanksgiving. It had been, the kinnar had said, in their level voice, *an inspection.*

It had been a game.

It had been a game, and somebody had kept the rules for two hundred years, and forgotten the thing that was played.

"Every year; every Dashain: three times. And every year my tears fell into the roots of the pipal."

"In the tears there was pain. And later, there was not only pain. Out of pain, anger was made. Out of anger, silence. Out of silence, a thing that learns to wait."

So that is the mist, thought Aashi. It came to her quietly, as such knowledge does. The white gold vapour that lay in the gorge in the morning, that hid a village from soldiers and tax-collectors and the censuses of kings. The cloud that moved like water around a stone. It had not been a god's gift, at all. It had been *weeping.* Seven years of a child's tears, soaked into the roots of a tree, and the tree had drunk them and had sent them up again, year after year, in a long grey breath over the hills.

"They fed you," said Aashi. Her own voice sounded very strange to her. "The bowl. There was rice in the bowl, every morning. *Someone* fed you."

The great grey face turned to her. And on it, for a moment, there was something that she took for gladness.

"The women," said the Lord. "Yes. Sometimes, before dawn, a woman came, with her eyes cast down. She left rice. She said nothing. I never asked their names. I only said: thank you, elder sister. And not one of them ever laughed."

The gladness went. What came into its place was cold, and slow, and came up from a great depth.

"Not one of them laughed. Not one of them spoke. Not one of them stayed to see the rice eaten, or put a hand on my head, or said: *this is wrong.* You do not know how I hated them for it. A laugh I could have hated cleanly. A laugh is an honest thing. But they left their rice like a person feeding a dog in the road, and went home, and slept."

Antim gave a small, choking sound. Aashi felt his hand shake, and held it harder. *Not one.* She thought of the women at the tap this morning, with their gagris on their hips; the women of the Mothers' Courtyard, white-faced and stammering; the nine, chanting in one voice that there were nine and no more. *We do not hunt,* an old woman had said. *We welcome.* Two hundred years of a village's women, and not one of them had laughed.

That is why, she thought. *That is why they were never taken.* And then, because she was honest, and had been trained to be, she thought the other half: *No. That is not all of why.* She did not yet know what the rest of it was. She set it aside, as one sets aside a thing one has seen in the corner of the eye, and the picture moved on.

"In the fifth year, on a winter night, a woman came in the snow."

"She was from the plains. She had climbed the hills. She was in the grip of a fever. In the crook of her arm, wrapped in a cloth, a child."

"She looked at me. And she put the child in my hands. Her breath left her there."

The tree swung round her in the picture, thick and silvery with frost, and under it, in the snow, the figure of a woman lay on her side with her scarf across her face. And in the hollow of the shrine, by a blaze of damp brushwood, with his goat-skin drawn round both of them and his back to the wind, the young person from the Dashain swing sat, with his cheek against a tiny head, and rocked.

It was a boy, a little under a year. It had a fist of black hair, damp and matted, and a face as red and crumpled as a plum, and it was howling with the whole of its lungs. And the young person holding it, who had sat in the shadow of that tree for five years without a kind

word to give or receive, who had learned not to speak, who had learned not to want, was looking down into the screaming little face with an expression Aashi had seen only once or twice in her life. She had seen it on her own mother, bent over a cradle. She had seen it, a week ago, in a mirror, when she had put her hand on her own flat belly and said nothing to anybody.

"I searched for a goat, for the child's milk. By evening I had fed him. I wrapped him in my mother's red cloth. She had left it, one morning, on the stone of the shrine. She said nothing. I never saw her again."

There was a long silence in the hollow. Somewhere high in the dark a rope creaked, as if a weight had shifted in a bed.

"My own child. My son. In all those years, for the first time, someone loved me. It was a tiny child, who did not know what I was."

"I was a mother, a father, and a servant, all at once. And I began to sing: *Sleep, my jewel.*"

He sang it. He did not mean to, perhaps; the old voice cracked on the first note, as a rope cracks that has long hung stiff. It was not a song. It was a hum, a handful of low rocking notes in a tongue of long ago, repeated, and repeated, with a falling sigh in the middle of each phrase that could not have been taught. It went round the hollow and into the cradles, and the cradles began, one by one, to sway in time. It was the lullaby that had come from the loft of a stone house on the night that Aashi lay awake with a twist of rice and ash under her pillow. It was the song of the rope. *Creeeeak,* it went, and the child's breath drew in; *creeeeak,* and its cry, let go.

It was never trying to frighten us, thought Aashi, with sudden cold comprehension. *That night. The baby in the loft. It was the only song it had.* And then, close behind it, colder: *It was singing to a baby that was not its own. It was singing to a baby that it meant to have.*

Antim had covered his face with his free hand.

"*Sleep, my son, sleep, my jewel,*
in the red cloth, in the red hour.
Sleep, and wake, and do not go."

The last line was new. She had not heard it in the loft. It came out of the dark in the child's thin voice, not the old one's, and it was sung flatly, and the cradles stopped swaying all together, as if they had been told to.

"For two winters, from cold to cold, I raised him. He spoke his first word: Mother."

She saw it. She could not have stopped herself. A boy of two, broad-faced, sturdy, bare-bottomed in the summer grass, lifting both arms to a tall figure in a goat-skin who knelt to catch him, laughing with a throat so unused to laughter that it cracked like a stick; and the swing, empty, above them, turning gently in the long gold light, as if for once it had forgotten what it was for.

Then the light went out of it.

"The seventh Dashain: the swing was raised. Someone saw my child. At dawn, five men came and surrounded my hut. I said: this is my son. They laughed. They said: a hijada eats children. They said: this child must be saved."

She would not look at the next. She could not look away.

The five men came into the circle of the black stones with their staves lowered. She knew several of them. They had the faces she had seen at the rope in the square that morning, in the fields, at the bell. They were the same faces, worn by other men. They struck the young person once, in the face, and he went down, and they struck him again; and over his head, over the shouting and the noise, a child's voice rose, thin and high and piercingly clear, crying a single word.

Aama! Aama! Aama!

"My father came. My own father. The headman. He lifted my child in his arms. The same arms that cast me out. And in them, now, my child. He said: This one, at least, can be saved."

He had not raised his voice. That was what she would remember. The grey-bearded headman of Pipalthan, with his heavy shut face, had stood in the grass beside the swing with a screaming two-year-old on his hip, and looked down on the creature at his feet; and for one moment, one single moment, something moved in the father's face that might have been shame. Then it was gone. He turned away. He carried the child down the hill between the terraces, past the staring boys, among the men, and the little voice went with him, rising and falling, rising and falling, growing smaller, until it was no louder than the rope.

"The child looked back at me over his shoulder. He spoke one word. I still remember it. He said: *Ghost.*"

She had thought, in the cave, in the dream, in the rope, that she had heard every sound there was to be made by a grieving thing. She had

not. In the hollow of the world, with thousands of cradles in the dark, a sound rose up that was neither wail nor word. It was low. It was very still. It seemed to come from a long way down, from the roots, from the black bed of the lake, a long deep dragging breath such as a creature draws that has been struck a mortal blow and cannot yet cry. The hanging rope swung. The lamp-flame bowed flat, and she snatched it close against her breast.

"Stop," said Antim hoarsely. "Please. That is enough. Aashi, tell it to stop."

"No."

"It is *killing* —"

"No, Antim." She was weeping; the tears ran down her face without her permission, and her voice stayed level. "He is not killing us. He is telling us. It is the only thing He has ever been allowed to do."

The sound ended. In the hush that followed, the old voice continued; and it was a moment before she understood that something had changed in it, that the grief had been closed up like a book, and that what was speaking now was very calm.

"That night I walked seven times around the pipal. Seven times. That is how I count."

"From the rope of the swing I made one knot. The knot my mother taught me, for tying bundles of grass. Within the knot I set the first lock of the child's hair. That was the first knot."

She heard her husband's breath stop.

The first knot. They had been hunting a first knot for three days. They had begged it from a blind woman in the dark; they had followed it in a policeman's note, rolled tight in a whistle; they had stood beneath a tree and counted every one in the sun until the numbers ran out. *Who failed to tie it? Who tied it wrong? Whose hands were they?* And all the while it had hung there, in the heart of the rope, at the very top, the oldest and the smallest and the simplest of them all: a knot for tying bundles of grass, with a curl of black baby hair in the middle of it.

It had not been tied by a mother. It had not been tied by the village. It had been tied by the one person whom the village had never expected to love anything at all; and she saw, now, what a knot with a child's hair in it *was.* It was a hold. It was a claim. It was the one thing in the world that could not be carried down the hill.

"I put the rope around my own neck."

"I told myself one thing, and it mattered to me more than all the rest: I will smile. For in the morning they would find me. And I did not wish them to know what they had done."

"I put on my smile. And I let my feet leave the ground."

For a long time nobody spoke.

The picture had gone from the dark. There was only the hollow, and the faint trembling of the cradles, and the lamp in Aashi's fist, which had burned, she noticed numbly, far longer than it ought to have. Its flame stood straight and still. It was the only thing in the whole of that place that had not wept.

Antim was looking at his boots. Aashi saw that his jaw was working, and that the muscle at the corner of it, the one that jumped when he was lying, was motionless. She did not need to ask what he was thinking. She had lived with him nine years. He was thinking of a rope bridge and a river and a man in uniform who had walked halfway across, always halfway, and not turned; and of a boy of twelve on the bank who had stood with his mouth open and not run after him. She thought, calmly: *Antim knows exactly what it is to be left.*

"You smiled," Antim said. His voice was a rasp, but it was steady. "You said that you smiled, so they would not know what they had done. Prabhu. Why?"

The great head turned toward him with a slow, courteous, almost curious motion.

"Because, my son, pride was all they had left me. If my enemies found me weeping, they would have won. But if they found me smiling: they would doubt their judgement, for all their days."

Antim lifted his head. For a moment, he and the Hanging Lord looked at one another across the empty air, and there was something in it that Aashi had seen exchanged only between two policemen across a table, at the end of a long night, when one has come to the end of the confession and the other is about to speak.

"It did not work," Antim said, quietly. "Did it."

The smile came off.

It did not fade. It came off, all at once, like a hand taken from a face, and what was under it was so naked, and so hungry, and so purely and impersonally *angry* that Aashi's body moved before her mind could, drawing her husband's arm against her own.

"No," said the Lord. "It did not work. They never doubted. They said in Pipalthan: *the hijada hanged himself from our own swing.* That was all. Not a word more. A few years later, famine came, and the whole settlement went away, and not one of them ever wondered what he had done."

He put the smile back. It took Him two tries.

"I did not die as the good die. Do not imagine it. I did not go up. I stayed, because there were things I had not finished. I went on hanging in the pipal. And the pipal held me, as no one ever had."

The amber light came back, and with it the rope. The cradles stirred. In the dark above her head Aashi saw a tree, the same tree, grown vast; its roots driving down through leaf-mould and rock and gravel and the dead of centuries; and in its lowest bough a thin grey thing that swung and swung and did not rot.

"I felt it: the roots began to touch my body. I was afraid. But I was already inside. I had become a part of the pipal. My tears became water, and the water became cloud, and the cloud settled upon the hills. And I waited. Do you know what I did, for all those years? I thought. I thought of every face at the swing. I learned them. I still have them, every one, and the faces of their children."

Dhuwa, thought Aashi. The old name came to her whole. *Dhuwakot.* It meant the fort of smoke, the fort of mist. The families who named their village had meant a refuge. They had not known whose breath they were naming.

"Seven generations ago, on a winter evening, forty families came. A load on their backs, the ashes of their dead in their hands, and hunger in their eyes. A widow, Rukmini, came before me."

She stood under the tree in the dusk, the picture said, with a child at her hip. She was a small, square, work-roughened woman of thirty, with a shawl over her head, in a crowd of her people, each with a bundle and a brass pot; and the mist, as the Lord remembered it, lay about them like a grey sea, and the little ones cried, and there was no fire. And Rukmini, who had lost a husband to the tax-collectors and two daughters to the fever, and who held in the crook of her arm, wrapped in her own wool, a boy of eleven months with a flushed face and a rattling breath, stepped forward alone and looked up into the face of the thing on the bough.

She did not scream. She did not flee. She looked at it for a long time, closely, as a woman looks at a cut of meat in a bazaar. And she said, in the flat dry voice of one used to dealing with landlords:

"*Sir, we are tired, we are hungry, and we have nowhere to go.*"

"*Will you give us a place in your hearth?*"

The voice in the hollow broke.

It broke the way a plank breaks when a great weight is set upon it, with a long creaking and then a snap. Under the sound she heard her husband draw a breath, and understood, with an odd rush of tenderness, that the thing on the rope had been waiting all those years to be asked; and that no one, in all that time, had ever asked it. And she was ashamed of the tenderness a moment later, when the voice went on, and she heard what it was made of.

"*Sir.* In life, and in death, no one had ever spoken to me as *sir.* A woman, who was like my own mother, looked into my eyes, and did not look away. She called me *sir.* What was I to do? I did what I knew. I gave them the mist."

"But in the middle of that night, Rukmini came to me again, alone, and whispered: *Sir, you have no one, and you want something. What is it that you want?*"

Aashi's eyes stung. *You have no one. And you want something.* Nine years she had sat across tables from the lonely, the cruel, the wounded and the half-mad, and she had never once seen the thing said so simply.

"I spoke a single word. The first in all those years. It was all I could manage. *A son.*"

There was a silence in the hollow, and in it, from all the cradles together, a faint small whisper, like leaves.

"Rukmini understood. A mother would. She thought I wanted a child to love. I let her think about it. It was *kind* of me to let her think about it."

The voice paused, and enjoyed the pause.

"What I wanted was something that could not leave."

"Oh," said Aashi. It escaped her, in a whisper. "Oh — that was the price."

"Yes. That was the price."

"Rukmini cut a lock from her own son's head. She set it in the knot. She said: *Father, this is your son. You must care for him as for one of*

your own house. Beside my first knot, I set hers. Two knots. A father and a son. A rope for a son. A son for a rope."

A rope for a son.

It had been written in the notebook in her lap, in her husband's neat hand, underlined twice. It had been said on a stone bench in the sun. She had thought it was an exchange. She had thought of a bill of lading: *thus much given, thus much received.* It had been nothing of the sort. It had been the other thing. It has been the thing that old women do at the births of grandchildren in every hill village in Nepal, when they take a lock of the baby's hair and tie it into a cord and set it in the household shrine, and say to the gods: *this one is yours as well, watch over him.* A guardian. A godfather. A second father, to whom one sends the child's first hair.

They asked a dead man to be a father. She felt the tears again, hot and silent. *And he said yes. And he heard it as* mine.

The Hanging Lord was looking at her. His head had come a little closer, on its tilted neck, and the old eyes were bright with something that she took for sorrow and that was, she saw, a great deal more like appetite.

"And I did the work of a father. For a hundred years, in forty houses, not one child died. I heard the name of every son. I held the hair of each in my hands. Each time a child was born in a house, I made a little cradle in my roots, and I rocked it, and I did not let go. I never let go of any of them. Not one."

He lifted a hand, and the hand was shaking. He lifted it toward the ranks of the cradles, going away into the dark, in their thousands, with the red cloth rocking and the little hair-locks in their hearts; and Aashi saw that at his touch, from every one of them, the faintest lamp of light came up: a glow, such as one sees in a field of fireflies. It was not the light of the lamp. It was warmer. It was the light of breath.

"Look. These are my sons. I rock them still. Even those who died. Even those who grew old. Even the ones whose mothers wept at their funerals. They came to me in the end, down through the root, and I have not set one of them down. *I do not set things down.*"

"Dear God," whispered Antim.

It was not a prayer. It was the sound that a man makes in front of a thing so large that his own mind has no place to put it. And Aashi, who had been listening for the word *love,* found that it had been said again

and again and that not once had it meant a hand opening. It had meant a hand closing.

"But it changed," said Aashi.

She said it because someone had to. The old thing would not; it had hung, with those wet bright eyes upon her, and gloated through an hour, and a century, and the long pleasant music of the knots; and she saw in the way that He turned His head from her that He would have gone on, if she had let Him, into the good years forever. She had seen it before. It was the way a witness will linger at the first sweet part of a bad story. "It changed, Prabhu. The kinnar said there were deaths, once. In daylight, as readily as in the dark. Fathers. Brothers. Grown sons. What happened?"

The face closed, as a hand closed.

It was like watching a lamp go out in a room. The light in the cradles dimmed. The great shoulders drew up. And the old voice, when it came, was lower and flatter, and had lost the courteous roll of its long vowels.

"The sons grew. The generations changed. By the fourth generation, no one called me *Father.* In some houses the word was used as a curse. The young man laughed: *He is a hijada's child!* They said it of their own sons. A father beat his boy and said: *Go, then, and cry to your other father, in the tree.*"

The cradles had gone entirely dark. Not one stirred. And in the hush she heard, from the roots above her, a sound that was very like the grinding of teeth.

"I heard it. I heard it all. In the roots of the pipal, every word. One night, one boy, eight years old, called out to me when his father was beating him. And I drew the father up into the rafters of his house. A rope about his throat."

The Lord did not say what had happened afterward. He did not need to. She saw the village from above, in the grey dawn, with a single man hanging from the rafters of a house in the middle of a terrace, and the women crowding at the doors, and a boy of eight huddled in a corner of the porch with his hands over his ears, who did not cry, and did not look up, and was alive.

And that was the first, thought Aashi. *That was the first father and the first son. Not a sacrifice. A rescue.* She thought it, and then she looked at the Lord's face and did not think about it any more.

"That was the first," said the Lord. "People say that I repented. I have let them say it. It is a good story and I have told it myself. But I will not tell it to *you,* because you are going to hear the end of it, and you would know. I did not repent. When the man's weight came onto the rope, I was glad. It was the first time since they took my son that I had been glad. I felt it go down through the roots into me, a father's whole weight, hanging, and it was *sweet.* I have not been glad in any other way since."

Antim made a noise like a man struck.

"The village saw. All the men cried: *The Hanging One has killed!* They read it as they read all things, through fear. They did not know what it was they were afraid of. I did: it was me. It was my own face. I had not known that they would take such care to make me a monster. So I obliged them. The men came to the pipal with fire and axes."

Aashi's hand went to her mouth. She did not need the vision. She saw it in the firelight of her own mind: thirty or forty men, in their winter shawls, with torches in one hand and woodcutters' axes in the other, climbing the shelf of grass in the blue of a winter dawn; the faces she knew from the tap, the school, the terraces; the great-grandfathers of the men who barred their doors tonight. They had come to burn a tree. They had come, with the cheerful rough sense of villagers who have decided to be rid of a nuisance, to cut down their *other father.*

"I killed them all. Fathers. Brothers. Sons, grown sons. By daylight. Before the whole village. In that hour I was a monster."

"No," said Aashi.

The word came out before she could stop it. The Lord's head came round. She did not know what she meant to say, only that it was not true, and that she was a policeman, and a policeman did not let a false word stand when it was said about a person who could not defend himself.

"You were a man," she said, "who had been tied to a swing. And pushed three times. And whose child was carried off with the word *ghost* in his mouth. And then —" She stopped to breathe. "And then you were a man who, having let them have their rope and their mist and their hundred years, was threatened with fire. I am not saying that it

was right, Prabhu. I will not say that. They were fathers. They had children. But I will say that it is not what *monster* means."

The hollow was silent.

Then, from the roots, from the cradles, from the lake, there came a sound that she had no name for. It was the Lord, laughing. It began as the giggle she had heard before, and it grew, and cracked, and became something else, until the whole hollow shook with it and the ropes swung and the lamp-flame ducked and shuddered; and it went on for a long time, and it was the most terrible sound she had ever heard, because there was real delight in it.

"A *man.* She says a man. Oh, you are kind. You want me a man because a man can be forgiven. You want to forgive me. Everybody forgives me. It is the cruellest thing the living do."

The laughter stopped, as a lamp was shut.

"I was a monster in that hour, woman, and I was happy. Do not take it from me. It is the only thing I have that is wholly my own. I looked at their faces and they were afraid *of me,* me, at last, and not of a thing that had been made of me; and I thought: *so this is how it is to be seen.* I would do it again. I *have* done it again. A hundred times."

Aashi said nothing. She had no breath for it. She had just understood that she had been trying, all this time, to find the place in the Hanging Lord where a hand could be laid, and that the Lord had known it, and had been waiting, and had just closed it up in front of her with a smile.

"You speak. Why?" said the Lord, mildly. "Because you, too, are a mother."

She did not know how He knew. She had told no one in Dhuwakot. But under the shawl, where her hand lay flat against the hollow of her stomach, something warm and small seemed to stir, once, like a light under water.

"And in your womb, a son."

"Yes," whispered Aashi.

The face of the Hanging Lord did a strange thing then. It folded. There was no other word: it creased, and sank, and for an instant, in the ruin of that long wet cheek, she saw the child of fourteen, with the red cloth about his waist, who had stood at the edge of the dancing in the firelight and heard laughter come across the ground.

Then the child was gone, and what looked out of the place where he had been was hunger. It was nothing else. It was the whole width of the face, and it was fixed on her belly, and it did not blink.

"I see, in that womb, the future of your child. I will speak of it later. First, let me finish my story."

❦

"The mothers thought."

"The women of the forty houses, led by a woman of Rukmini's line, assembled beneath the pipal one night. Their men were dead or cowering at home, and they planned a pooja."

She could see them. The picture had come back with the quickness of a nightmare, and it was an image she would never be able to put away: forty women in white and red, kneeling in a half-ring on the cold ground at the foot of a great tree, with their saris pulled over their heads and their eyes cast down; and at the centre of the ring, a young woman with a ladle in her hand and a brass pot at her knee, a tall, plain, hard-handed woman of thirty or so, with Rukmini's square jaw. She did not look up at the tree. Not one of them did. They had learned that. They had been taught, at great cost, that they must not look.

"They did not seek to destroy me. They sought peace. The word of the pooja was: *Father.* And its first law: *By day, you are our father.* And by night I was *Lord.*"

"The law had three clauses: *By day you shall not harm our sons. By night we shall not look upon you. And we shall give you a knot every birth, and, when needed, a gift.*"

Antim let out a long breath. "A treaty," he said. "That is a treaty. A divided day."

"Yes, my son. It was a treaty. By day, they called me *Father,* and their love bound me. By night, they barred their doors, and did not look upon my face. It was a mercy and a snare, and I knew it. I accepted it. Because, for the first time since the swing, they were offering me the name of *Father* again. A beaten dog takes the hand that feeds it. A beaten dog has no choice."

The voice stopped. When it came again the courtesy was gone from it, entirely, as a coat was shed.

"I took the name. I took the knots. I took their gifts. And I hated every day of it. A father! They wanted a *father,* a tame thing in a tree, to keep their sons from harm. They did not want *me.* Do you understand? The pooja was built on a lie, and the lie was that I could be thanked."

Aashi's mouth had gone dry. She thought of the nine clay lamps on the platform at the foot of the tree. She thought of the old woman in the courtyard with the brass pot, humming as she poured. *The keeping of the knots belongs to the eldest of the mothers.* She thought: *every dawn she says the Word. Every dusk she lights the lamps. And the Word, and the lamps, are the whole of the treaty.*

And tonight no one lit them.

"But one thing, my children, you do not understand. A treaty cannot be made out of fear. The first generation understood it, for they tied their knots from love. The second did not. The third remembered only the *words.* And when it is only words, the pooja is a thread. And a thread, in time, breaks."

The lamp trembled in her fist.

"Every night, in every house, a bar goes across a door. *Father, do not call on us.* A child begins to call me *Father.* And his mother stops his mouth. I hear it every night. A thousand times. A hundred years. Every bar is a stone thrown in my face. And I have never learned to bear a stone."

"It was the doors," said Aashi, softly.

She understood now. She understood it in the pit of her stomach, as one understands a joke that one's own family has been telling for years. The curfew. The bars. The shutters pinned from within and the planks nailed over the windows; the men running home from the terraces with the bell in their ears; the nine mothers with their sons pressed to their chests in the firelight, and a father with a khukuri across his knees, saying to a child of six: *be that, be that always.* The village had built a wall of fear around the Lord to keep Him out, and every stone of that wall was a *No* spoken to a man who had been told *no* all his life.

It was never the pooja that bound Him, she thought. *It was the thing that the pooja was made of. And the thing that the pooja was made of was love. They starved it of love, and fed it fear, and the treaty rotted from the inside, and He grew.*

"You overcame it," she said. "The pooja. It did not break. You outgrew it."

"Yes."

"From their fear I drew my strength. Every night, by the bar upon their doors, they made me stronger."

The Hanging Lord drew Himself up. For an instant, in the dim light of the cradles, He seemed to grow; the long shadow of Him went away over the lake, and the roots shook, and a fine rain of dust sifted down.

"And I will tell you the rest of it, since you are so wise. I came to love the bars. Fear is warm. It is the only warmth they ever gave me, and it was given every night, in every house, by every hand. It was the one way they could think of me. And I was *thought* of. Do you know what that is, after the swing? To be the reason a whole house lies awake? To be the thing in the throat of every sleeper? I have been wept over, whispered over, counted over, prayed to and prayed against, for two hundred years. I would not exchange it. I would sooner be feared than not be there."

He smiled.

"And today, the last thread has broken, too."

It was Aashi who looked at the old woman first.

She had not meant to. She had been looking at the Lord's hands, at the green glass bangles that rang when He moved, and the looking had carried her gaze down the long grey arm and the trailing red cloth to the earth at the foot of the chair, where Hajurama lay on her back with her thin hands folded and her eyes shut and the bundle against her side. In the amber light, in that great hush, she looked very small. She looked like a child who has been put down for the night in a bed too big for her.

I held the door, she had said. *All my life.*

"Prabhu," said Aashi. Her voice was not quite steady. "She told us that you took her eyes. She told us it was the only thing you ever did to her. She said that you did not kill her, because that would have been a kindness." She swallowed. "She is the one woman in the whole history of the village that you have ever touched. Why?"

The Hanging Lord did not answer for a long time.

When He turned His head, His eyes went to the dead woman, and stayed there, and the look that came into His face was one that she knew, and did not at first trust. She had seen it on the faces of mourners at a hundred door-steps in a dozen villages, in the first raw hour, when the body is still warm, and the grief has not yet found the shape it will

take. It was quiet. It was exhausted. It was a look of tenderness so naked and so unguarded that she almost turned away. She looked again, harder, as she had been taught to look at a man who was weeping too well.

It was tenderness. That was the horror of it. It was real. It was only that it was the tenderness a man has for a thing he has owned for sixty years and has broken.

"Phulmaya."

He said it softly, and the word fell in the great hollow like a coin into a well.

"That was her name. No one remembers it, but her name was Phulmaya. She was nineteen. She had been two years married. She had no child. There was a boy, who was not hers. Hari. Six years old."

It came as the others had come, from the rope: quickly, in light. The Mothers' House, but the Mothers' House as it had been, newer, with dark beams not yet blackened by sixty more winters of smoke. A cold dawn. A huddle of women in a half-ring around a pot, and in the middle of the ring a girl of nineteen, thin, wide-mouthed, in a plain red sari, kneeling with a small boy held hard against her chest. He was dark and solemn. His hair stood up in a tuft. He had no shoes. He had the look of a child who has learned that it is safest to be very quiet.

"Hari's mother had died of the fever, and his father was coughing sickness. He was nobody's son. That year, famine came. A council of the mothers sat. They decided: a gift beyond the knot must be given. A boy whom no one would miss."

Antim breathed out. He did it slowly, like a man setting down something he had been holding at arm's length. "The women," he said. "The women chose him."

"Yes, my son. The women. They did not choose out of knowledge of what I wanted. They chose because they said: *it is a god's due.* And because the men said: *the boy is another mouth.*"

It was never a hunt, thought Aashi. *It was a sacrifice, and nobody asked the god what he wanted.* She thought of nine mothers in the courtyard, reciting a lie in a single voice. She thought: *they have been giving him the wrong thing for two hundred years.*

"I never hurt those children," said the Lord. "I held them for three days, sang to them, and set them down at dawn. That was the whole of

my comfort: that for three days I might hold a child that had been given and was not taken back."

Antim made a small sound.

"The kinnar," he said hoarsely. "That is what happened to the kinnar. You did not harm them. You held them for three days, and you sang. And in the end you set them down."

"Yes. That one is my sibling. And I let it down, and it went back to them. And do you know, it went back, and washed their feet, and carried a lamp to their children. I have never understood it. I hold it, a little, against all of you."

He stopped, and for a moment the green bangles rang in the stillness, and she thought: *He is not telling us this because it is true. He is telling it so we will think He is gentle.*

"But Phulmaya did not know this."

The picture slid on. It was night, and the stair; and up the stairs, in the dark, with a single torch of pine-pitch held high by a woman in front, came a procession of women, in single file. They were singing. It was the old low song of the Dashain, the one that Aashi's own mother hummed at the tika, with its long falling cadences; and in the middle of the line, carried in the arms of a stout old woman in white, with his bare feet dangling and his eyes enormous, went a small boy in a clean shirt. Behind the last of the singers, a little way behind, a girl of nineteen followed in the dark with her shawl over her head. She had not been told to come. She was walking very quietly, with her feet set down on the outer edges of the treads. She was counting. Aashi saw her lips move. *Four hundred and ten. Four hundred and eleven.*

"She followed behind. She broke the law. *When the rope moves, none may look.* But Phulmaya looked. Because, my son, she had served me; and she said: *I will look. I want to see what it is that I have served.*"

"The same," said Aashi, very low. "She said it to us. In the cave. *I wanted to see what it was that I served.*"

"At that hour she beheld my face."

For the second time in the long night, the hollow was utterly still.

It was Antim who understood it first. He had put out his free hand, without knowing it, and laid it flat against the cold air as though against a wall. "She saw you," he said. "A girl of nineteen. A married woman, in a village where women do not look at you, who had come to save a boy. She saw you hanging. And she did not scream."

"She said: *Sir, do not take this child.* She said: *He is mine. Not till today, but from today, he is mine.* And she went on looking at me. There was no fear in her eyes."

The old rusted voice had dropped almost to a whisper. In the amber light the great hollow seemed to hold its breath. Aashi saw the girl in the vision, standing alone on the earthen dais in the glare of the pine-torch, with her hair fallen out of its knot, and her hand stretched out toward the thing in the roof, and her head thrown back; and on her face, as the Lord had said, not terror but the pure fixed look of a woman who has seen a hurt thing in a road and does not know whether it will bite.

"There was no fear, my son. There was *pity.*"

He said the word as another man might spit.

"In all my life, for the first time, someone had pitied me to my face. My mother had pitied me, but with her eyes cast down. Phulmaya did it *looking.* And I could not bear it."

The word hung in the hollow, plain and heavy as a stone.

"I took her eyes."

"My hands were not trembling. I tell it so, sometimes, because it is a better story. They were steady. I put my thumbs to them as one presses the seeds out of a fruit. And I let Hari go, because I wanted her to know that I could. And I did not take her life, because a woman who has seen my face and lives, blind, for sixty years, and can never again see anything else, is a better witness than a corpse. She was to carry me. She *has.* I have been behind her eyes every day since, a lamp that cannot be put out."

Aashi found that she was holding her breath again. She let it go.

He took them, she thought, *because for the first time someone had looked and not laughed. He could not bear to be pitied by a person who could still turn and walk out of the cave.* It was the worst thing that she had heard that night. It was also the most human. She had seen a man break a witness's arm for the same reason. She had seen it in her own family: the cruel little spasm of pride that makes a wounded creature strike at the one hand that is held out to it. But she had never seen it kept like this, and sharpened, and turned into a thing to live by for two centuries.

"And Hari?" said Antim. He spoke gently, as he spoke to frightened witnesses. "What became of him?"

"Hari went home. And he never again, in his life, went anywhere. He read books. He taught every child of the village its ka, kha, ga. Today his hip is bad. He does not know why his life was spared. I am fond of that. I like to think of him teaching, and not knowing, and hearing the bell."

"The schoolmaster," said Aashi.

It came out as a laugh and a sob together. She pressed her fist against her mouth. *The old schoolmaster with the bad hip. Ram's promise. "I said I would go home when the bell went."* She thought of the whole of Dhuwakot's children, learning their letters in a whitewashed room, from a quiet bent man who had been carried up the stair once, on a night when he was six, and set down again; and she thought of a blind old woman in a courtyard, sending a pot of ghee every Dashain to the house of a man who did not know why.

We came here pretending to be what he is, she thought. *We have been wearing his trade like a coat.*

"Phulmaya never told him. She never once said: look what I did. She gave her whole life to me. Year after year, she came with a bundle. In a red cloth. A doll of straw."

Aashi's eyes went to the red parcel at the dead woman's side. It lay in the curve of the arm, so small, so ordinary, with its corner turned back.

"She would say: *Lord, your child has come back to you.* She fed the bundle. She sang to it. As to my own baby. Many years. Sixty years."

"I knew that it was straw. And every time, I accepted it. Do you know why? It was the only apology I had ever been offered. And an apology that is *accepted,* my son, is spent. But an apology that I took, and kept, and did not forgive, was a debt. I wanted to be owed for as long as I could. If I had forgiven her I should have had nothing."

She could not stop the tears. She did not try. She sat in the rope seat with her husband's hand crushing hers and let them fall, and she thought of the *tenth baby*, of the closed door in the courtyard and the old woman rising and the humming from the back room and the brass cup ringing on the stone; of the nine mothers who had said, *we do not talk of the tenth*; of the long sly smile of a village telling a policeman its secrets. It had not been a baby. It had never been a baby. It was a vow, carried by one woman, year after year, in a red cloth, so that no child should ever again be carried away from a man who had asked for

nothing but to hold one. And He had taken it, every year, and kept the debt.

A doll of straw, she thought. *And she sang to it every day for sixty years.*

And my husband shot her for it.

She did not look at him. She could not. But beside her, with a ragged, strangled sound, Antim began to weep.

❦

The old voice, when it went on, had gone flat.

"But Phulmaya was a woman. And there is one thing the women of that village could never refuse to do: endure. They endured everything. They endured my law. They endured their own men."

"But on that Dashain, in the year two thousand forty-nine, it all came to an end in a single hour."

The picture came back, dim, a ghost of a picture. They saw the great pipal at dusk. They saw a rope hung ready from the lowest bough and a platform of flat stones beneath, and on the platform a row of nine clay lamps, unlit, in a line. They saw an old woman with a stick, led by the elbow by a girl, crossing the trodden grass; and a crowd of men on the far side of the swing, perhaps thirty or forty, in their best dhaka topis, with a flask going from hand to hand and the high hoarse laughter of men who have had a little too much, on a feast day, in the cold.

"That day the men played again at the swing. Three times. They pushed a boy. They sang. Among them was one, Karna Bahadur, drunk with Rakshi. In his house a baby was born. His elder son, Bishal, is eight years old."

"The slate," whispered Aashi.

"Yes. Bishal was writing *ka.* Karna Bahadur came to the pipal for his newborn's first lock. Phulmaya, with her helper, stood before him. The men laughed: *Karna! Tie it with your own hand! Show the hijada how a man ties a knot!*"

She did not want to see it. She saw it. She saw the heavy carpenter's hand, thick-fingered, steady with drink, take the lock of black fluff from the old woman's palm. She saw it wind the hair once round the rope, and then deliberately, with a brutal, sure, mocking skill that only a man who has worked with timber and cord all his life could

have shown, make the knot. A long coil. A run of tight turns. A loop. A noose.

It was a hangman's knot.

"He tied a noose. He said: *Here, hijada. A rope for a son. Hang again.*"

The laughter of the men went up into the dusk like a flock of birds. Aashi felt her whole body go cold.

"Phulmaya touched the knot. She knew its shape with her fingers. She knew. She could have untied it. In a moment."

"She did not."

Aashi stared up into the ruined face. She saw the tilt of the head, and the shut mouth, and the green bangles trembling, and she waited. Behind her, in the quiet, she heard Antim's breath catch. He too had seen. He too had understood. *That is mine to carry,* an old woman had said in the dark of a cave, with her hand on a red bundle. *Whose hands were they?* Aashi had asked it; and the old woman had said *I will not say, not to you, not here.* And all the time the answer had been the simplest in the world.

Hers. The hands that held the knot. The hands that did not untie it.

"After sixty years, there comes a day in a woman's life when she knows: *Today I could stop it. Today, in a moment, I could. But I do not wish to.* She wished it all to end. She wished that the Hanging One would show His anger. To the village, to those men, to all. And I showed it."

The great shape above them drew itself up. The light of the cradles darkened. In that moment, in the full black dark of the hollow, she heard, as clearly as if it had been breathed in her ear, a thin high sound like the rope of a swing stretched to its limit. It was the sound the pooja made, she realised, as it parted: the thread of a hundred years snapping, one fibre at a time.

"She let me out of my cage, and she did not even know she had held the door. Sixty years she served me; she thought she was serving a father. She was serving a knife. At last she grew tired of holding it by the blade."

"That night I took Karna Bahadur. And Bishal. I took Bishal too. For, my son, a new law was made for me: *For one knot, a father and a son.* For a noose, a noose. A father and a son, together. Neither shall leave the other."

Aashi's voice, when it came, was not her own. "Why both?" she said. "Prabhu. Why do you take both?"

The Hanging Lord turned. For one instant His eyes were wholly black, and the ruined mouth, still curved in its smile, was a thing she did not want to look at. Then something went out of Him, like a breath, and when He spoke His voice was tired.

"I see my own father. I see my own son."

"A father carried a son away. A father drove a child out. I see it in every father. And seeing it, I say: *I shall never let them part.* I take the father, so that no son is left in a house without one, as I was. I take the son, so that no father is left in a house without one, as I was. I make them even. Then I keep them. Do you see how gentle that is? It is what I would have wished for myself."

"That is the law of a man who cannot bear being the only one left," said Aashi, slowly, before she could stop herself.

The smile slipped, and was put back.

"The shoes," said Antim.

He said it hardly above a whisper. His voice was ragged, but he was looking up, with an expression Aashi had never seen on his face: it was the look of a man who has dropped a stone into a well, and has at last heard it strike the water. "The cave. The beds. The shoes at the end of the passage, the boots, then the sandals, then the little ones, in the same order. Twenty-nine pairs of shoes. You did not scatter them. You did not hide them. You set them out in a row, and the little ones stand in the same order as the big ones. Father and son. Father and son. Nine times."

"Yes. Father and son, together. Your eyes saw it. I laid them in my cradles, pair by pair. I put them to sleep. The father holds the son in his arms, and the son holds the father. They feel no fear. They are smiling."

"They are smiling because I have taught them how," said the Lord, and the smile on His own face widened until it showed His teeth. "It is not hard. One has only to practise. One has only to hold the corners up."

"Are they dead?" It was Aashi. She had sat up, the lamp rocking in her fist, and her own voice was a stranger's, steely and precise: the voice she used in court. "Prabhu. I need to know. Are the twenty-nine dead?"

The Lord's head tilted. For a long moment He seemed to turn the question over, like a man looking at a word in a language he has not spoken for a long time.

"What is death, my daughter? I hang. I died. I am alive. I live inside my death. They are where I am. Neither living nor dead. Hanging."

Antim's hand slid from hers. He had risen halfway from the swing. "They are *alive.*"

"I do not say so. But they breathe. I hear it. Every night. Twenty-nine of them. Twenty-nine breaths. And I decide, my son, which breath is the next."

Nobody spoke.

In the dark, far off, among the ranks of the swinging cradles, something small and soft and regular moved in her hearing, like the slow breath of a sleeper heard through a thin wall. She had been hearing it for some time, she realised. She had taken it for the water. It was not the water. It was a sound she had heard in every hospital in Nepal, in every night-ward, in the holy hush of a house where the old are dying and the young sit up: twenty-nine lungs, drawing in, and letting go. They were not the small red parcels, she understood; those were only the keepsakes of the long gone. The living hung apart, in larger cradles behind the chair, each long enough to hold a man, and nearer than she had dared to look. *Eleven policemen. Nine men in sandals. Nine small boys in rubber slippers and school-shoes.*

He did not kill them, she thought. She felt the world tilt. *He is keeping them. He is keeping them in the one place where nobody can ever be left.* And the relief that went through her at the thought was so great, and so quickly followed by a horror she could not have named, that she nearly laughed.

❦

"Then let them go."

Antim was on his feet.

He had come up out of the rope seat without being aware of it, and he stood on the bare earth of the dais, a thin tall man in a plain brown jacket with the mud of a cave drying to his knees, his hands open at his sides and his face wet. He was not a Superintendent. He had left that on

the stairs. He was a son. He had the look of a boy standing on the bank of a river.

"You have told us everything," he said. "You have told us the truth, and I believe it, God help me, I believe every word. I believe that they were cruel to you. I believe that you loved them, and were betrayed. I believe that they are asleep. I want you to let them go. Please." His voice broke. "The eleven. Pandey. There are nine boys in that row in their little slippers. Their mothers are sitting in a house tonight with their hands in their laps. I am begging you."

The Lord's head had come round. The dark eyes rimmed with ruined kohl rested on him with a long, level, unreadable look.

"Pandey."

"The one with the great grey moustache?"

"Yes."

"He saluted me."

The hollow was quiet. In it, a long way down, a drop fell from a root and made its small clear ring upon the lake.

"He said: *Thank you.* He thanked me for the tea. Me, my son. The Hanging One. With one hand raised to his brow. In two hundred years, no one had saluted me."

"I made him a cradle, the nearest of all. The softest. And he keeps his hand lifted there, at his brow. In the manner of a salute. He will keep it there until I choose to let it fall. I shall choose, I think, a long time from now."

Antim sank down on his heels.

He did it without a sound. He crouched on the earth with his elbows on his knees and his fists against his mouth, and his shoulders shook, and his wife, rising from the other seat, came and knelt beside him and laid her cheek against his arm. Neither of them spoke. Overhead, the Lord watched them with the grave unblinking attention of a man at a graveside, who had come, in truth, to enjoy the service.

When Antim lifted his head, his face was ravaged, and strangely quiet.

"I killed her," he said.

"Yes."

"She was an old blind woman. She was reaching for my wife. I thought — God, I thought —" He stopped, and began again, in the flat steady voice he used for confessions. "I heard my father, and I heard

Pandey. I heard the numbers. I let go of Aashi's hand. And I drew a gun, in a cave, in front of a child's slate, and shot a woman who had been carrying a doll of straw for sixty years." He drew a breath. "I do not ask for your forgiveness, Prabhu. I do not think that I could bear it. I ask only what you mean to do."For a long time, the Hanging Lord did not move.

Then He did. He rose, or the rope rose with Him; the great grey body lifted up on its high knotted spine, and the white hair swung out behind, and the whole hollow darkened as if a cloud had passed across the sun. A single strand of red uncoiled from the roof. It came down like a snake and hung in the air before Antim's face, a hand's breadth from his throat, thin and bright and swaying a little, as a hooded thing sways before it strikes.

Aashi was on her feet. She did not remember rising. She stood between her husband and the rope with the lamp lifted high in her hand, and her voice, when it came, was calm.

"You have never taken a woman," she said.

The cord stopped.

"No woman has ever been taken; the only one you ever touched was Phulmaya, and when I spoke of Phulmaya you had the face of a man who cannot forgive himself. I do not think you could do to another woman what you did to her." She was shaking from head to foot. She held her ground. "He is not a woman, Prabhu. But I am. And I am standing here. If you want him, you will have to look at me."

There was a silence in which she thought she could hear her own heart, and the child's, a smaller fainter pulse, quick and light, like a bird under a hand.

Then the Hanging Lord laughed.

It was not a kind laugh. It was dry, and rusty, and broken, and it went on a beat too long, the laugh of a person who has not laughed for two hundred years and has forgotten where it is supposed to stop. It rose from the throat of the rope and ran along the roots, and the cradles, in their thousands, shivered in the dark.

"You see? This is the thing. These women. They do this. So small a body. So great courage. And it will not save him, and it will not save you, and you will stand there and be brave while I do it, and I shall *enjoy* it. Oh, how I shall enjoy it."

The red cord drew back. It lifted, uncoiling, and went up into the dark. And in its place, very slowly, a second thread came down, and held something: a small, dull, red-wrapped parcel, no larger than a loaf. It had been lifted from the earth beside the dead woman. The cloth had slipped, in the dark, and a wisp of straw stuck out from the corner.

It hung before Antim at the height of his chest.

"Not tonight. I am not finished with you. Take it."

Antim looked at it. He looked at Aashi. Then he put out both hands, with the stiffness of a man handling something that might break or burn, and took the straw child out of the air.

It weighed nothing. A bundle of dried stalks, bound in a rag of old red cotton, worn grey at the folds with sixty years of fingers, with a thin braid of black yarn tied at one end for hair. It had no face. It had never had one. But it had been rocked so often, so long, by so many hands, that it had taken on the faint warmth of a living thing, and as Antim cradled it, with his head bowed and the tears running off his chin, it seemed to him that he felt it settle against his chest and sigh.

"It is yours now. Carry it. You will find it grows heavier. She forgave you, my son, I heard it; it ran through the roots as she went. She said: *Oh, you foolish boy.* Even then, she looked at you as one looks at a child."

"I heard it," Antim began. "Before I — I heard it, and I thought —"

"You heard the word. You did not hear what was in it. It was a word of pardon. She forgave you, as she forgave me, for sixty years." The voice thickened and grew cold. "Do you know what that is, to be forgiven by her? It is a mouth full of ash. It is the cruellest thing she could have done to you, and she did it without knowing, and she is dead, and now it is yours, and you cannot give it back. Everyone forgives. I have never understood how any of them bear it."

He bent over the straw child. Aashi saw his shoulders heave. She put her hand on his back and left it there. Above them the roof was dim, and the cradles had gone quiet, and nobody in that vast, cold, living place made any sound but a man weeping over a doll; and from the dark above them, softly, patiently, a long way off, a child began to hum.

❦

"You wish to ask why I took only men."

Aashi had not spoken. She looked up, with her palm still flat on her husband's back, and the Lord was looking at her, and His face was tired and gentle and old, and she had learned by now what that meant.

"I did wish for it," she said. "I did not like to ask."

"It is the thing of which I am most ashamed. But you have asked, and I shall say. The men treated me as refuse. I hear their laughter even now. But that is not all of it."

"The women left me rice. The women did not look at me. The women did not curse me. And my mother was a woman. And my mother left me."

He lifted His hand, and looked at it. The bangles clinked.

"A man I can break. A woman's kindness I cannot bear. I cannot face a woman. For when I look at one, I see my mother. And my mother looked at the ground. Phulmaya looked. And I took her eyes. And since that day, before women, I have been a coward."

A coward, thought Aashi. She had called the Lord many things in her own mind, a hundred times in a day: monster, killer, thing. She had never once thought *coward.* It sat on the old grey face, in that smile, as naturally as dust. *He is afraid of us. All these years, all these deaths, He has gone through the village taking the fathers and the sons and never once touching a mother, a daughter, an aunt, a girl of sixteen lying awake in the dark. It was not because He was kind. It was because He could not bear to be seen by us.*

It did not make it better. It made it a good deal worse.

"And there is the other reason," said the Lord, "which you have not asked, and which is not shameful at all, and which I like better."

The smile turned, slowly, until it was directed at both of them.

"I leave you the women. I leave you the mothers, to sit up all night with a shutter nailed across the window and a bowl of cold rice on the floor. I leave the sisters, who hear the footsteps stop. I leave you the daughters, to grow, and to marry, and to bear sons, and to lie awake. Do you think I could think of a better thing to do to a woman than to leave her? I have been *left,* Deputy Madam. I know exactly what it is worth."

Aashi said nothing at all. There was nothing in the language for it.

"So it was never the ledger," she said at last, slowly, to the dark rather than to Him. "Antim kept saying it. The fathers. The sons. A system, an accounts book. A man who counts. It was nothing but this.

The ones who hurt you, and the ones you could not bear to look at, and the ones you had decided to leave behind."

"Yes. That is the whole of the account. The rest was made by men."

"The stairs," Antim said. He had raised his head. His voice was thick. "The steps. Four hundred and eleven. You made them match."

"No. The first generation cut the stairs, in hope, to make a path for me. I did not stop them. But every father who comes, comes with his greatest fear. And a fear, my son, is a number. Yours was four hundred and eleven. The count of your father's barracks. I heard it ring. I counted with you."

Antim's mouth opened. For a moment, no sound came. "You did not make them match," he said. "You — walked with me."

"Yes. You were not alone. I am never far from being afraid. It is a way of keeping them company."

Something broke in Antim's face then, quietly, like ice breaking in a stream in spring. He put his forehead against the straw child's rag, and Aashi heard him say, very low, to nobody: "I have been counting for twenty-six years. And someone was counting with me."

She saw it, and was afraid. It was what she had wanted for him for nine years: that he should be, once, not alone. And it had come, at last, from the one place in the world from which it ought not to have come, and he was leaning toward it as a plant leaned to a window. *That is how it holds you,* she thought. *That is how it has held every one of them. It does not drag. It keeps you company until you cannot walk away.*

She drew a long breath. She was, she found, extraordinarily tired. The lamp stood straight and gold in her fist. And in the great breathing darkness the cradles had begun to sway again, in time, all of them, with the slow tide-pull of a heart.

She lifted her head. Something had come to her, out of the dull cold sense of the profession that had never quite deserted her, and she said it before she could be afraid of it.

"There are rites for the unquiet, Prabhu. We know them. A hanged man is taken down, and he is bathed, and he is burned, and a son lights the pyre, and the name he was born with is spoken over the fire so that it can go with him. Nobody did that for you. Let us do it. Let us take you down. Antim will light it. Tell us your name, the one your mother gave you, and let it be said."

The hollow was entirely still.

Then the Lord's face did something she would remember in her own death. It did not rage. It went blank, as a face goes blank in the moment before a man falls from a height, and in the blankness there was real terror, bare and childish and total.

"My name."

"Yes."

"You would take me down." The voice had gone high and thin. "And burn me. And say it over me. And I should be *gone.* There would be nothing under it. I have been the swing and the rope and the knot for two hundred years, I have been grieving so long that I am the shape of it, do you not see? Untie me and what is left? A little string. A little hair. A boy in a goat-skin, shivering, with nobody coming."

He had begun to tremble, and the cradles trembled with him.

"No. No. I will not be taken down. I will not be *finished.* I will be what I am forever, I will be in every house, I will be a thing that is never forgiven and never laid to rest, because the day I am laid to rest is the day they win." The trembling stopped. The smile came, very wide, and very slowly, like a wound opening. "Thank you, my daughter. That was beautifully done. I wanted so much to be offered, so that I could refuse."

Antim had put his arm around her. She felt him shaking. She understood what she had just seen, and the understanding settled in her like a cold stone in the stomach: that it was not that the Lord could not be saved. It was that He had looked at salvation, from a long way off, with all the clear sight of two hundred years, and chosen the rope.

"Prabhu," she said, after a time, in a very small voice. "Why did you bring us here?"

The Lord's smile did not alter.

"Because, my daughter, you are the first in all these years to ask for my story. And because I wished to be seen, once, before I go. Not by a village. By a *witness.* A curse that is understood by no one is only weather. And because you carry a door."

Her hand went to her belly. She could not stop it.

"A child in the womb is neither living nor dead. Neither counted nor outside the count. I, too, in my life, was third. Your child is the one door through which I can look upon the world."

"Listen, for this is the part that nobody in your village knows, and that the eldest mother took to her pyre. When the women made their

pooja, they wrote into it a law: *none shall look.* They wrote it to keep my face from their eyes. They did not understand that it kept me from the world. A thing that cannot be looked at cannot be asked. A thing that cannot be asked cannot be let go. For two hundred years I hung in this hill with the door shut, and I could not leave, because nobody would look upon me and ask. Only a woman could do it, for the pooja was a woman's thing; and she must come of her own will; and she must come carrying a son, who is of the third, who is neither in nor out. I have waited for her since the day Rukmini died. I have watched three hundred women come to the tree. They all had their eyes lowered. You *looked.*"

Aashi's mouth was dry. "You said you were not allowed to move beyond the gate," she said. "Hajurama said so."

"And she held it for forty years, with her thread and her Word. She was the last hand on the rope. But a rope with the last hand gone is only a rope. It needs a mouth to say *come,* and she is dead, and the door is open, and the carrying woman has looked, and asked. It is done. It has been done for a few minutes. You were so kind as to ask me for my story."

"What do you see?" Her voice was a thread. "When you look?"

For a time, He did not speak at all. The thousands of cradles hung about Him in the amber dark, turning, each with its small hair-lock, its small sleeping boy. He seemed to grow larger, and older, and more weary, all at once; as though every one of those two hundred years had come down on His shoulders like a yoke. And when at last the old voice came, it was very quiet, and the rope above it creaked in the stillness like a bough taking a weight.

"I see that I am going out."

"For two hundred years I was a thing on a hill. I could not walk down the stairs. I could not cross the water. The pooja held me, as a ring holds a dog to a post; and it was a ring I had helped to make, because I wished to be fed. Now Phulmaya is gone. The last thread has broken, too. The post is rotten. At dawn, when the bell is not rung, I shall leave this hill, and I shall go down the road the buses go, and past the bridge, and into every town in the world, by the one door that is open to me, which is a child who has not been born. I see the road. I have never seen a road."

"I see that I have borne it all. Seven generations. For seven generations I could not laugh. I wept and I trembled. I heard the bars go across their doors, night after night. I bore the swing, the laughter, the lowered eyes of my mother. Three pushes, every year, for two hundred years."

"Tonight, and tomorrow's dawn as well, there is no law."

A cold ran down Aashi's back, starting at the nape and ending in the soles of her feet. She understood. She understood it all at once, as one understands the end of a sentence when it is already too late to alter its beginning. *By day you shall not harm our sons.* A treaty. A thread. An old blind woman at a tree at dawn with a brass pot and a ladle, saying a Word. *Now who will tie them?*

Nobody. Nobody will. Not tomorrow, nor any day after. And we came down into the hill and shot the only one who could.

Antim had gone still. He too had understood. He raised his face, and she saw in it that same clear dreadful comprehension, the terrible clarity of a man who has been counting for twenty-six years and has at last been given a sum that cannot be wrong.

"No," he said. "Prabhu, no. Not the village. Not the children. Whatever it was that was done to you, they did not —"

"I have not harmed them, my son. I shall do nothing to them tonight. Tonight we shall only finish the tale."

The hollow trembled. The thousands of knots on the thousands of ropes swung together, once, slowly, like the sails of a ship in the first breath of a gale; and from the chair, from the roof, from the lake and the lamp and the cradles, there rose a voice that was no longer an old man's, nor a woman's, nor a child's, nor the voice of any one thing that had ever lived. It was the voice of the hill. It was the voice of a tree that has put its roots through two hundred years of weeping, and found nothing at the bottom of the well but more of itself. It filled the hollow to the roof, and the two small figures standing on the dais with a lamp and a straw doll between them bowed before it like reeds in a river.

"The world showed me cruelty. For seven generations I have borne it here, in this village, in this hill, in this rope. Every one of those nights. Not a day of it was forgiven me, and not a day of it shall be forgiven them.

"Now I desire vengeance.

"Not upon the dead; the dead are dust, and they have escaped me. Upon those who come after. The unborn. The ones who have done nothing, as I did nothing. It is the only fair thing. I stand at the edge of the curse, and my curse is for the generations yet to come."

The voice sank. The hill grew still, and in the stillness the Lord was a figure again, long and grey and bent, smiling.

"Not by rope, my son. Do not look so. I have hung enough. A rope is a small thing. What was done to me was not the rope. The rope was only the end of it. It was the laughing. It was the looking away. It was the feast, and the smoke of my father's roof, and my brother's good coat, and the word *mine* said over a thing that was not mine. Those I can plant. Those do not need a tree."

"And your village will not be touched. A village is a small thing, and it has been mine. Let it keep its bars and its bell, let it be feared; it will be the best fence I ever raised. Nobody looks behind a fence."

Antim whispered, "What do you want of us?"

"Nothing. You have already given it."

❦

The lamp went out.

It did not gutter. It did not flicker. The small gold flame that had burned in her fist through a night and a day and an eternity, that had burned, she understood now, only because it was *allowed* to, because He had wanted them to stay and listen, simply ceased, as a word ceases at the end of a breath. The dark came down like the lid of a box.

Aashi and Antim, lying down, opened their eyes, and woke up from a nightmare, which is what they thought, which is what Jhundiyeko Prabhu wanted them to think. Prabhu, the lord whose curse is passed but unknown to all. The lamp went out, the darkness remained, and the chaos left amongst them.

"Aashi!" Antim's voice, somewhere very near. "Aashi, your hand —"

"I have it. I have it. I —"

She did have it. His fingers were locked in hers, as they had been for the whole of that night, as the red thread on her right wrist, and the red weal on his left where the other had burned, had said they should

always be. She held on. *Husband and wife go together. You do not separate.* She held on with all the strength of nine years.

And in the dark the old voice said, close, close, so close that she felt the breath of it on her face, as warm as a lover's:

"Hajurama would have laid her hand on you. Do you remember? The touch of the eldest mother, on a carrying woman, turns my eye away for a night. She was reaching for you, child. She was reaching to shut the door. And your husband, who loves you so, who has counted all his life for fear of losing someone, put a bullet in the one hand in the world that could have kept me out."

A sound came out of Antim that was not a word.

"Do not weep. It was well done. It is the best thing he ever did for me."

Something touched her belly.

It was not a hand. It was a cold so absolute that it had weight, and it came, she thought, not from outside but from within, as if a drop of the lake had been let fall into the centre of her. She tried to cry out. She felt her husband's fingers go rigid in hers, and heard him make a small thick sound, like a man going under water; and she thought, with the last clear corner of her mind, *it is only fear. It is only fear. People faint from it. Hold on, hold on —*

Sleep, sang a voice, in a child's pitch and an old man's and the flat voice of a headman, from every side at once. *Sleep, my son, sleep, my jewel. Sleep, and wake, and do not go.*

The last thing she knew was the smell of marigolds, thick and sweet and rotten, and a small, tender, delighted sound, like a very old child, giggling in the dark.

❦

End of Chapter Four

CHAPTER FIVE

The Tenth Bundle

She woke up because someone was calling her name.

It was Antim, and he was very close, and his voice was thin and flat with the fear of a man who has already called it several times. She lay with her cheek against cold rock and a taste of marigold in her mouth, and above her was a strip of pale sky between two walls of wet black stone, and she lay quite still for the length of a breath and could not for the life of her say where she was.

"Aashi. Aashi. Please."

"I am here," she said. Her voice was a croak. "Antim. I am here."

His hand found hers and gripped it hard enough to hurt, and she sat up. The world swung and settled. They were sitting on a narrow ledge of rock at the foot of a cliff, in the grey of morning, with a thin skin of frost on the stone and the mist drawn right back into the gorge. In the east, above the ridge, there was a seam of cold yellow light. Somewhere below, a cock was crowing, flatly, as a cock does in a village where nobody has slept.

She knew the place. It was the foot of the Hanging Rock. And a little way along the cliff, no wider than a door, its lip slick and black and a dead fern growing from its lintel, was the Throat.

"We came out," said Antim.

"We came out."

"I do not remember coming out." He was staring at the crack with his mouth slightly open, a thin man in a brown jacket with a day's stubble and the look of someone who has been dropped from a height and is waiting to find which of him is broken. "I remember the stairs. I

remember the cave. And then —" He stopped. "Aashi, I had the most appalling dream."

She turned her head.

They looked at each other in the thin light, and for a moment neither said a word. Then, slowly, as people do who have been caught doing something shameful, they both began to speak at once, and both stopped, and Antim gave a short cracked laugh that was nothing like his own.

"You first," he said.

"A hollow," said Aashi. "A great hollow in the earth, with ropes. Thousands of them, hanging from the roof, and a little red parcel at the end of each, like a cradle. And a chair." She wet her lips. "And someone hanging in front of the chair. He turned around. He had a face."

"Long," said Antim, very low. "Grey. With kohl running down the cheeks."

"Yes."

"And bangles. Green glass."

"Yes."

"And he told us a story."

"He told us a story." She could hear her own breath. "Antim, I dreamed that I asked him to turn around. I dreamed I said, *I would like to see who is speaking.* And I dreamed that you — that you took out the —"

She could not finish it. Antim said it for her, in a voice so quiet she almost lost it.

"That I shot the old woman."

They sat on the ledge with the dawn coming up behind them and looked at each other across a gulf of thirty-six hours, and the cock crowed again below, and neither of them moved.

❦

It was Antim, in the end, who found the reasonable thing.

It was what he did. He had always done it: gone round the hard thing until he found the handle by which it could be lifted. He took out his handkerchief and wiped his face, and the voice that came out of him

when he spoke again was the voice of a Superintendent explaining a failed raid.

"It was the air," he said. "You smelled it. You could hardly breathe. There was rot, and damp, and some kind of gas in a place like that, or a poison from the mold. We had a lamp that went dim. We stood in it for hours. People see things in bad air, Aashi, it is known; miners see their mothers. We have simply — had the same nightmare, because we have been told the same story for three days, and been frightened by the same people, and stood in the same dark." He swallowed. "It is not so strange. Two people who share a fear will share a dream. I have seen it in a prison."

"How long were we down there?"

"We slept. We were poisoned, and we slept. The mind makes its own time."

"Antim." She had to say it. "You dreamed that you shot an old woman. You dreamed it in the same *words*."

"I did not shoot anyone." He said it very gently. "Look."

He put his hand to the holster on his hip and drew it back with a startled movement, and she saw that the leather was empty.

They both looked at it.

"I must have dropped it," he said slowly. "On the stairs. In the dark. I will say so in the report. A man can lose a revolver in a fall." He laughed again, that short cracked sound, and it came out wrong, a laugh that had been tried on and did not fit. "There. You see? That is why I dreamed it. I knew I had lost it, and I was ashamed, and the mind made a story."

"And this?"

His hand had gone to the breast of his jacket, to a lump there that she had not noticed. He drew out a small bundle of dried straw, bound in a rag of old red cotton, worn grey at the fold, with a thin braid of black yarn at one end for hair. It lay in his palm. It had no face.

For a long time they both looked at it.

"I do not know," said Antim. His voice had dropped almost to a whisper. "I do not know where I got it. I must have found it in the cave. Some child's toy. Some poor woman's —" He stopped. A tear ran down the side of his nose, quite unexpectedly, and he looked at it on his finger with a kind of stupid surprise. "I do not know why I am crying."

"Keep it," said Aashi.

She did not know why she had said that, either. She put out her own hand and closed his fingers over the rag, gently, and felt it, through his knuckles, warm; and then she looked down at herself.

There was no mud on her boots. There was no blood on her sleeve. The clothes in which she had gone down into the earth were dry and plain and clean, as if someone had laid them out for her that morning. There was a clay lamp in her left hand. She had not noticed it. It was whole, and cold, and its wick was a little curl of ash; and on the clay of its base, where no thumb of hers had been, was a small round smudge of red.

It is nothing, she told herself. *A smear of the clay. The potter's thumb.*

She put the lamp in her bag.

❦

It was a Wednesday when they went in.

She had the fact whole, like a stone in her hand. Wednesday at lamp-lighting, with a clay lamp and a pouch of pitho and a red thread on her wrist. And her watch, when she lifted her wrist, said twenty-three minutes past five, and went on saying it. She looked at the sky. She looked at the frost. She looked at the light on the opposite cliff, and she knew with perfect certainty, as she knew her own name, that she had never in her life seen a Thursday dawn.

"It is Friday," she said.

"Yes."

"It is the last day. The report is due."

"Yes." He had risen, and put out his hand to help her up. "We should get down to the village. The kinnar will be frantic."

She took his hand. It was warm, and she held it, and there was a fine tremor in it that she thought was his, and her own. And as they stood in the cold light with the Throat behind them, she said, because she had to say it, because her mind would not let go of it, as a tongue goes to a loose tooth:

"Antim. In the dream. I asked him why he had brought us. And he said —"

She asked for my story. And she looked.

"He said that he had been waiting two hundred years for a woman who would look at him and ask. With a son in her. Of her own will. He said that a thing which cannot be looked at cannot be asked, and a thing which cannot be asked cannot be let go." She stopped. She was shivering. "Do you remember that? Do you remember what he said it was *for?*"

Antim looked at her.

For an instant, so brief that she was never sure afterward that it had happened, his face changed. It did not alter. It *settled,* as a face settles in a mirror when the light shifts, and his lips curved a very little, and she saw the corners of his mouth lifted, evenly, as if by a small patient hand.

"It was a dream, my love," said Antim, tenderly. "Only a dream."

And she felt a great, warm, drowsy peace come over her, and smiled; and they went down the ledge together, hand in hand.

The kinnar saw them come out.

They had been sitting on the flat rock beside the Throat for two nights and a day, with the lantern at their feet and the long charcoal coat drawn round them, and they had not slept. They had lit the lamp at every dusk and put it out at every dawn. They had watched the sun go over the ridge twice. They had said to themselves, a dozen times, in a voice that grew steadily more reasonable, that it was finished and there was nothing to be done and they should go home; and they had sat on.

So they were looking at the cliff when it happened, and they saw it plainly, though afterwards they were not able to say what it was they had seen. There was no sound. The Throat in the grey light was a split in a rock, with a fern and a trickle of seep-water. Then there were two people standing in it, as though they had been there all the time: a thin man in a brown jacket and a woman in a shawl, hand in hand, blinking at the daylight like sleepers disturbed. They stood for a moment. They came down the ledge together. And the kinnar rose from the rock all at once, as a bird rose, and the lantern swung, and for the length of a breath they could not speak.

"You are *alive,*" they said.

"Of course we are alive," said Antim, and laughed.

It was a warm, rueful, shamefaced laugh. The kinnar heard it, and something went quietly cold at the base of the spine, and they did not at once know why. They looked at the man. He was unhurt. He was

unmarked. There was not a smear of mud on his boots, nor a thread torn in his sleeve, nor the least sign that he had passed through the place which, by every account the kinnar had ever been given, had never in two hundred years returned a man whole. And his face was smiling. It was a smile of great sweetness and warmth, and it did not change.

Smiles change, thought the kinnar. *That is what they are for.*

"Two nights," they said. "Two nights and a day, I have sat at this stone. I thought I should be carrying you out in pieces. I thought, if the Lord were merciful, I should find your boots."

"We are sorry to have worried you," said the woman, gently. "You have been so kind. Kinder than we had any right to expect." She came forward, and took the kinnar's free hand in both her own, and her fingers were warm and dry and steady, and she looked up into the kinnar's face with wide clear eyes, and the kinnar, who had read the faces of a village for thirty years, could find in them nothing at all.

It was not that the eyes were empty. It was that they were *full.* They were full to the brim of an easy, trusting, open peace. There was no fear in them. There was no horror, no strain. They were the eyes of a woman who had had a night's sleep.

"Tell me what you saw," said the kinnar.

"Nothing," said Antim.

He said it earnestly. He told it, with a frown of effort, in the plain way of a man doing his best to give a true account: they had gone in at the lamp-lighting, as they had been shown, and counted the stair, and found the cave beneath. There were bodies. A great many, old, dried, in niches in the wall; goats and a dog; a great deal of mud and decay, and insects in their thousands. The air was bad. They had lost their light and become, he confessed, very much afraid, and had spent the night in a chamber beyond a fall of rock. In the morning the way out had been open. That was all.

"I had the most appalling dream," he said, ruefully, "from the foul air. We both did. It is a thing that happens, I am told. One sees one's fears."

"And the Lord?"

The two of them exchanged a glance, small, bewildered, affectionate, the glance of two sensible people who have been asked by a nervous child whether there is a ghost under the bed.

"There was nobody," said Aashi. "Only the dead and the dirt. I think the village has been leaving its dead there a long, long time, as a kind of grave, and telling itself a story about why. I am so sorry, Didi. I know it is not what you hoped."

"And the eleven? The nine fathers? The nine boys?"

"We found no sign of them." It was said sorrowfully. "Antim looked for their boots. He looked very hard. Beyond the rockfall there is a place where the mountain has come down, and a river, and I think —" She stopped, delicately. "I think the cold, or the water, or wild animals. A terrible, ordinary thing."

She believes it, thought the kinnar.

It came upon them slowly, with the awful clearness of a thing seen in a mirror. They had looked at liars all their life. They knew every kind: the bold, the sly, the weeping, the ones who are better at it than they know. This was none of them. The woman was telling the truth. She was telling it as she remembered it, from the inside of her own head, with her hand in her husband's, and it was *wrong,* it was a story that had been placed in her like a coin in a pocket; and she did not know.

And so does he.

"May I see?" they said.

❦

They went in together.

It was ten paces. The kinnar counted them. Ten paces of wet rock and a roof so low that the man stooped, a floor of gravel and dung and last year's leaves, a goat's skull picked clean, a heap of cave-crickets trembling in a corner. At the tenth pace there was a wall of fallen stone, black and glistening, wedged to the roof, with no gap in it that a rat could have used, and the look of having stood there for ten thousand years. The kinnar raised the lantern, and set a palm against it, and pressed. The stones were stones. A drop of water ran down the largest and fell into the dust.

"By day," they said, "the Throat is stone."

"Yes," said Antim, behind them. "So you said."

They stood for a long time with their hands against the wall.

I was seven, they thought. *I was taken in. I came out of it with this.* The fingers of the other hand rose, and touched the pale line on the forehead. *I have a scar, and a swing, and a name that nobody says. I have lived thirty years in a house ringed with powder because of a thing that lives under this hill.* And a wall of stones, and two sleepers who walked out of it unharmed, and a smile.

Is He?

The doubt came in quietly, as water came into the boat. It was the worst moment the kinnar had known since childhood. They had made a life out of being the one person in Dhuwakot who did not need to believe, because they *knew;* and now, in front of a wall that said nothing, with the cold clean light of the morning on the stones, they found that they did not.

A small grey voice said: *You have been alone with it for so long. You have been alone with it so long that you have made it.*

They took their hand from the wall.

And the voice said: *Look at their shadows.*

They turned. The couple stood in the mouth of the cave with their backs to the light, hand in hand, and on the floor of the passage, thrown long by the low sun, lay their two shadows. The kinnar looked at them for a long moment.

The shadows were not standing.

They hung. It was a very slight thing. It was no more than a trick of the light on a wet floor. The two black shapes lay out side by side across the stones, and at the place where the feet should have touched the earth they trailed a little, and swayed, as the tails of a coat swayed on a hook.

Well, thought the kinnar, with a perfect calm. *Then I am not mad.*

The kinnar came out into the morning slowly, and smiled, and the smile was courteous and tired and quite ordinary.

"Then I am a foolish old creature," they said, "who has frightened you for nothing, and sat on a rock for two nights."

"No," said Aashi, warmly. "You saved our lives."

"Did I? Well. You are safe. That is a great thing, in Dhuwakot." The kinnar's eyes went past them to the yellow seam along the ridge. "You will wish to go home."

"It is Friday," said Antim. "We were to report on Friday. We should leave at once."

"At once. Then I shall see you to the gate."

"There is no need —"

"I said that I would see you out of Dhuwakot alive," said the kinnar. "I do not give my word often. I have not given it to anyone in thirty years." The lantern lifted a little, and the light fell on a face that had grown very old and very sure. "You will walk in front of me. If you do not mind."

❦

Dhuwakot was awake.

The kinnar had known that it would be. It had been awake since Thursday dawn, when the girl who carried the old woman's tea had gone into the back room of the Mothers' House and came out screaming, and the whole village had been up since, in a long shuddering dread that was worse than any night. They came down into the square as the sun cleared the ridge, and the square was full. People stood in knots. They called across the flagstones. And as the three of them came out of the alley by the whitewashed platform, a boy ran with his mouth open and stopped dead, and every head came round.

Nine clay lamps stood on the platform, in a row, unlit. Somebody had dusted them.

"The Karkis!" cried a voice. "It is the schoolmaster and his wife!"

They came with a rush: women with their shawls half off, men with sickles and sticks in their hands, a girl of seventeen in a green blouse with her face swollen from weeping. Tilmaya Gurung came through them like a bullock, with her hand on the girl's shoulder, and her eyes were red.

"Where have you *been*?"

"Gone up to the Hanging Rock," said Antim, easily. "Forgive us, we should have said. My wife is fond of walking. We lost the path in the mist, and spent the night in a shepherd's hut, and the next in the open, with a very poor fire." He bowed a little to the crowd, with the warm helpless courtesy of a visitor who had been a trouble. "I do hope you were not alarmed."

A murmur went over the square, half relief and half something that was not relief. A man laughed. A woman said, *the Rock! In this weather!* The girl in the green blouse put her hands over her face.

"Hajurama is gone," she said.

The square went quiet.

"She went out at the bell on Wednesday," said Tilmaya. Her voice was very low and steady, the voice of a woman who has said one sentence forty times and has not got used to it. "She took the little gate behind the Mothers' House, with the bundle and her stick. She has not come back. We have looked in every house. In the lower wood, under the Rock, in the stream. We have called all night. None of us has slept."

"Hajurama," said Aashi, with a shade of grief that was exactly right and entirely sincere. "Oh, no."

"We saw nothing of her," said Antim, sorrowfully. "We spoke with her on Wednesday morning, in the courtyard, as you know. A great lady. She was good to my wife. But we did not see her after that. At her age, in this cold —"

"She knows these hills," said the girl, fiercely.

"Of course she does." Aashi's hand lay on the girl's arm. "She will be found, I am sure of it. She will have sat down to rest at the foot of some wall, I think. They do, you know. The old."

And the kinnar, standing a pace behind with the lantern low, watched Tilmaya's face. They saw the old fear in it take this offered comfort, and clasp it, and turn it over; and they saw something else behind it, in the heavy, hard-handed Gurung eyes, that went very still. It was the look of a woman who had said to a dozen policemen over fourteen months, *we saw nothing,* and who had never before heard it said back.

Nobody said aloud what she had carried.

It was Antim who looked up first, at the sound of a stick on the stones; and an old man in a patched woollen waistcoat came limping up the alley with a hand on his hip, a bent, dark, solemn person with his white hair standing up in a tuft. Hari, the schoolmaster. He had been out in the lower wood since the dawn of the day before, calling for the old woman, and was grey with it.

"Master-sahib," said Antim.

It was said gently. It was said in a voice the kinnar had not heard from him before, rich and soft and strange, like honey over a cut; and the old man stopped dead.

He stood in the middle of the square with his stick in his hand and his head a little to one side, as a man stands who has heard, a long way

off, in his sleep, the ringing of a bell he knew in childhood. His face went slowly grey. His hand crept to his hip. He said, "You are the visitor." And then, very low, in a voice that had no breath behind it: "Forgive me. I thought that I knew you."

"I am sure you do not," said Antim, smiling.

The kinnar's grip on the lantern tightened until the wire creaked.

❦

They went down through the village with the kinnar a pace behind, and the kinnar watched.

They had been watching people all their life. It had been, in the long years of the powder and the lamp, the only thing left to them: the slow patient study of faces, of walks, of the ways in which a body tells what a tongue will not. And what they saw, as the three of them went out under the pipal and down the long lane toward the terraces, was the portrait of a couple whom someone had *finished.*

On Tuesday night, at the gate, the man had counted. They had heard him: the planks of the fence, the steps of the lane, the beads of the lantern-chain, a low steady mutter of numbers under his breath, as one hears a clock in another room. Now he walked in silence. He walked under the great rope with its fist-thick knots, and did not once lift his eyes.

On Wednesday, a dozen times, the woman had put her hand to the low flat place beneath her navel, as people do who carry a letter in a pocket. Now her hands hung quietly at her sides.

And they walked in step.

Left, right, left, with a certain swing at the end of the stride, a lift and fall of the heel. It was a march. The kinnar had seen it once before, on a man in a uniform that nobody wore any longer, in a village on the other side of a war. They went down the middle of the lane like two puppets on one string, with the whole of Dhuwakot at their backs, and nobody called after them, and nobody followed. The village was not detaining them. It was letting them out. It was the long exhausted guilty exhalation of a community that had asked two strangers to go into its dark and had been given back, at the end of it, not a corpse but a pair of unscathed smiling civil servants who said there was nothing there.

They want to believe it, thought the kinnar. *They want it so badly that they would believe it if it were told by the Lord Himself.*

And the thought, having been made, stopped the kinnar where they stood, for an instant, on the cold stones. They stood quite still. They felt the old, familiar, patient pressure of the hill on the back of the neck, and for the first time in thirty years they did not know whether it was fear or recognition.

If it were told by the Lord Himself.

The lantern clinked. They walked on.The gate stood at the bottom of the hill.

It was smaller than most people remembered. It was two black posts set into the ground on either side of the path, and a crosspiece lashed to them with rope: the sort of gate a hill farmer puts at the mouth of a field to keep a goat in. It could not have stopped a child. But from the crosspiece, as thick as a hem, hung red threads, hundreds of them, in loops and knots and short bound hanks, bleached by the weather to every shade from pink to rust. Some were new. Some had rotted to a thread's breadth. Every family that had ever left Dhuwakot, and every family that had ever stayed, had tied one there.

The mist stopped at the posts.

It stopped as if a ruler had been laid across the world. On the village side the air was damp and still and smelled of leaf-rot. On the far side, a hundred paces off, the road went on in clean golden sunshine, down toward a bend where two crows were quarrelling over a dead rat; and the kinnar, who had stood at this gate on a thousand evenings in thirty years, had never once put a foot beyond it after dark.

They stopped three paces short. The couple went on to the crosspiece and turned.

"Well," said Antim, brightly. "This is as far as you need to come."

"I thank you for your kindness," said Aashi. She had taken her husband's arm. Her face, in the clear light, was flushed and tired and happy, and the kinnar, looking at it, felt a thing they had not expected to feel at all, which was pity. "You kept your word. You have been better to us than —"

She stopped. It was a half-second, no more, like a foot over a stair. Then she went on in a voice that was not quite the voice she had begun in; and the kinnar's heart, which had been beating slowly and hard against their ribs for an hour, gave a single great stroke and was still.

"Better than we deserved. Go carefully, Nanthan – Ah, Nanthali, now. The road is long."

The word fell on the cold air like a stone into a tank.

Nobody moved.

It was a small name. It was a name given in a kitchen, in the dark, by a mother, to a child who was neither the son she had been promised nor the daughter she had hoped for; a name that had been whispered three times and never again. The kinnar had not heard it in thirty years. It had gone into the earth with the mother, who had died when the child was ten; and there had been only one other creature in the world to whom it had ever been told. On the third night of a seven-year-old's Dashain, in the dark, a voice had asked, in the kindest tones in the world: *What is your name, little one?*

And the child, who had been so cold, and so frightened, and had never in all their life been asked, had told.

Aashi blinked.

She looked down at her own hand on Antim's arm. A small frown drew her brows together, the frown of a woman who had said a word in her sleep and been overheard, and she looked at the kinnar with a faint puzzled smile.

"I'm sorry," she said. "I do not know why I —" She put her fingers to her lips. "That was your name. Wasn't it?"

"Yes," said the kinnar. "That is my name. I had forgotten."

"It is a pretty name."

"Thank you."

"I think," said Aashi, slowly, "that we have been very tired." She looked at Antim, and he looked at her, and between them there passed a flicker of something that was not the easy contentment of the whole morning. It was a doubt, perhaps. It was a shadow of the dream. And for an instant the kinnar saw them both on the very edge of it, a hand's breadth from the water, like two people looking at their own reflection and finding the face wrong.

Then the shadow passed. Her hand tightened on his arm, and Antim smiled, and the smile was warm and sweet and steady, and the tremor at the corners was gone.

"Goodbye," said Aashi, quite cheerfully.

"Goodbye, memsahib."

And the kinnar, standing at the gate in the cold with the lantern low, watched the two of them walk out of Dhuwakot into the sun.

❦

It was like being a bell.

They felt it long before they understood it, and they would remember the exact moment all their life. The couple crossed, hand in hand, beneath the lintel with its thousand red threads; and the whole of the hill, from the pipal to the posts, *rang.* It was a low note, felt rather than heard, in the soles of the feet, in the teeth, as of a huge string drawn to the very limit of its length and parting. Every thread on the crosspiece stirred at once, as in a gust of wind, though there was no wind. The mist behind them moved. A bird went up out of the lower wood, crying.

And something went past.

It did not pass the kinnar. It passed *through the gate,* between the posts, in the air above the heads of the two walking figures, and it was not a thing that could be seen; it was only that the light, for a moment, was somewhere else. The kinnar felt a coldness go by like the passage of a great animal, huge, bright, silent, joyful. They felt the sweetness of marigolds. They felt something laugh.

They had heard it laugh once before, on a night in a hollow in the earth, thirty years ago, when they were seven and shaking, and had told it their name.

The hill breathed out.

Then it was over. The birds settled. The mist lay quiet on the slope. The threads hung down, red, still, ordinary, and a hundred paces away along the road in the sunshine two small figures went on walking, hand in hand, without once looking back, as people walk who have nothing on their minds.

The kinnar stood for a long time at the gate.

Why now? they thought.

It was not fear, though the fear would come. It was the long slow patient puzzlement of a mind that had spent thirty years learning every inch of a thing and had just seen it do what it had never done. *Two hundred years He has been loose at night. Two hundred years He has walked in the dark and taken what He pleased. And He never crossed*

this gate. Not in the year the axes came. Not in the year of the fire. Not when the thread was nearly cut, three times, and the old woman thought that the end had come. He lay in the hill and He ate the village and He could not go one step beyond the posts. They touched the crosspiece. The rope was dry and rough under their fingers. *And this morning He walked out of it in the arms of two schoolteachers. Why now? And how?*

A bell was ringing in the village. It was the first bell, the call to the fields. The kinnar listened to it for a moment, and the answer arrived, as the answer to a long sum does, all at once, from a place that had been waiting for it.

A carrying woman.

Tilmaya had whispered it in the courtyard, in the fear of the old, on Wednesday morning: *a carrying woman, at the lamp-lighting hour, in Dhuwakot.* The kinnar had seen it themselves in her walk, in the small instinctive movement of the hand. *And she went in. And she looked. They would not have told her not to; the law told every woman not to look, and none had ever dared. It is the one law the pooja never needed to enforce.* They closed their eyes. *Of her own free will, with a son in her, she went in and she looked, and the old woman was gone, and the last hand was off the rope.*

He did not break out. He was let out. And she does not know.

They opened their eyes.

The couple were small figures now at the bend of the road. They had stopped, as people do, to look at the view; and the woman had put up her hand to her husband's face, and he had taken it, and kissed it. Then they went on, round the bend, and were hidden by the bend.

The kinnar waited for the terror.

It did not come. What came instead was a clear, cold, almost restful sense of the shape of what had happened, as of a puzzle that had been laid out whole on a table. *He said,* they thought, *that He would not trouble the village.* They had not heard Him say it. They did not need to. It was in the way the morning had gone: the careful lies, the easy smiles, the gentle hands. A thing that wished to destroy Dhuwakot would not have troubled to leave it a story. *He means to keep us. A village is a small thing, and it has been His. He will leave it its bars and its bell and its fear, and go out into the world.*

They looked down the empty road, in the clean golden light, to where the Lord had gone.

And I cannot follow, they thought. *And I cannot tell. And I shall not be believed.*

It was almost a relief. It was the knowledge a person has who has been caught for thirty years in a net and learns, at the end, that it was cast over somebody else.

They bent, and set the lantern on the flat stone at the foot of the left-hand post, where the evening would find it. They took a thread of red cotton from the pocket of the long coat, and tied it, with the quick hard turns of one tying a bundle of grass, to the crosspiece. Then they pulled the muffler up over their chin, and turned, and walked slowly back up the hill into the mist, toward the houses, with their back to the sun.

The nine mothers were already carrying the lamps to the platform for Friday night.

The report was filed on the following Monday.

It ran to nine pages, typed, in triplicate, and it was the best-written document that either of them had ever produced. Her husband wrote it. She sat across the kitchen table from him, in the grey light of a Bhanjyang morning, with a cup of tea going cold at her elbow, and watched his hand move on the paper in the clean sloping script he had learned in a barracks school as a boy; and every line of it was what he honestly believed. That was the horror of it, though neither of them would know it for years.

The village of Dhuwakot, it said, *was visited by the undersigned over four days. The inhabitants were found to be civil and frightened. No evidence was discovered of any crime. No cause was discovered for the disappearance of eleven police officers and eighteen civilians, and the undersigned are bound to record that none is likely to be discovered.*

The ground beneath and around the pipal tree and the so-called Hanging Rock is unstable and contaminated, with fallen rock, foul air and standing water. The undersigned lost their way, were separated from the guide, and suffered illness and loss of memory for a period of some thirty-six hours. One service revolver was lost. It is the considered view of the undersigned that any further inspection of the site would be

unsafe, and that officers sent to it would be at serious and unquantifiable risk.

It is accordingly recommended: that the file be closed as UNSOLVED; that the village be declared a restricted area and no officer, surveyor, official or visitor be posted or admitted there; that all inquiries concerning it be referred to this report; and that the matter be allowed to rest.

It was signed *A. Karki, Superintendent,* and below it, *A. Karki, Dy. Superintendent.*

She read it twice, and signed it, and felt nothing but a vague tired relief, as one feels on finishing an unpleasant duty. She had never lied in a report in twelve years. It did not cross her mind that she had.

It was accepted without a query.

She would think about that, in the years to come, more than about anything else. She had expected a summons. She had expected questions, and the cold dry voices of men in an office on the sixth floor asking why a Superintendent and his wife had come back from a village that had swallowed eleven policemen with nothing to show. They did not ask. The report went up the stairs, from the Superintendent to the Deputy Inspector General to the Home Ministry, and a curious thing happened to it at every landing. Each man who opened it read the first page with attention, and the second with less, and by the fourth had begun to feel a deep, soft, reasonable tiredness, a conviction that this was a matter that was not his to settle; and each of them, setting it down, found that he did not want to pick it up again. A file was opened, and a file was closed, and a stamp came down on the cover with a small flat sound: UNSOLVED. CLOSED. RESTRICTED. And within the month the Inspector General, a heavy, careful man with a reputation for caution, was telling a colleague over a glass of rakshi that he had a vague sense of some trouble in the hills, a year or two ago, that had been put to bed; and he could not for the life of him remember the name of the place.

Jhundiyeko Prabhu, the lord, was not clever. He was something far worse: He was *patient.* He did not push; He rested His weight, very gently, on the places in a man where a wish to look away was already comfortable, and waited. The Inspector General did not want a scandal. The Home Ministry did not want eleven widows. The district did not want a village of fear on its books. Everyone, somewhere, wanted what

the Lord wanted: for the thing to be small, and quiet, and over. And the report, which carried a little of Him in every sentence as a bottle carries a little of what it held, had only to lean on a hundred small wishes, and they fell in the same direction like grass in a wind.

That was all it was. Nobody had been forced. People had been telling each other for a thousand years that it was not their business.

❦

The widows of the eleven policemen were written to, and paid, and the notices that came to the nine houses of Dhuwakot said, in the sweet cold language of the state, *presumed absent;* and in none of them did anyone read them aloud. The files that bore the dead men's names were sent to a store-room, and a flood in the monsoon of 2058 B.S. took the store-room, and by the time the clerks who had known the names retired, no one could have said what the files had been for.

The village sat up on Friday night.

They would tell it, afterwards, to each other and to no one else, in the dark of the long winter evenings, in low voices, with the door barred. They sat up with the lamps lit and the bar across the door and their sons on their laps, in the firelit houses on the second terrace and the third, and the old women said the Word as well as they remembered it, and the nine mothers, red-shawled, in the Mothers' Courtyard, set out the nine cold lamps on the platform at the pipal's foot and lit them with their own hands, shaking, in the dusk. Nobody came. The rope above the platform hung still. The pipal did not whisper. The night passed over Dhuwakot from the dark to the grey like any other, and at dawn on Saturday the cocks crowed in the lower wood, and nobody died.

It happened again on Saturday. And on Sunday.

By the end of the week the village understood that it had been spared. It did not understand why. The eldest mother was dead, or gone; Hajurama's body was never found; but the Word had been said, in some fashion, by someone, and the lamps had burned, and they chose to believe that the old woman had done a last brave thing in the dark, and that the Lord had taken her instead of the rest. It was the sort of thing that they could believe. They made it a story. They called it the Last

Gift, and the little children learned it at their mothers' knees; and they went on barring their doors.

They went on barring their doors for fifty years. There was never again a disappearance, nor a night of rope. The Lord had said that He would not trouble them, and He was a thing that kept His word; and the fear that He had left in the hill, like a coat on a hook, did His work for Him without His presence. The restricted order stayed on the books, and nobody remembered who had signed it. People came to the edge of the district to ask about Dhuwakot, and were told, by shopkeepers and conductors and tea-sellers and police, in the same vague and slightly weary voice, that it was a bad place, a place where nobody went; and when they asked why, the answer was a shrug, and a changing of the subject, and a kind of soft fog that came down over the faces of the people who were asked. A bus-driver on the Jyamire road would take his hat off at the turning, and could not have told you why. A child who misbehaved would be threatened with it. And Dhuwakot sat on its hill in its white mist, with its bars and its lamps and its swing, for fifty years, perfectly safe, perfectly feared, perfectly forgotten, and perfectly alone.

It was, as the Lord had said, the best fence He ever raised.

❦

They did not speak of it. They believed there was nothing to speak of. Every morning they woke and smiled and ate their rice, and every night they lay side by side in the room in Bhanjyang with Aama's red threads on the shelf, and slept, and slept well; and if Aashi sometimes woke at three in the morning with her hand pressed to the small flat place beneath her navel, and a taste of marigold in her mouth, and the sound of a rope in her ears, she told herself that it was the baby, and the stairs of the old house, and the heat.

She tried once to speak of the dream to Aama.

It was in the second week, on a Sunday, when Antim had gone to the bazaar. Aama had come in from the porch with her stick and stood in the door looking at her daughter-in-law with her small black eyes, and Aashi had felt a sudden sharp wish to tell her everything, a wish like thirst. She opened her mouth, and what she said was: "You are very good to us, Aama."

The old woman did not answer.

She looked for a long time at Aashi's right wrist, where the red thread she had tied was tight and clean. She came across the room, slowly, on her stick, and took the wrist in her wrinkled fingers; and the fingers were warm and dry, and they shook. She held it. She looked into Aashi's face, and the black eyes were very bright, and for a moment Aashi thought she would speak.

Then she let go. She stepped back, and a look went across her face that Aashi did not understand. She went to the shelf where the spools of thread lay in their saucer, and took a length of the red cotton, and a pinch of rice from the jar, and sat down in the corner of the kitchen with her back to the room; and Aashi heard her muttering, thinly, the long rough old charm that was only half a prayer, and saw the thin hands tying, and tying, and tying. It took her an hour. When she was done, she got up, and came across the floor, and tied a second thread on the wrist beside the first. It was grey. Aashi saw it, and did not understand. It had been red when it was tied.

"It will not hold," said Aama, in a very small dry voice, to the floor. "I know. I only wanted to have done it."

And she went out, and sat on the porch till dark.

❦

The boy was born in the month of Shrawan, in the rain, at the height of the monsoon, on a night so loud with water that the midwife could not hear herself speak. It was an easy birth. That frightened Aashi more than anything. She had braced herself for pain, for thirty hours of it, for a thing torn out of her in blood; and instead there was a long warm easy tide, and the midwife's hands, and a sudden slithering, and then a silence.

"A son," said the midwife. She was a stout old woman called Bimala, who had delivered half of Bhanjyang, and she was holding the child up to the lamp with her mouth a little open and her brow creased. "A fine boy. A good weight. But the cord was round his neck. Twice. I have never seen it so tight. Look. He is not even breathing."

He lay in her hands, wet and perfect, with his eyes shut, and round his neck, where the cord had been, ran a narrow livid line, as red as a thread. The room had gone entirely still. In the corner of it, on a stool,

Antim sat with his hands between his knees and his face the colour of paper.

Then the lamp-flame leaned.

It leaned toward the window, though the window was shut. A cold went through the room, a cold so total that the midwife's breath smoked, and the smell of marigold, thick, sweet, rotten, rose from the floor and the walls and the cot and the bed, from the hair of the woman on the pillow and the coat of the man on the stool. It rose, and gathered, and drew together as smoke draws together in a draught. And Aashi felt it leave her. She felt it go out of the small flat place beneath her navel where it had lain curled for seven months, like a hand unfolding from round a bird, and out of her spine, and her hands, and the whole warm trembling length of her; and at the same moment she saw Antim lift his head on the stool and gasp, as a man gasps who has been held under water. The window banged open. The rain came in. And over the roar of it, so low that none of them would ever be sure they had heard it, from the rafters or the doorway or the dark outside, came the creak of a rope, and a small, tender, delighted giggle, going away.

The baby coughed.

It was a thin wet cough, and then a gulp, and then a howl, a great furious outraged bellow that shook the lamp, and the midwife sat down heavily on the bed and said, "God be thanked." He was red and furious and perfectly well. He was breathing in great sobs. His fists beat in the air. And Aashi, holding him against her, wet and slippery and shouting, understood in one clear instant that she was alone in her body with another human being, for the first time in seven months, and that she had no idea why that sentence had come into her head.

"Subodh," she said. She was weeping. "Subodh. Subodh. Be well."

Over the rain, in the dark outside the open window, the rope creaked once more, a long way off, and went out over the hills.

The nightmare came back to them by degrees, as a tide returned to a beach.

It did not come all at once. It came in the autumn after the boy was weaned, when Aashi woke one morning with the words *none shall look* in her mouth and could not think where she had heard them; and again in the next spring, when Antim, sitting on the porch with the child on his knee, put out his hand to catch him up, and his face went suddenly, appallingly white, and he said to nobody: *I shot her.* It was a slow,

cruel, uneven returning, like feeling coming back into a limb that has been laid on. Piece by piece the dream ceased to be a dream. The hollow, the cradles, the chair; the long grey face with its one remaining eye; the old woman's hands folded on her breast. And at the end of it, on a night in the year 2054, the two of them lay in the dark of their room in Bhanjyang with the rain on the roof, and looked at each other, and understood that it had been real, every word, and that they had been walking about for four years inside a thing that had not been theirs.

They were not free. They had been spared the thing that frees: they had not been broken. They had been *used,* and set down again, whole, with their lives and their jobs and their son, and their silence. There was nothing wrong with them. There was nothing at all that a doctor could have found. And in the long years that followed, as the boy grew, and the Inspector General retired, and the file in the cabinet gathered dust, they learned the particular horror of those who have been the instrument of an evil and not the victim of it: that no one would ever believe them, and that they could not have borne it if they had. For what would they say? That they had lied in a report, and had not known? That they had walked a monster out of its cage, and shaken its hand?

Antim stopped counting. He had counted for forty years, all his life; and in the spring of 2054 he stopped, with a sudden clean absence, like a clock, and was never able to start again. He took to sitting on the porch with a cup of tea that went cold. He sat with the straw child on his knee. It had come home in his jacket, and he had never been able to throw it away, and now it hung above the child's cot, in its faded red rag, and its thin black braid swayed whenever a door was opened.

Aashi tried to burn it, once. She got as far as the stove.

You may, said nothing, kindly, in the grey light of the kitchen. It was only a memory of a voice, a faint sweet smell of marigold, an echo she would never now forget. *It is only straw. I have no need of it any longer.* And she stood with it in her hand, and understood that He meant it; that He had given it to Antim as a man gives a coin to a beggar, not out of love, but because it cost Him nothing; and that what He wanted, from the two of them, was already done.

She put it back above the cot.

❦

Subodh grew up kind.

That was the hardest thing. She had waited for something else, for a long dark flowering in him of everything she feared, and it did not come. He was a loud, healthy, laughing boy, with his father's long bones and her own quick temper, who brought home injured birds in his hat and wept at funerals and could not get to say anything unkind about a person to their face. He was the favourite of every teacher. The Lord was not in him. She was as certain of it as she was of her own name; she had felt Him go, on the night of the rain, as one feels a splinter leave a wound. The boy was only a boy. He had been the door, and a door is not a room, and the thing that had gone out through it had not stopped to leave a mark.

But on the day Subodh turned seven, a larger boy at the school gate pushed him down in the mud, once, twice, three times, and stood over him laughing; and Aashi, at the gate with a tiffin-box, saw the larger boy's face as it bent over her son's. It was a plain, freckled, ordinary face. For the length of a heartbeat the corners of the mouth were drawn up evenly and trembled at the edges, as if by a small patient hand; and there was, in the still air of that bright afternoon, the very faintest smell of marigold.

She dropped the tiffin-box. She was across the yard before she knew she had moved. When she reached the boys the larger one was crying and did not know why, and her son, wiping his face, was explaining to him with great seriousness that he did not mind.

She stood in the yard with a child in each hand and did not know what she had seen.

She knew later. It took her thirty years. The Lord had not gone to ground in any one person, as a snake goes to a hole. He had no body now to hide in, and needed none. He had let go of the Karkis, and the hill, and the rope, and had *thinned,* as smoke thins in a room when a window is opened, until He was not in any single person at all but a little in all of them, in the air between: in the pressure at the base of a throat, in the quickening of a pulse at a neighbour's good fortune, in the small cold click of a latch. Wherever a man looked at another and was suddenly sure that he had been wronged, there was a place for Him. He did not need to enter anyone. He needed only to be *felt.*

A rope for a son, she thought, in the night. *And a son for a rope.*

❦

He did not hang anyone.

That was the cunning of it, and it was a cunning she did not understand for years. He never again needed a rope, because the world had plenty of its own. There were bodies; she had been trained, in a lifetime of the police, to look for the body, and she found them by the dozen. But no one had been hanged by a thing in the dark. Each had been killed by a neighbour, a brother, a pupil, a friend, in daylight, by hand, for a perfectly ordinary reason; and the more of them she found, the less any of it could be proved.

It began with the small things. It always does. She would trace it afterward on the back of a school exercise book, in her old careful hand, trying to make a map of a sickness: a house in Bhanjyang, in the autumn of 2056, where two brothers who had sat at the same hearth for forty years fell out over a boundary wall and never spoke again; a shopkeeper in Jyamire who watched his neighbour's shutter go up an inch higher than his own, and lay awake with it, and cut his neighbour's rope. A woman at a wedding, who looked at another woman's bangles. A bright boy at a school who watched a duller boy given the prize. In each case there was a moment, a small cold moment like the click of a latch, in which a human being looked at another human being, and was suddenly and entirely *sure,* without evidence, that they had been wronged; and in each case, if one had looked closely enough, in the corner of the room, one would have found a faint sweet scent of marigold, and heard, if one held one's breath, from nowhere, the least creak of a rope.

It is envy, she wrote. *It begins with envy. It is the first knot, because it is the easiest to tie: you have only to look at what another has, and say that it was yours.*

And from envy comes the second, which is wrath. And from wrath, hatred. She stopped, and sat for a long time with the pen lifted. *And it cannot be seen. Whom should one arrest?*

❦

It went down the generations like water down a terrace.

It was in the wage-dispute at the mill, in 2063, when a quiet man who had never raised his voice took a spanner to his foreman in front of forty people and could not afterwards say why. It was in the long feast at the house of the district minister, in 2070, where a hundred and twenty guests ate and ate under a roof that was paid for by a road that was never built, and a man who had come hungry from the hills sat among them with his mouth full and a fierce soft light in his eyes; *gluttony,* she wrote, *not of food but of everything. The hunger that is not for the thing, but for the having of it, and the having more.* It was in the sister who sat at her dead mother's bedside counting spoons. It was in the young man who, because he had been laughed at in a classroom in 2068 for the way he spoke, rose to a great height thirty years later and laughed, in his turn, at a hundred thousand. It was in the preacher who preached patience, and the priest who preached peace, and in the pious quiet look that passed between them at a feast, each reckoning the other's following. It was in the two villages on either side of a river that had shared a well for four hundred years, and had a quarrel about a goat, and had by the end of a decade a wall, and by the end of two a grave.

Each thing, taken alone, was a local sorrow. That was what she could not make anyone see. There was never a day on which anything happened that could have been reported to a ministry as the work of one hand; there were only reports, in their thousands, each with its own reasonable cause. And between the reports there was, as the years passed, a gradual, steady, unremarked thickening of the air; a habit of looking sideways; a quickness to take offence, a slowness to forgive; the sense, in every house and every office and every market, that someone else had more, and was laughing about it. People grew careful. They grew guarded. They began to lock doors that had never been locked, in the daytime, in the sun, and to say that it was the times.

And in every case, on the outskirts of whatever it was, at the edge of the account, there hung a small thing that nobody noticed: a lock of hair, tied in a hard little knot, in the bush by the road; a red thread on a wrist; a rope in a field at dusk, swaying, with no wind.

Three pushes. It was in the schoolyards, as it was in the swing. *One, two, three,* and a laugh.

And there were the bodies.

Aashi kept a second book for them, a narrow red-backed ledger from the Bhanjyang bazaar, and she kept it as the police keep a register: date, place, cause, as the file had it. She did not write what she knew. She wrote what the files said. It took the sting out, a little, to write it in the dull language of the state.

Autumn 2058, Bhanjyang. Two other brothers; another boundary wall. The younger held the elder's face under the water of the irrigation channel until the bubbles stopped, and was found sitting on the bank with the elder's head in his lap, weeping and smiling. Cause: dispute over land. He asked the constable, politely, why he was crying. He did not know.

Monsoon 2061, Jyamire. A cousin's new tin roof. A tin of kerosene, a winter of patience, one night. Seven asleep beneath it, the youngest four months old. The man who lit it stood in the lane in the glare and was seen by the whole village to be smiling. Cause: fire, accidental. Nobody would sign for any other word.

Winter 2067, a schoolyard, at the prize-giving. Twenty boys, a set of cricket stumps, and a master who had marked one of them down. They said afterwards, one after another, that they had only pushed him. Once, they said. Only once. Cause: not stated.

Spring 2072, a market town on the plains road. A rumour that a child had been taken. By evening there were two hundred people and a lamp-post, and a stranger from the hills who had asked the way to a pharmacy. They found the child at dark, asleep in a granary. By then the crowd had gone home to its supper, and nobody could say who had begun it. Cause: persons unknown.

Winter 2091. A signature, in a glass tower, in the hand of a very reasonable man; and, at the end of a mountain road, a field. Eleven hundred. The papers called it a regrettable failure of roads. The man who signed it slept well. Afterwards he asked a clerk for a cup of tea, and was seen to look at it, tenderly, for a long time.

She kept the ledger for forty years. In every entry there was a thing the files did not record, and she wrote it in the margin, in a smaller hand: a smell of marigold; a lock of hair knotted hard in a bush by the road; a rope in a field at dusk, swaying with no wind. And in every one, when they took the man who had done it, and they always took him, for he never ran, he was found quite calm, and quite kind, and quite unable to say why; and the corners of his mouth were lifted, very evenly, as by a small patient hand.

Antim had stopped counting. Aashi began the week that he stopped. She made a mark in the margin for each, in fives, with a stroke through, as a prisoner marks a wall. She stopped at four hundred and eleven. It was the number of the stairs, and she could not bear to learn that the tally would pass it; and she knew, besides, that it was only what the files had let her find.

He had taken twenty-nine from a hill. He did not need a hill now.

❦

Antim died in the winter of 2088.

He died in his sleep, in a chair on the porch, at seventy-six, with the straw child in his lap and a cup of tea at his elbow, and his face was quiet and clear and perfectly smooth. They found him in the morning. His hand was still closed on the rag. She did not weep; she had wept for him, she supposed, in the first week of a December, forty years before, and found that there were no tears left in a person who has done it for so long. She sat by him for a long time in the thin sun. At the end, she took the straw child, gently, out of his fingers, and laid it in her own lap.

It was very light. It was a little warmer than it should have been.

"I am sorry," she said, to her husband, to the porch, to the morning. "I am so sorry. You were counting. You were counting and I did not help."

And she heard it, then, for the first time in thirty-four years: not a voice, but a very small contented sound, from somewhere in the air, like a child in a cradle turning over in its sleep.

Aashi lived another seven years. In that time she wrote, in a spidery hand, in an exercise book with a green cover, the whole of it: the bus, the lantern, the tree; the kinnar and the lamp; the hollow and the cradles; the old woman, and the gun. She wrote it twice, and burned the first. She wrote it with her face quite calm and her hand quite steady, as a woman writes a will. She wrote it for Subodh, and then she did not give it to him, because he was a good man, with three children, and a post in a school; and she did not want to take from him the one thing that she was sure was still entirely his.

At the end of the exercise book she wrote a last line. She wrote it in capitals.

THE TENTH BABY WAS NEVER STRAW.

She did not explain it. She had not known how.

❦

Dhuwakot, 2100 B.S.

The bus from Jyamire no longer stops at the turn.

It comes up the long road in the grey of the morning, when the fog is lifting from the valley, and it slows, as a matter of habit, at the place where the track goes off to the left between two black posts; and the driver, a young man with a good moustache and a mobile phone propped on the dashboard, looks the other way. The passengers look the other way. A child at a window, who has not been told, presses her nose to the glass and sees a white wall of mist on the hillside with a gate in it, and a long way up, a spot of yellow light, like a lantern; and her mother, without saying a word, reaches across and pulls the curtain.

Nobody has gone up to Dhuwakot in fifty years.

It is forbidden, by an order that nobody can trace and nobody has ever thought to question. The file is closed. The official gazetteer calls it *a hamlet of the old settlement type, now largely depopulated,* and the guidebooks, when they mention it at all, advise visitors that the road is unsafe; and if a traveller asks why, the shopkeeper's eyes go soft and far away, and he says that he cannot quite remember, and offers tea. There are rumours, of course. There are always rumours. They say that a hundred and sixty people live there still, behind doors that are barred from dusk until the first light; that the women are unusually long-lived; that on the night of Dashain, on the eleventh night of Aswin, at

Dashain, a small yellow light comes down the hill as far as the black gate, and waits there, and goes back up.

The pipal still stands. The rope still hangs from its lowest bough, a hundred fathoms of braided red, knotted from the top to the bottom with the hair of nine sons; and every dusk, in the square beneath it, an old woman in a white sari with a red border lights nine clay lamps on a platform of stone, and says a Word that has not been understood for generations, to a thing that is no longer there. She does not know. Nobody in the village knows. They sit up in their barred houses, with their sons on their laps, and listen to the mist, and are afraid of the dark, which is empty. They have been afraid for so long that it has become a kind of faith. They are the best-guarded village in the world. And inside the fence that He built for them, the hill goes on, in its white wool, keeping its nothing, while the thing that it was made to keep goes out and out and out into the world.

Beneath the hill, in the roots, in the dark, twenty-nine sleepers still lie in their cradles, policemen and fathers and sons, smiling; the Lord did not take them with Him, because a thing that is kept is a thing that cannot leave. One of them still holds a hand raised to his brow. They breathe, all night, in time, and nobody comes down the stairs to hear it.

At the gate, on a flat stone, a lantern burns. It has burned, in some fashion, every night for forty years, though no one has been seen to light it. A person of seventy-eight, they say, kept it up till death; a tall thin person with a scar on the forehead, in a long charcoal coat, who walked down every evening at dusk with the light, and set it on the stone, and stood a while with their back to the hill. They are buried in the lower wood, under no stone. On their wrist, they say, when the women laid them out, was a single red glass bangle, and in their hand a thread of red cotton tied in a knot of the sort that is used for tying up bundles of grass. No one in Dhuwakot knows what they meant by it. It went into the ground with them.

It has not been enough. It has not been nothing.

❦

The year is 2100, and the world has never been so full.

It has roads, and phones, and clean water in every house. It has more food than it can eat, and more than it can give away, and ten

thousand ways to say what one wishes to say to ten thousand strangers in a second. It has never in its history had so much to be grateful for. And on a Tuesday evening in the second week of Bhadra, in a flat in Kathmandu with a good view and a bad lock, a man of thirty-four sits at a table with the light of a small bright screen on his face, reading what a stranger has said about him, and feels, at the base of his throat, a small tight pressure, as of a thing put on that does not fit.

He does not know why he does it. He will not know, afterwards. He types a reply. It is clever, and it is cruel, and it will be seen by a million people by the morning, and it will be answered with another, and another, until a girl he has never met, in a town he has never heard of, takes down from a high shelf a length of cloth.

In the corner of his room, where the old calendar hangs, there is a faint sweet smell of marigold.

It is in the cheering of the crowd at a ground in the east when a man who has done nothing is thrown down. It is in the long table, in the long car, in the high glass tower with its lights on all night, where a very reasonable person says *just this once,* and *everyone does it,* and *they will never miss it,* and reaches. It is in the flattery, and the whisper, and the little lie that is not a lie. It is in the mother who looks at another woman's child. It is in the boy at the back of the class who sits very still and learns the faces of every one of those who are laughing. It is in the old man in the village by the river who has not spoken to his brother in forty years, and cannot tell you what it was.

It is in the way you feel when you hear that a friend has done well.

It is not a ghost. It is not a god. It is not hiding in a hill. The tree is only a tree, and the rope is only a rope; and the Hanging Lord of Dhuwakot has not been in Dhuwakot since the winter of 2050, when a woman with a son in her looked Him in the face and was kind. He went out through the door she opened, and He was not inside her, nor her husband, nor her child, for longer than the half year it took. When the boy was born He let go of them, and of all bodies, and went out into the rain and became everyone: thinned, and spread, and settled in the world like the damp in a wall. He is no longer a thing that lives in any one person. He is the feeling of a hundred million people. He has been about his business ever since, patient, courteous, unhurried, and everywhere, in the long slow work of making the world a very large and well-lit village, with its doors barred against itself.

He did what He said He would. He did not hang the world. He taught it to hang itself, a little, each day, in small ways, with a smile; and when the little ways were not enough, as in every generation they were not, there were always enough who felt the pressure at the throat, and obeyed.

In the files of every district there are dead who bear His mark, and nobody has ever laid the files side by side. If anyone did, they would find that the dead are past counting by any stair; that the same small held smile is in them all like a watermark, in the face of whoever is the last one standing in the lane, in the light of the fire. And in a ministry, on the sixth floor, there is a folder with a faded red cover and two signatures. That is what the clerks say. No one has been able to find it for forty years. It was moved in a flood, or burned in a fire, or mis-shelved in a move; and every man who has gone looking for it has found, after an hour, that his head ached, and that it did not much matter, and that the matter was surely one of those that had been put to bed. The case was never solved. It was never even remembered as closed, in the memory of any living person. It was forgotten, which is a finer way to end a thing, and which He had arranged with a single page.

Somewhere in Nepal, tonight, a man is lying awake with his eyes open, and counting. A woman is looking at her neighbour's lit window. A child is being pushed, once, and again, and then a third time, in a courtyard, by a crowd that is laughing. A girl of sixteen lies on her mat and listens to her father's breathing and does not sleep. Somewhere a bell is ringing, and a door is being barred.

We do not talk of the tenth, said the nine mothers, in the courtyard, and smiled.

They were right not to. There were nine knots, and nine sons, and a tenth bundle that was never a baby, and was never, in the end, only straw. It was the cradle that the Lord kept for the child that nobody held: the one carried off down the hill, the one pushed three times, the one at the edge of the firelight who looked on at somebody else's feast. It is the only cradle that has never been full, because it was made to fit anyone. It was made to fit you.

And the one who hangs in it is not a ghost, and not a monster, but a boy in a goat-skin, once, a long time ago, who learned to smile; and who has never, in all this time, been so well loved, so closely watched, or so sure of being obeyed.

He is among us still.

People still live in the world, where Jhundiyeko Prabhu lives inside them. Whenever something wrong, something evil happens, He remains, and smiles while his curse has done the task. The world where he lived among everyone, the world that he created full of hatred, now, is within the whispers of one. People in Nepal are still afraid of the tales of Jhundiyeko Prabhu. The fear keeps him alive, His presence grows the womb of mishappenings, and Prabhu, the word isn't always good in itself. Jhundiyeko Prabhu succeeded, and his curse is upon every street of Nepal.

He may be anyone. He may be the one who laughs, or the one who lies awake. He may be your neighbour; he may be your friend; he may be the thing you feel in the chest on the first night you cannot sleep for another's good fortune. He may not be a man at all. He may only be the soft sweet pressure at the base of the throat, the little cold click of a latch, the hand at the back of the neck that says: *you were wronged. You were left. You deserve it more than they.*

Listen.

If you are very quiet, and it is late, and the house has gone still, you may hear it. Far off, and gentle, and patient, from somewhere above the ceiling of the world, where the roots go down into the dark.

❦

End of Chapter Five

THE END

THE HANGING LORD

A Novel

A supernatural mystery thriller

SWAYAM SHAKYA

A SUPERNATURAL MYSTERY / THRILLER NOVEL

THE HANGING LORD

"Do not look at the one who hangs.
What hangs, also watches."

In Dhuwakot, the doors are barred before sunset, and nobody looks at the rope that moves without wind.

Eleven policemen went up the hill.
None came back.

Now a Superintendent and his wife arrive in disguise, carrying a lamp, a red thread, and one rule: *do not look.*

But something beneath the hill has waited two hundred years for someone who will.

Some knots should never be untied.

WRITTEN BY
SWAYAM SHAKYA